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Early Childhood

The Great Afternoon

Cartoons Are for Life: The Secret Password & The Afternoon Sanctuary

Date: 1994-05-18 at 15:30 America/New_York

3:30 PM — The Secret Password

Three polite, measured knocks sounded against the painted wood of my closed bedroom door just as the red digital clock on the cable converter box ticked to 3:29.

"Cartoons are for life," came Katie's voice through the wood, hushed and completely serious.

The secret password was given. Immediately, I scrambled up off the dark low-pile carpet of my deep-blue bedroom and swung the door open to admit my twin sister just in time for our favorite afternoon block of cartoons. Having just turned nine years old back on April eighth, neither of us cared what the other kids on our street in Virginia Beach were doing after the school bus dropped us off. School was six straight hours of scraping desks, unpredictable bells, and teachers who tried to seat fraternal twins on opposite sides of the hallway just because I was a boy and Katie was a girl. To the teachers at school and the adults in our extended family, I was Nathaniel, though Dad and Katie half the time just called me Nate; behind this door, I was simply the other half of Katie's perimeter.

Katie slipped inside, her long, straight platinum-blonde hair swinging past her shoulders as she pulled the door shut behind her until the latch clicked. We didn't need to explain to anyone else why we had a password for a room ten feet away from her own bedroom down the hall. Out in the rest of the house, the afternoon air was already heavy—Mom had locked her bedroom door at two o'clock with another headache and a glass from the kitchen cabinet, and Dad wouldn't be home from work until five-thirty to start dinner. Behind my closed door, however, the rules belonged entirely to the two of us.

I rushed back across the carpet and pressed the power button on the front of the television and the cable converter box just as the Majestic Studios castle logo and the afternoon cartoon block bumper flashed across the curved glass tube.

The opening brass fanfare of the *Galactic Samurai Geckos* theme song burst out of the small speaker grille, and instantly, both of us got completely carried away. Katie grabbed both of my hands, and for the next sixty seconds we bounced on the balls of our feet in the middle of the carpet, belting out every single word of the intro theme in unison while the animated title cards rolled across the screen.

Then, just as quickly, the final drumbeat of the opening theme faded out, the episode title card appeared, and the two of us were brought gently back to earth.

Without letting go of my hand, Katie dropped down onto the carpet right beside me, leaning her shoulder firmly against mine. I adjusted the volume knob down two notches so the dialogue wouldn't echo into the hallway, rested my back against the side of my bed frame, and let my sister's weight anchor me in place while the afternoon cartoons glowed across the quiet room.

Summer Camp at Virginia Dominion University

The Parallel Pair: Dominion Mall & The VDU Fieldhouse

Date: 1994-07-12 at 08:45 America/New_York

8:45 AM — Two Pairs on Dominion Mall

"All right, Youth Division, let's buddy up in two lines for the walk across Dominion Mall!" Counselor Brad announced over the splash of the circular concrete plaza fountain, tapping his wooden clipboard with a grin.

Standing on the wide, sun-bleached concrete plaza of Virginia Dominion University in Norfolk at eight-forty-five in the morning, wearing matching royal-blue VDU Summer Camp t-shirts over our shorts, Katie immediately tightened her fingers around my right wrist. When our dad, David Prairie, had signed the two of us up for this two-week, all-day camp block—running from nine o'clock in the morning until four o'clock in the afternoon—he had wanted to keep us safely out of the house in July while he was at work. Katie and I had our own rule for surviving six hours a day around fifteen noisy, unfamiliar kids: we were not letting go of each other.

Two paces ahead of us in the Youth Division line, I noticed we weren't the only brother and sister operating on that exact protocol.

A nine-year-old boy with reddish-blond hair and wire-rimmed glasses—whose name tag read *Michael*—and his seven-year-old sister *Rachel*, who had dark shoulder-length hair and glasses of her own, were standing hip-to-hip with their fingers laced together in a white-knuckled grip while their fourteen-year-old sister adjusted her backpack beside them before heading over to the Senior Division group. Just like Katie and me, Michael and Rachel didn't care about the cartoons or baseball cards the other campers were shouting about; they were holding onto each other like their lives depended on it.

Naturally, the two college-age counselors running our Youth Division—Counselor Brad and Counselor Kelly—looked at the four of us and reached the exact wrong conclusion.

"Look at this—we've got two brothers and two sisters right next to each other!" Brad called out brightly. "Let's mix it up today so the boys can hang out with the boys and the girls can hang out with the girls! Michael, step right back here and pair up with Nathaniel! And Rachel, you team up with Katie!"

Before I could protest, Brad guided me a step forward beside Michael, while Kelly gently steered Katie two steps back beside Rachel.

For four seconds, the counselors' geometry held.

I looked sideways at Michael through the thick Tidewater humidity. Michael looked sideways at me behind his wire-rimmed glasses. Neither of us had anything against the other—in fact, I could tell in half a heartbeat that his brain hated the sudden change in the line just as much as mine did. Behind us, Katie wasn't saying a word to Rachel, and Rachel wasn't saying a word to Katie; both of our sisters were staring straight at the backs of our blue camp shirts with their shoulders stiff and their jaws locked tight.

Michael and I didn't need to say a single word out loud. As soon as Counselor Brad turned his back and held his clipboard up in the air to lead the group across the light-gray concrete squares of Dominion Mall, Michael gave me a tiny, solemn nod, and I nodded right back.

I stepped half a pace to my left. Michael stepped half a pace to his right. In the exact same motion, Katie slipped forward to grab my hand again, and Rachel stepped right back into place on Michael's left flank.

By the time our sneakers clicked across the second concrete expansion joint past the circular fountain toward the precast-concrete and blue-glass facade of the University Library, the boy-and-girl experiment was completely over. It was brother and sister on the left, and twin brother and twin sister on the right.

9:30 AM — Terminal 4 and Terminal 5

At nine-thirty, the counselors ushered us out of the ninety-degree heat into the sixty-eight-degree air conditioning of the university computer lab.

Thirty beige desktop towers running *Quantum OS* and curved CRT monitors lined the walls, their cooling fans humming in a low, steady chord behind rows of mechanical *KeyMech* keyboards. I loved computers almost as much as I loved our afternoon cartoons, and Katie loved sitting beside me while we took turns with the mouse and keyboard.

Counselor Brad, however, still hadn't given up on his clipboard chart.

"Okay, campers, listen up!" Brad called out from the front desk, holding up a plastic tray of 3.5-inch floppy disks. "Boys on the left wall row—we've got *Wagon Train West* and *Where on the Map Is Scarlet Devereaux?* loaded up! Girls on the right wall row for *Digit Chompers* and *PixelPaint Junior*!"

Brad pointed Michael to Terminal 4 and guided me into the rolling plastic chair right next to him at Terminal 5. Across the blue carpet, Counselor Kelly led Rachel and Katie to Terminals 19 and 20 against the opposite wall.

The moment Katie's hand left my wrist, the hum of the computer lab stopped feeling calming and started feeling like a trap. Down the row to our left, a boy in a basketball cap was pounding his mechanical spacebar with both thumbs and yelling at the screen as his wagon sank in a river. I didn't touch my keyboard at Terminal 5. Instead, I twisted halfway around in my plastic chair and looked straight across the center aisle.

At Terminal 20, Katie was sitting completely motionless in front of the flashing five-by-five number grid of *Digit Chompers*, twisting the hem of her royal-blue camp shirt around her fingers while looking back across the carpet at me. Right beside her at Terminal 19, Rachel Ragsdale had pulled both hands off her desk and tucked her knuckles tightly against her chest.

Next to me at Terminal 4, Michael pushed his chair back six inches and looked at his sister. At the exact same moment, I tapped the open corner of my desk at Terminal 5 and motioned to Katie.

While Brad was kneeling beside the dot-matrix printer at the front of the room, Katie and Rachel slid off their chairs in perfect synchronization and walked three quiet steps side by side across the carpet.

Rachel squeezed onto the right half of Michael's seat at Terminal 4, and Katie pulled the empty rolling chair from the end of the row right up against my right side at Terminal 5, her long platinum-blonde hair brushing my sleeve as she exhaled a long, quiet breath of relief.

“Hey, girls, your computers are still running over on the right wall—” Counselor Kelly started, walking down the aisle before stopping short as she took in the two identical brother-and-sister teams sitting shoulder-to-shoulder at Terminals 4 and 5.

“She’s playing with me,” Michael told her quietly from Terminal 4, his left hand resting on the arrow keys while Rachel’s right thumb hovered over the spacebar for *Digit Chompers*. “I steer the square, and Rachel chomps the multiples. That’s how we play.”

I rested my left hand on the keyboard of Terminal 5 and placed Katie’s hand over the beige two-button mouse for *Wagon Train West*.

“Katie’s my twin,” I said, looking up at Kelly with quiet, unshakable certainty. “We always play together.”

Kelly looked from Michael and Rachel to Katie and me. Neither pair was making noise, neither pair was arguing, and the panicked stiffness had vanished from all four of us the second the sisters were back beside their brothers. Slowly, Kelly smiled, pulled an extra chair over for Rachel so both pairs had two seats pushed flush together, and jotted a quick note on her clipboard.

“Okay,” Kelly said gently. “Michael and Rachel on Terminal 4, Nathaniel and Katie on Terminal 5.”

For the next hour and a half, Katie and I guided our pixel wagon all the way across the western rivers without losing a single ox—trading turns with the mouse while Michael and Rachel cleared screen after screen of *Digit Chompers* two feet to our left.

1:30 PM — Pair 1 and Pair 2 at the Fieldhouse Pool

After eating our grilled cheese sandwiches side by side in the Monarch Commons dining hall at noon—just a few seats down from where Michael and Rachel’s fourteen-year-old sister Jessica used her written lunch exception on the camp roster to sit with them and quiz them on campus landmarks—our group walked down Hampton Boulevard to the VDU Fieldhouse.

The Fieldhouse was a massive brick athletic building where the Lady Admirals played women’s basketball during the school year while the men’s team played downtown under the concrete dome of the Norfolk Prism. Down the rubber-floored hallway, through the double doors of the Fieldhouse Natatorium, the indoor swimming pool echoed with splashing water and bouncing whistles.

As soon as I stepped out of the boys’ locker room in my swim trunks, Katie stepped out of the girls’ locker room door in her navy one-piece swimsuit, walked straight across the wet white tile, and grabbed my hand with both of hers. Right next to us on the bench, Rachel Ragsdale did the exact same thing with Michael.

Up on the deck beside the white plastic Buddy Board, Counselor Brad held up his thick black grease pencil and tried the gender split one last time.

“Every fifteen minutes when the lifeguard blows the long whistle and yells *Buddy Check*, you and your buddy have to find each other in the shallow end, grab hands, and hold them up in the air!” Brad called out over the echoing cavern. “Michael and Nathaniel, you guys are Pair Four! Rachel and Katie, you two are Pair Nine!”

Katie squeezed my fingers tightly as thirty kids splashed into the pool at once. I didn’t let go of her hand, and four feet to my left, Michael didn’t let go of Rachel’s. Together, both pairs walked down the wide fiberglass steps into the warm, three-foot shallow end along the side wall.

Two minutes later, the head lifeguard on the high white chair raised his silver whistle to his lips.

TWEEEEET!

“BUDDY CHECK!” the lifeguard shouted through his red megaphone. “Find your buddy and hands in the air!”

Out in the middle of the shallow end, kids who had been chasing each other in *Admirals and Anchors* pool tag splashed around in circles trying to remember who their assigned partner was.

Along the shallow wall, Katie’s left hand was already laced tightly through my right hand, and Rachel’s right hand was already laced tightly through Michael’s left. Before the whistle had even stopped echoing off the steel roof trusses of the Fieldhouse, all four of us raised our joined hands straight into the air above the water.

Up on the deck, Counselor Brad stared at our two pairs of raised brother-and-sister hands, looked at Counselor Kelly laughing softly behind her clipboard, and finally surrendered. Wiping his rag across the grease pencil on the white plastic board, Brad wrote two new permanent assignments at the very top of the list:

PAIR 1: MICHAEL + RACHEL PAIR 2: NATHANIEL + KATIE

Katie looked at me as we lowered our arms back into the warm water, a bright, triumphant smile breaking across her face, and across the lane Michael and Rachel shared the exact same quiet grin. For the rest of the two-week camp block—from the morning walk across Dominion Mall to afternoon *Four-in-a-Row Grid* and *Wild Draw* cards in the Fieldhouse multipurpose room—nobody at Virginia Dominion University ever tried to separate either pair of siblings again.

Big Family Christmas

The Newport News ARTS Train & The Downstairs Sofa Bed

Date: 1994-12-23 at 18:15 America/New_York

6:15 PM — The Newport News ARTS Platform

The evening train pulled into the brick ARTS—American Rail Transit Service—station in Newport News with a long hiss of air brakes and a cloud of white steam rising into the cold December air.

Up on the concrete platform, Katie and I stood side by side in our winter coats with our hands tucked into our pockets, watching the stainless-steel ARTS passenger doors slide open. Moments later, Grandma, our Aunt Elizabeth, and our twelve-year-old cousin Chelsea—Aunt Liz's developmentally disabled daughter, who was three years older than us—stepped down onto the platform carrying their holiday suitcases, and the whole family crowded together to exchange hugs and greetings.

True to form, before we had even walked ten feet past the station canopy toward the parking lot, Aunt Elizabeth wasted no time digging into her coat pocket and lighting up a cigarette.

Beside us, Chelsea immediately scowled and angrily plugged her nose with two fingers.

"Mom, that's gross," Chelsea stammered, waving a hand in front of her face as all of us were forced to stand on the cold curb waiting before we could load into the vehicles.

"Liz, put that out," our dad snapped, his breath fogging in the December chill as he hefted two suitcases into the trunk of our Holt sedan. "You know damn well that's not good for you!"

"Alright, alright," Aunt Liz snapped back, stubbing the cigarette out on the heel of her boot as we sorted ourselves into the two vehicles for the drive back across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

Chelsea climbed into the middle of the back bench seat of the Holt sedan right between Katie and me, while Dad and Aunt Liz sat up front. Behind us, Mom—who was having a rare sober evening so Grandma wouldn't ask questions at the ARTS station—drove Grandma in the pickup truck following our taillights down Interstate 64.

As soon as our sedan cleared the tunnel and turned onto the familiar streets of Virginia Beach, Katie leaned forward slightly to look across Chelsea at me, her eyes bright with holiday excitement.

"Welcome to Virginia Beach!" Katie squealed happily, squeezing Chelsea's mittened hand. "Now, the three of us are going to have to squeeze into one room!"

8:00 PM — Downstairs Sanctuary

When we pulled into the driveway at home, Katie, Chelsea, and I pitched in right away to help Grandma and Aunt Liz carry their overnight bags through the front door.

Standing at the foot of the stairs in the foyer, Dad laid out the holiday room assignments.

“You three will share the sofa bed,” Dad said to us kids, gesturing toward the living room. Turning to the adults, he added, “Mom, Katie’s room is closer to the upstairs bathroom. Liz, you get Nathaniel’s room.”

In a lot of houses, getting evicted from both of our upstairs bedrooms for the holidays would have felt like a punishment. To Katie and me, however, Dad had just handed us the greatest logistical gift of Christmas. With Grandma in Katie’s room, Aunt Liz in my room, and Mom and Dad behind their closed door at the end of the upstairs hall, all four adults were confined to the second floor—which meant the entire first floor belonged exclusively to the three of us kids.

“Chelsea, there’s a bathroom down here we can use,” Katie explained immediately, pointing down the short hallway off the living room. “It has a shower. We can stay downstairs while the adults are upstairs.”

“Okay,” our cousin replied, setting her backpack by the couch. “Where do we sleep?”

“The three of us will sleep down here. This sofa is a sofa bed,” Katie replied proudly as the three of us finished carrying the last of the adults’ bags up the stairs.

Because the train had arrived late in the evening, dinner was fast and simple—warm bowls of soup and buttered rolls around the dining table—and before nine o’clock, the adults retreated upstairs for the night, leaving the first floor completely to the three of us.

“I want to take a shower,” Chelsea announced to Katie and me once the upstairs footsteps quieted down.

Katie walked her down the short hall to show her how to turn the downstairs shower faucet on and where the clean towels were stacked, then came back out into the living room where I had already changed into my long-sleeved flannel pajamas and was busy pulling the heavy metal frame of the sofa bed out from inside the couch. Working together, Katie and I unfolded the mattress, smoothed out the clean cotton sheets, and spread two thick winter quilts across the top.

A few minutes later, the bathroom door clicked open. Instead of putting her pajamas on inside the bathroom, Chelsea wandered straight out into the living room wrapped only in a bath towel, making her way casually toward the sofa bed Katie and I had just finished setting up.

“CHELSEA!” Katie stammered, her hand shooting out in a flash to clamp firmly over my eyes. “Your cousin shouldn’t be seeing all of you!”

Before Chelsea could even blink, Katie spun her right back around by the shoulders and shunted her straight back into the downstairs bathroom to finish drying off and put her flannel pajamas on properly.

“You need to stop blushing,” my twin sister admonished me once the bathroom door clicked shut behind Chelsea—except she didn’t truly admonish me at all, letting out a quiet, bubbly giggle as she took her hand off my face. “You promise not to tell anyone?”

“Promise,” I replied, rubbing the bridge of my nose as we both climbed onto the left side of the wide sofa bed in our flannel pajamas and pulled the heavy winter quilt up to our chins.

“You know Chelsea sometimes forgets the rules when she’s in a different house,” Katie whispered, leaning her head against my shoulder underneath the quilt and lacing her fingers through mine. “As long as we look out for each other down here, nobody upstairs is going to yell at anyone.”

“Not a word to anyone,” I whispered back, squeezing her hand.

Two minutes later, Chelsea came back out of the hallway wearing her full green flannel pajamas, fuzzy socks, and a sheepish grin, and climbed under the quilt on the far side of the sofa bed. With the living room lamp clicked off and only the colored lights of the Christmas tree glowing softly in the corner, Katie stayed tucked right against my side—the two of us holding down our downstairs sanctuary while the winter wind rattled the front windows.

Middle School & The Blizzard of ’96

The Blizzard of ’96

Snow Day in Virginia Beach & The Backyard Promise

Date: 1996-01-06 at 11:30 America/New_York

11:30 AM — Waiting for the First Flakes

“You think we’re going to have snow?” Katie asked, her breath fogging a small circle on the cold glass pane as the two of us stood shoulder to shoulder at my upstairs bedroom window.

“Hope so. SNOW DAY!” I said, practically vibrating with excitement as I pressed my palms against the wooden sill and looked out at our residential street in Virginia Beach.

Outside on the first Saturday of January 1996, it was bitterly cold, and heavy, slate-gray clouds were rolling in off the Atlantic until the sky looked like brushed steel. Behind us on my bedroom stand, the local Norfolk GBS news station had cut into regular Saturday morning programming, the meteorologist standing in front of a swirling radar map warning all of Hampton Roads to prepare for the Blizzard of ’96. Even on a Saturday, a real blizzard meant Monday and Tuesday would be wiped clean off the school calendar.

“Snow,” Katie replied hopefully, leaning her shoulder against mine as the news anchor continued to drone on and on about wind gusts, coastal flooding, and how many inches were expected later in the afternoon. Both of us were thrilled at the thought of the whole neighborhood shutting down.

At twelve-thirty, while Katie and I were sitting side by side at the kitchen table eating our lunch sandwiches, the first white flakes began to drift past the dining room window. At first it wasn't much—just fine, powdery crystals swirling across the dry grass—but within twenty minutes the flakes grew thick and steady, dusting the wooden fence rails and the roof of Dad's car.

"Wonder if it will stick," Katie giggled, pointing her finger toward the patio.

By late afternoon, it didn't just stick; it buried the entire backyard under a clean, silent blanket of white.

Inside the house, however, the quiet didn't last. Around five o'clock, the familiar, sharp sound of Mom's and Dad's voices started rising from the upstairs hallway—first a slammed cabinet door, then the bitter, overlapping shouting match that always followed whenever Dad found another empty bottle hidden behind the pantry cans.

5:45 PM — The Backyard Bear Hug

Katie and I didn't wait for the yelling to reach the staircase. We pulled on our heavy winter jackets and boots and slipped out the back door into the twilight snow.

Out in the backyard, inside the perimeter of our white wooden picket fence, the falling snow acted like a giant acoustic blanket over the neighborhood. The streetlamps glowed pale orange through the swirling flakes, and every footstep made a soft, muted crunch under our shoes.

Standing near the center of the yard with the snow settling onto my short blonde hair, the cold wind hit my face, and all at once the weight of everything we had been carrying over the past year caught up with me. My chest tightened, and before I could stop myself, I started sniffling in the cold air.

Katie turned around immediately. She didn't hesitate for a second—she stepped straight through the snow and pulled me into a tight, fierce bear hug, wrapping both of her blue-jacketed arms around my shoulders.

"What's wrong?" Katie asked softly against my ear, holding onto me with all her strength.

"I'm just so happy you're willing to do all of this for me," I whispered into her shoulder, my voice shaking slightly as I held onto the back of her winter coat, unsure of how to put the rest of the knot in my chest into words.

Katie didn't need me to explain it. Because she was my twin, she already knew the exact two things crushing my ribs.

"You're still upset with last year, and that girl everyone thought you had a crush on?" Katie asked gently.

"Yes, I am," I whimpered, burying my face against her collar, overwhelmingly grateful that my twin sister was hugging me instead of telling me to toughen up. All through the previous spring at school, a pack of kids in our grade had latched onto a rumor that I had a crush on a girl in our homeroom, turning every hallway change

and cafeteria period into a relentless, mocking gauntlet that wouldn't stop no matter what I said. "And it does not help that Mom and Dad are arguing with each other again. I just want to enjoy the snow without the screaming."

"I'm right here, and I will never leave you," Katie replied fiercely, pulling me into an even tighter bear hug as the heavy January snow came down all around us in the twilight. "I'm your sister, and I would just never, ever leave you."

She held onto me for a long moment in the quiet yard, letting the steady pressure of her arms slow my breathing down, before she spoke again.

"Your classmates are mean," Katie continued, her voice firm against the cold wind. "Especially when they refuse to back down. When we go back to school, I will gladly play my part of pretend girlfriend so they leave you alone."

"Thank you, but I think everyone knows that you're my sister," I whispered, managing a small, shaky laugh even as my teeth started chattering from the twenty-degree air.

"Come on, let's head back inside before we freeze," Katie said, taking my hand and leading me back across the snow-covered grass toward the back door.

Inside the warm kitchen, the shouting upstairs had finally stopped—Mom had gone to bed for the night, and the house was still again. Standing beside the dark green laminate counter with the snow piling up against the dining room window glass behind us, Katie wrapped her arms around my neck for one more long, warming hug until the chill left my fingers.

"Let's use my bed tonight," I whispered as we started walking up the stairs together. "This way we can see the street from my window when we wake up in the morning."

"Sure," Katie smiled. "I hope we wake up to snow on the ground like there is right now."

At the top of the landing, I paused outside my bedroom door and looked at her. "Real quick, if you're going to spend the night with me: what should we do about getting changed?"

"I'll go change into my warm pajamas in my room and grab my pillow, and I'll knock when I'm ready," Katie whispered with a practical nod.

Three minutes later, after I had pulled on my own heavy winter flannel pajamas and climbed under the covers by the window, three quiet knocks sounded against my door.

"Cartoons are for life," Katie whispered from the hall.

"Come on in," I whispered back.

Carrying her pillow under her arm in her purple fleece pajamas, Katie crossed the carpet and climbed under the heavy blanket right at my side. Outside my bedroom window, the Blizzard of '96 howled silently across Virginia Beach, piling deep drifts against the curb under the glow of the streetlamp, while inside the warm perimeter of my bed, my twin sister and I fell fast asleep holding hands.

Katie Is Dumped

No More Fighting & The Dinner Dance Promise

Date: 1997-10-16 at 16:15 America/New_York

4:15 PM — Tears Under the Blue Butterfly

“Leave me alone! You’d never understand,” Katie sobbed, turning her head half away as I pushed her bedroom door open and stepped onto the carpet.

I had just walked up the stairs after seventh grade when I heard the sound echoing right through her hollow wooden door into the upstairs hallway. Katie was standing near the foot of her bed against the bright magenta-purple wall beneath her framed blue morpho butterfly print, crying up a storm with her shoulders shaking inside her dark navy t-shirt and both hands pressed over her face.

For the first month of middle school—while I spent my afternoons quiet in my blue bedroom with my *Nova 64* video games and Katie tried her hardest to fit in with the girls from her English class and a seventh-grade boy named Donnie—the stress of the loud hallways and Mom’s worsening drinking at home had pushed the two of us into the stupid habit of bickering whenever we passed each other in the hall.

Hearing the ragged sound of her crying, I dropped every trace of that irritation at the door. Stepping quietly across her room, I placed my hand gently on her shoulder.

“What is it?” I asked softly.

Katie continued sobbing for several seconds, her chest heaving as she tried to catch her breath. I realized immediately that this wasn’t a small hallway argument—this was serious. It took her a long moment to realize that I wasn’t going to tease her or make fun of her for crying.

Slowly, she lowered her hands from her tear-streaked face.

“Donnie dumped me,” Katie choked out, fresh tears spilling down her cheeks. “I loved him, and he dumped me!”

I reached my hand out to gently wipe the tears from her eyes. Never having had a girlfriend myself—and never having been dumped—I didn’t fully understand the mechanics of middle-school romance, but I didn’t need to understand romance to see how badly my twin sister was hurting.

Katie reached out with both hands and took mine, holding onto my fingers tightly as if she were drowning and I was the only solid ground in the room.

“Please… don’t let go,” she whispered, her voice raw.

I closed both of my hands around hers and held on firmly. Looking straight into my eyes with a sudden, desperate seriousness, Katie asked the question that mattered most to survival in a middle-school cafeteria:

“Will you sit with me at lunch?”

The look on Katie's upset face told me the only answer she needed to hear—and it was the exact answer I wanted to give her anyway.

"Yes," I answered without hesitation. "I'll sit with you at lunch."

Katie burst into fresh tears of pure relief, letting go of my fingers only to throw both arms around my neck and pull me into a tight hug.

"Thank you," she whispered against my shoulder.

I could hear how raspy and sore her throat was from all of her crying, so I offered to run downstairs and get her a cold glass of water, but she shook her head and held onto my shirt even tighter. As I wrapped my arms around her waist and hugged her back in the quiet room, I felt something shift permanently inside my chest. All the petty squabbling we had done over the past few weeks felt completely, utterly stupid. Katie didn't want to stop hugging me, and I didn't have a single problem with that.

"Please, no more fighting," my sister sobbed softly into my shoulder.

"I understand," I promised, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair as we continued to hold onto each other.

"I'm still upset, but thanks for this," Katie murmured a minute later as I felt a few more warm tears soak into the shoulder of my maroon t-shirt.

"Katie, I'm here for you," I told her. And as I said the words out loud, squeezing my arms around my twin sister, I realized just how much more I loved hugging her and keeping her safe than arguing with her.

5:00 PM — The Pretend Date & PB&J Sanctuary

When her crying finally began to subside, the two of us sat down side by side on the edge of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread, our shoulders pressed together and our hands still linked.

"Thank you," Katie said quietly, wiping her eyes with the back of her wrist. "Thank you for being there for me. Someday, I know I'm going to repay this."

She went quiet for a beat, looking down at our joined hands, before she suddenly whispered:

"Take me to the Dinner Dance this week."

The seventh-grade Dinner Dance was tomorrow night in the school cafeteria, and half the reason Katie had been crying so hard was the thought of either staying home alone in embarrassment or walking into that room by herself while Donnie was there.

"Of course we can go together," I said immediately, knowing I didn't have a date of my own—and wouldn't have wanted to go with anyone else even if I did. "Even though you're my sister, we will go on a pretend date."

“Oh, thank you. Thank you,” Katie breathed, the last of the heavy sobs finally leaving her chest as she leaned her head against my shoulder.

“Would you like it if I made you dinner tonight?” I asked, deciding right then and there to start playing my part as her protective pretend boyfriend.

“Let’s just have something simple, like sandwiches,” she said softly.

“Alright,” I replied, giving her hand a gentle squeeze as the two of us stood up and headed downstairs together.

In the quiet kitchen, I made us both thick peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwiches and poured two tall glasses of cold milk to soothe her sore throat. After we finished eating at the table, Katie looked across at me.

“Could we watch a movie together?” she asked.

“Sure,” I replied warmly. “Let’s pick something together.”

We walked back upstairs to my deep-blue bedroom, picked out our VHS tape of *House Guard 2: Lost in Manhattan* from the shelf beneath my television stand, and pushed it into the VCR. As the opening Majestic Studios credits began to roll across the CRT screen, Katie kicked off her shoes and climbed into my single bed right at my side, resting her head on my shoulder and pulling the blanket across our legs.

Near the end of the movie, when the closing music faded in, I glanced down and saw that my sister was fast asleep against my arm, her breathing slow and completely peaceful after an afternoon of crying her eyes out.

I reached carefully for the remote, clicked the television off, and decided right then to let her sleep. I decided that I would tell her that I didn’t mind after we woke up in the morning. Katie was exhausted, and the last thing I wanted was to see her become a grouch because she was woken back up without enough sleep. Part of me marveled at how natural it felt sharing my narrow bed with my twin sister again—just like we had during the Blizzard of ’96 and on the downstairs sofa bed at Christmas. We had chosen this close brother-and-sister bond together, and enjoying the warm, quiet company of the person who mattered most to me in the world, I slid down onto the pillow beside her and let myself drift off to sleep at her side.

The Pretend Boyfriend & Twins’ Day

Twin Brothers Always Stay: Spirit Week & The Living Room Sofa

Date: 1997-10-17 at 07:30 America/New_York

7:30 AM — “Twin Brothers Always Stay”

The next morning, when the pale autumn sunlight filtered through the blinds of my bedroom, I woke up first—and sure enough, Katie was still fast asleep right at my side in the small bed.

“Katie,” I whispered softly, gently prodding her shoulder so I wouldn’t startle her in case she didn’t realize right away that she had fallen asleep in my room the night before.

My sister stirred against the pillow, blinking her blue eyes open in the quiet blue room before looking from the wall to me in mild surprise.

“Morning, sleepyhead,” I whispered with a small smile.

“I slept in your bed?” she asked groggily, rubbing her eyes.

“Yep, and I did not mind,” I replied, looking her straight in the eye. “Let’s play a game together.”

For the first time since Donnie had broken her heart yesterday afternoon, Katie’s face lit up with genuine excitement. While she sat up against the headboard, I slipped out of bed, walked across the carpet to the television stand, and powered on my *Nova 64* video game console. I was still in full protective-brother mode, determined to keep cheering her up until I heard her laugh again.

Before I picked up the controller, I turned back to face her.

“I’m your brother. I will always be here for you. Promise,” I told her, my voice steady and earnest in the quiet room. I paused for half a beat, then added the truth I knew we would live by for the rest of our lives: “Boyfriends come and go, but Twin Brothers always stay. Always.”

Before the console title screen had even finished loading on the CRT television, I found myself wrapped in Katie’s arms again. She stood up from the edge of the mattress and hugged me with everything she had, making it unmistakably clear that she had no intention of letting go of me. She held onto my shoulders while the video game rolled through its opening demo sequence on the screen behind us, then sat down on the carpet right at my side.

“We should probably get dressed,” Katie said after a moment, glancing down at her wrinkled shirt from yesterday. “Guess I will pop into my room real quick. Leave the game on this screen while we get dressed?”

“Sure,” I replied, gently ushering her to the bedroom door. “I’ll open my door when I’m dressed.”

8:00 AM — Spirit Week: Twins’ Day

Five minutes later, after I had pulled on a clean maroon short-sleeve t-shirt, medium-wash blue jeans, and my tan sneakers, I opened my bedroom door. Katie walked right back in from across the hall—and the second I saw what she had picked out of her closet, I had to grin.

Without planning it, she had put on the exact same shade of maroon short-sleeve t-shirt and medium-wash blue jeans with a dark belt.

“Next week is Spirit Week at school,” I said as she stepped into the room. “Want to have a little fun on Twins’ Day, since, well, we *are* twins?”

Katie giggled as I handed her the second black controller from the floor stand. “Yeah, we are twins! Wonder how many others will really be twins compared to how many will do it just for fun.”

We both laughed out loud at that remark, and right there in front of my computer desk and television stand, we stubbornly made up our minds.

“I think it’s settled, then,” I declared. “We will dress exactly the same, and we will enter the contest.”

We laughed again, already looking forward to seeing how the teachers and our classmates would react to actual fraternal twins walking into the Spirit Week Twins’ Day assembly dressed identically and holding hands.

“Too bad we don’t have matching shoes,” Katie remarked, looking down at her grey-and-red sneakers next to my tan ones.

“Ah, well. Still, let’s do what we can. I think these pants and shirts look close enough,” I said, setting the controllers on the desk and pulling her into another tight, standing hug in the middle of the room. Both of us laughed into each other’s shoulders, our matching maroon sleeves wrapped around each other’s backs. Yesterday’s tears were completely gone.

5:30 PM — Macaroni & Cheese on the Living Room Sofa

Later that evening, after spending the afternoon practicing our co-op levels and getting ready for the weekend, Katie and I walked downstairs and decided to sit together on the tan-brown living room sofa, curling up side by side while we waited for dinner to be made.

As usual in our house, Dad was in the kitchen working over the stove after a full day at his job, while upstairs Mom was already passed out drunk in bed behind her closed door.

“Mac and cheese is what I smell,” I whispered as Katie slid flush against my right side on the sofa cushions, draped her left arm warmly around my shoulders, and rested her right hand across my forearm to hold me close to her.

“Our favorite,” she replied softly, resting her cheek near my shoulder as the two of us sat there, happily snuggled up together beneath the blue-framed underwater painting on the living room wall.

We had a few quiet minutes to ourselves before the timer on the stove went off, and neither of us wanted to get off the sofa. After years of feeling like we had to keep our guard up against loud classrooms and the unpredictable storms upstairs, snuggling together on the couch felt like the safest, most comfortable place on earth.

As we sat there in the warm glow of the living room lamp, Katie whispered, “Snuggling up is just so comfortable.”

“It is,” I replied quietly, leaning into the warmth of her arm around my shoulders. Neither of us moved an inch; we were both completely content holding onto each other and letting the rest of the house fade away.

A few minutes later, Dad stepped to the doorway of the dining room with a pot holder in his hand, looking over at the two of us curled up together on the couch before calling us in to eat.

When we sat down side by side at the dining table over our steaming bowls of macaroni and cheese, Dad looked across the table at the two of us, his tired eyes softening with genuine gratitude.

“I really appreciate that you both don’t fight and argue with each other,” Dad said quietly, his voice heavy with emotion. “Honestly, I wish your mother didn’t drink her life away. I want to do my best to not only be your father, but also be a proper dad to both of you. Your mother’s drinking is not your fault, and I don’t want either of you to think that. Please don’t let your grades suffer because of it.”

Underneath the edge of the dining table, Katie reached her hand over and laced her fingers tightly through mine, and I squeezed right back. Whatever happened upstairs, and whatever happened in the hallways at school, my twin sister and I had our sanctuary—and we were never letting go.

Sixteen & Summer Sanctuary

Bonding With My Sister

Summer Sanctuary: Hearthstone Pizza, The Sunlit Valley, & Katie’s Room

Date: 2001-06-18 at 08:30 America/New_York

8:30 AM — First Full Day of Summer

“Summer is here,” I said, blinking open my eyes as the warm June sunlight filtered through the blinds of Katie’s bedroom.

“Our first full day with the house to ourselves,” my sister replied softly as we started waking up.

Having both turned sixteen back on April eighth, the two of us were curled up side by side in our pajamas on top of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread beneath the framed blue morpho butterfly artwork hanging on her magenta-purple wall, completely used to being pretend dates and full-time anchors for each other. With both of our parents already gone for their morning shifts and two quiet weeks stretching ahead of us before Summer School started, the entire house was finally calm.

Katie rubbed her eyes, then looked over at me and asked, “Get dressed and have breakfast?”

“Sure, I am getting hungry,” I replied, giving her hand a quick squeeze as I climbed out of bed.

I stepped across the upstairs hallway into my own deep-blue painted bedroom to pull on a clean maroon crew-neck t-shirt and jeans while Katie changed in her room, and two minutes later we met right back at her doorway, exchanging a warm, familiar smile before making our way down the stairs together.

“Let’s just have some cereal, then we will figure out what we want to do for the day,” I said as we reached the bottom landing. “I want to spend the day with just you.”

Our stomachs were calling us, as was our daily routine of taking our morning dose of medication before the day got underway. In the quiet kitchen, I pulled two ceramic bowls out from the cupboard and set our morning medication tablets beside two glasses of water while we picked out our cereal from the pantry—being twins, of course it was the exact same box—and sat down at the kitchen table, pulling our chairs right up against each other so we were as close as possible.

After we took our morning medication and started on our cereal, my twin sister reached across the table, took my hand, and looked straight into my eyes.

“What would you like to do today?” Katie asked.

“I was thinking of snuggling on the sofa over a movie,” I suggested as we continued eating our breakfast side by side.

“I know just the movie I want to watch,” my sister said, squeezing my hand. She gave me that unmistakable look like she had a big secret and started giggling. She wanted me to ask what movie it was, but after sixteen years as her twin brother, I knew she wouldn’t tell me—I would have to wait and see what it was when she popped the tape into the VCR.

Since I had made breakfast, Katie took it upon herself to carry our bowls and spoons over to the counter and load our dishes into the dishwasher.

“I will get the tape, then will join you on the sofa,” Katie called over her shoulder as I headed toward the living room.

“Alright, Katie,” I replied, settling onto the cushions of our tan-brown living room sofa beside the coffee table, where Dad had neatly stacked the slightly outdated *Quantum Basic 5.0* programming textbooks—complete with clear plastic mylar covers and barcode stickers on the spines—that he had checked out from the Virginia Beach Public Library to get a head start on his upcoming fall *Quantum Basic 6.0* class at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR. Over the past few weeks, Katie had started reading Dad’s library books cover to cover and teaching the programming exercises to me, and when Dad found out, he had beamed with pride and actively encouraged both of us to keep coding.

Even better, when Summer School started in two weeks, Katie and I weren’t going because we were behind. We had intentionally signed up to knock out an academic credit over the summer so that when our main high-school year started in September, our schedules would line up with a free period and lunch block together every single day. Until those summer classes began, I was looking forward to having unbroken time with my twin sister.

9:30 AM — *Hearthstone Pizza & Journey to the Sunlit Valley*

A minute later, Katie walked into the living room holding a familiar white clamshell VHS tape behind her back, slid the cassette into the VCR beneath the television, and walked over to sit on the sofa right next to me.

Immediately, she lifted her arm and made it clear she wanted me to snuggle up in her arms. I slid flush against her side and rested my head against her shoulder, glad that I got to curl up with Katie now that the two of us had become so close.

Across the room, the CRT television flickered to life. My eyes lit up as the sweeping orchestral welcome theme to one of our favorite companies—*Majestic Studios*—played across the screen, and then my eyes lit up even further as the previews transitioned and I recognized the exact childhood VHS movie that my sister had put on for us: *Journey to the Sunlit Valley*.

“I knew you would like it,” Katie whispered, resting her cheek against my hair as she looked down into my eyes.

“Of course,” I whispered back with a grin as the tape rolled through its iconic opening bumper before the feature presentation—the familiar, upbeat birthday party commercial from *Hearthstone Pizza* where the older brother was supposed to be nice to the little girl.

We happily stayed curled up together on the cushions as Sprout and his friends began their journey across the screen, wanting nothing more than to sit there quietly in each other’s arms watching the movie. Both of our parents were away at work, the house was completely peaceful, and we had decided that all we wanted was each other—just brother-and-sister time together in our sanctuary before Summer School was set to begin.

9:00 PM — Katie’s Room Beneath the Blue Butterfly

By the time evening rolled around and the June twilight faded outside the living room windows, we had spent the entire day side by side without a single argument, a single raised voice, or a single interruption from the outside world.

As we walked up the stairs together after dinner and paused on the second-floor landing between my blue-painted bedroom and her magenta-purple bedroom, Katie turned to me and took my hand.

“Share a bed?” Katie asked softly.

“Sure,” I replied without hesitation. “Your room or mine?”

“How about my room tonight,” Katie suggested with a gentle smile.

After I stepped into my blue room to brush my teeth and change into a comfortable t-shirt and flannel pajama pants, I crossed the hall and knocked lightly on Katie’s door. Inside her room, under the warm amber glow of the bedside lamp and the framed blue morpho butterfly on her wall, we climbed onto her bed together, propped our pillows against the headboard, and pulled the green-and-gold covers

across our legs. Katie draped her arm around my shoulders and laced her fingers through mine, and as the house settled into quiet around us, we drifted off to sleep side by side.

End of Summer Cruise

Part 1: The I-95 Haul, The Quantum Basic Library Book, & Ditching Captain Barnaby

Date: 2001-08-19 at 09:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 18, 2001 — The Twelve-Hour Grumble Down I-95

"If *Command1_Click* calls the subroutine before the text box validates, the whole form throws a type-mismatch error," Katie murmured beside me in the back seat of our Holt sedan, tapping her finger against page 142 of the thick paperback resting across our knees as another green Florida mileage sign flashed past the window on Interstate 95 South.

"That's only in *Quantum Basic 5.0*," our dad, David Prairie, called back from the driver's seat, his eyes flicking warmly to the rearview mirror despite the fatigue of ten straight hours behind the wheel. "Wait until we test it on the *Quantum Basic 6.0* compiler at the CCHR lab next month. Though I'll be honest with you two—I'd a whole lot rather be sitting at our kitchen table in Virginia Beach testing that code right now than driving to Port Canaveral."

"So would we, Dad," I grumbled, shifting my stiff legs on the bench seat while Katie laced her left hand through my right.

None of the three of us—not Dad, not Katie, and not me—had wanted to go on this seven-day Caribbean cruise at the end of August. Back in July, Katie and I had worked hard through our high-school summer school class, knocking out a required academic credit early so that when eleventh grade started in September, our main school-year schedules would free up for a shared lunch block together every single day. All the three of us had wanted for the final two weeks of summer was to stay home in peace so Dad could study for his upcoming fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR.

To get a head start before classes began, Dad had gone to the Virginia Beach Public Library and checked out the newest programming manual they had left on the shelf—a slightly outdated, dog-eared copy of *Learn Quantum Basic 5.0 in 21 Days* wrapped in a clear plastic mylar library jacket with a barcode sticker on the spine. Within forty-eight hours of Dad setting that book on the dining table, Katie had started reading it cover to cover and teaching the event loops and form layouts to me on my bedroom computer. When Dad caught us working through his library book together, he hadn't been upset at all; he had beamed with pride and started actively encouraging both of us to follow our dreams.

Up in the front passenger seat, however, our mother, Brenda, hadn't cared about Dad's CCHR classes, our summer school credit, or the fact that twelve hours crammed into a sedan was making Katie's and my legs ache from hip to ankle. Mom

had insisted on booking this seven-day Eastern Caribbean cruise—and when we finally rolled over the causeway into Port Canaveral on Saturday afternoon, the visual irony hit Katie and me right through the windshield.

Docked at the premier terminal across the blue channel stood a gleaming, navy-and-gold *Majestic Cruise Line* ship, its twin funnels shining in the Florida sun.

We didn't turn into the *Majestic* terminal. Instead, Mom directed Dad toward Pier 3, where a boxy, bargain-rate mass-market ship called the *M/S Sunward Tropics* was loading passengers.

By four o'clock that afternoon, standing packed shoulder-to-shoulder in bulky orange foam lifejackets out on the humid teak planks of the Deck 4 Boat Promenade for the mandatory twenty-minute safety muster drill—with all of the ship's elevators shut off—I felt the first warning tremor shoot down both of my calves. Beside me, Katie was leaning almost her entire weight against my right arm just to keep her knees locked. Both of us had lived with mild cerebral palsy since birth, which had always made our balance uneven, but standing on that hot deck before climbing two flights of metal stairs back to our cramped inside cabin left our legs shaking and our arms strangely weak on the brass banisters in a way neither of us had ever felt before.

Dad walked right behind us up every step of the stairwell, one hand braced behind Katie's back and the other steadying my elbow, his brow furrowed with quiet concern as he watched how hard our arms were straining just to pull ourselves up the railing.

Sunday, August 19, 2001, 9:30 AM — Ditching *Captain Barnaby* for the Deck 8 CyberCafé

"Look at the two of you—you're going to be late for the character breakfast!" Mom snapped at nine-twenty on Sunday morning, shoving two neon-yellow *"Camp Sunward Youth"* lanyards and a printed activity sheet into Dad's hand before disappearing out the cabin door toward the Lido Pool Bar. "And I put Katie's name down for the two o'clock beginner ballet and ballroom workshop in the Starlight Lounge!"

Katie stared at the pink dance slip in horror, her fingers tightening around my wrist as the ship rolled gently on its first full day at sea heading toward Nassau.

"Come on," Dad said quietly, his jaw tight as he picked up his canvas backpack—with the Virginia Beach Public Library *Quantum Basic 5.0* book tucked inside—and led Katie and me down the narrow corridor to the elevator. "Let's go see what your mother signed you up for."

Five minutes later, the three of us stood outside the double glass doors of the Starlight Lounge on Deck 6.

Inside, thirty screaming six- and seven-year-olds were banging plastic spoons against paper placemats while accordion music blared from the speakers. Waddling between the tables were two sweaty crew members zipped into bargain-bin polyester foam mascot suits—*Captain Barnaby the Buccaneer Parrot* and *Salty the Starfish*—whose faded fabric looked like it had been pulled out of a carnival dumpster.

At the podium by the door, a twenty-two-year-old youth counselor glanced down at her clipboard—where Mom had written *Prairie, Nathaniel* and *Prairie, Katie*—and then looked up at two sixteen-year-old high schoolers standing side by side in t-shirts and jeans. Her face turned bright red with second-hand embarrassment.

Dad took one look through the glass doors at the foam parrot, looked at Katie's and my mortified faces, and didn't hesitate for half a second.

"Take those yellow lanyards off, kids," Dad said calmly.

Stepping up to the podium, Dad handed the lanyards back to the relieved counselor, drew a clean line through both of our names on the character breakfast roster, and asked her to cross Katie's name off the afternoon ballet workshop sheet as well.

"Where are the computers and the arcade cabinets on this ship?" Dad asked the counselor.

"Deck 8 Midship, sir—right next to the quiet library and card room," she replied gratefully.

Ten minutes later, sitting side by side in two padded armchairs inside the air-conditioned quiet of the Deck 8 CyberCafé overlooking the deep blue Atlantic, Katie and I finally exhaled. Dad swiped his cabin card to buy two hours of desktop terminal time, pulled the thick, mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook out of his bag, and set it open on the desk right between our keyboards.

While Mom spent the entire Sunday at sea up at the pool bar, the three of us spent the afternoon right there by the ocean windows—Katie pointing out how to nest *For…Next* loops on the screen, my fingers typing the syntax into the editor, and Dad sitting right beside us smiling with genuine pride.

Part 2: The Nassau Pier, Guest Services, & The Last Straw

Date: 2001-08-22 at 14:00 America/Puerto_Rico

Monday–Wednesday, August 20–22, 2001 — The Nassau Pier & The Honest Question

"Hold onto my arm, Nate—don't look down at the concrete," Katie breathed against my shoulder as the ninety-two-degree Bahamas sun beat straight down onto the endless gray concrete expanse of Prince George Wharf in Nassau on Monday morning.

Ahead of us, Mom was already a hundred yards down the pier, marching briskly toward the duty-free liquor stores and open-air bars along Bay Street without once looking back to see where her children were. Halfway between the ship's gangway and the terminal gate, my right knee buckled without warning. When Katie tried to catch my weight with both hands, her own wrists gave out, and both of us nearly went down onto the hot concrete before Dad caught us under the arms and guided us onto a shaded wooden bench beside the port tram stop.

“Neither of you is walking another step in this heat,” Dad said firmly, kneeling down to check our trembling ankles before flagging down the port courtesy shuttle and hiring an air-conditioned island van driver to take just the three of us over the bridge to the step-free underwater glass aquarium tunnel on Paradise Island.

Over the next forty-eight hours—as the ship steamed south from the Bahamas toward Charlotte Amalie in St. Thomas and Philipsburg in St. Maarten—the gap between what Mom wanted and what our bodies could handle grew wider by the hour. Every time the ship rolled in the Caribbean swell, walking the long metal passageways felt like wading through wet cement, while Mom spent every afternoon running up the cabin bar tab and complaining whenever she passed us that Katie wasn’t attending the ship’s dance classes.

On Wednesday afternoon, Dad collected Katie and me outside the Deck 8 arcade, led us to a quiet, shaded alcove of deck chairs, and looked straight at the two of us.

“Please be honest,” Dad asked quietly. “Are you two not enjoying the cruise?”

When Katie and I looked at each other and struggled to come up with an answer, Dad leaned forward and rested his hands on his knees.

“I want to let you both in on how I feel,” Dad said earnestly. “Katie, this especially goes for you. I watched you teach your brother the *Quantum Basic* programming that I am learning in school at CCHR, and I am absolutely encouraging both of you to keep at it if you both like it. I see that your mother is trying to talk you into being a ballerina, but I get that you don’t want to.”

“I don’t have the balance to dance,” Katie said honestly, looking down at her sneakers. Mom still refused to accept that we had cerebral palsy—let alone whatever was making our arms and legs grow weaker this summer—insisting she saw two completely healthy kids. “I like this coding thing.”

“And I am encouraging you with this coding thing… I am encouraging both of you,” Dad said warmly.

“I didn’t appreciate that Mom tried booking us on the kid stuff,” I added, thinking back to the foam parrot mascot at Sunday morning’s breakfast door. “Katie and I are sixteen and already in high school, and I don’t want to meet the characters. It’s not even the characters that little kids want to meet, because it’s not *Majestic Cruise Line*! I want to play the computer games.”

“I get it,” Dad said, nodding firmly. He took a deep breath, his expression turning solemn. “There is something else I wanted to confide in both of you, and that is Mom’s drinking issue. Our next stop will be the front counter where I want to attempt to cut off the flow of alcohol to your mother.”

2:45 PM — Cutting Off the Flow at the Front Counter

The process at the Purser’s Desk in the Deck 5 Atrium Lobby seemed to drag on forever, and Katie and I found a padded seat across the lobby while we waited for Dad to be finished.

Because every bar on the ship operated on cashless plastic stateroom keycards—and because Dad's *Anchor Federal Credit Union* card was the sole payment method guaranteeing our cabin's Master Folio—Dad had the authority as the primary account holder to revoke all charging privileges on Mom's keycard and have the Watch Purser place a mandatory alcohol cut-off flag on her passenger ID across the ship's point-of-sale network.

When Dad finally walked back over to our bench, he held out three plastic cabin keycards, each newly stamped with a small holographic fountain-cup sticker.

"I bought the three of us a soda package, and we can get sodas and juice every fifteen minutes," Dad told us. "Your mother is going to be mad, but I don't care. I am so sorry to both of you that it is turning out like this, but I have to protect both of you."

Sitting down beside us for a moment, Dad lowered his voice to a quiet whisper.

"I know that you two have decided that you are inseparable, and I am okay with that, and I won't tell the world about your little secret," Dad whispered, looking at Katie and me with steady, unconditional protective warmth. "Yes, I know, and I think I've known for a while. Just don't go blabbing to everyone, and be careful with things."

3:30 PM — The Corridor Breakdown & The Ultimatum

The three of us rode the elevator down to Deck 4 and walked to our stateroom—and to our horror, though not to our surprise, when Dad opened the door, our mother was passed out drunk across the three-cushion convertible sofa that was supposed to unfold into the bed that Katie and I shared at night.

"Oh, I've had enough of your mother's nonsense," Dad said, pulling the door shut and turning Katie and me right around in the passageway.

We walked a long way through a narrow, windowless maze of identical stateroom hallways—our legs trembling and our feet stumbling against the carpet seams with every roll of the ship—until we finally reached a quiet stairwell seating alcove and sat down on the built-in bench.

Right there under the brass wall sconces, Dad buried his face in his hands and absolutely lost it, breaking down and crying.

Katie and I were completely at a loss for words. Our mental image of Daddy being tough and unbreakable came crashing down all at once, and for the first time in our sixteen years, we were seeing the exhausted, hurting human side of our father.

Katie and I sat close against his sides on the bench and just waited, holding hands because this was something neither of us knew how to respond to.

"I guess it will have to be a cruise for three," Katie whispered softly to me.

“Yeah, I guess,” I whispered back to my sister. We both looked over at our father, who was the most upset we had ever seen him in our lives. I didn’t even remember crying this hard when taking a bad fall on the pavement, and yet here the three of us were.

“I’ll try my best to handle this. Daddy needs us right now,” Katie whispered, resting her hand on Dad’s arm. “This is going to be a long and painful cruise.”

That was when we heard a screaming rage echoing down the metal hallway toward our alcove.

“The heck was that?” I asked, my heart jumping as a startled Katie looked up beside me.

“Where is my fucking beer?!”

Our mother had woken up from her drunken nap on our sofa, stormed up to the nearest deck bar, discovered that her keycard had been cut off at the register, and tracked us down the corridor—drunkenly screeching profanities at our visibly upset father.

Spotting Katie and me sitting on the alcove bench directly beneath the black dome of the stairwell’s ceiling security camera, Mom’s bloodshot eyes locked onto us.

“And you two ungrateful brats!” she slurred loudly, staggering forward toward our bench. “I signed you up for the character meet-and-greet and the dance class, and you ditched them and got your father to cut off my card!”

As she lunged toward our bench and swung her arm wildly in my direction, her balance gave out and she missed completely as Dad surged to his feet and stepped squarely between her and the bench, blocking her path in full view of the ceiling security camera.

“Don’t you ever raise a hand toward them!” Dad said, his voice turning to iron as he wiped the last trace of tears from his eyes. “I’ve had enough, and so have the kids. This cruise was supposed to be family time, and the three of us are tired of your drinking. Nathaniel, Katie, and I are giving you a choice right now: us, or the alcohol.”

Mom glared at us and slurred something bitter that none of us could even understand.

“Message received,” Dad said flatly. “You pick the bottle over your husband and children.”

Turning his back on her, Dad looked down at Katie and me and reached out both hands to help us stand up as our mother drunkenly stumbled away down the hall.

“Come on, you two,” Dad said gently. “I want you to show me what you two would like to do.”

As he supported our elbows and led Katie and me away down the passage, Dad made a vow that neither of us would ever forget.

“I’m making both of you a promise: I want to be a dad, and I want you both to help guide me through this,” Dad said quietly. “It will be painful, but your mother does not seem to want to be a mom. I’m sorry, but I have to do right by both of you.”

Holding onto Dad’s arms as our exhausted legs shook beneath us, the three of us stumbled through what felt like an endless hallway of cabins until we finally stumbled out into the bright light of the lobby.

Part 3: Stateroom 6004, The Loaner Wheelchairs, & Pizza for Three on the Aft Deck

Date: 2001-08-23 at 18:30 America/Puerto_Rico

Wednesday, August 22, 2001, 4:15 PM — Domestic Separation, The Brig, & Two Manual Wheelchairs

“My kids can barely stand up after walking down that Deck 4 corridor, and my wife is screaming profanities at us in the passageway,” Dad told the Chief Purser flatly as the three of us reached the front counter in the Atrium Lobby, my knees trembling so badly that I had both hands braced against the marble counter edge while Katie leaned against my side. “I am not putting my son and daughter back in Stateroom 4118 with her tonight. I don’t want her in the cabin with us anymore.”

The Chief Purser glanced down at the black security radio clipped to his lapel, took one look at Dad’s raw, red-rimmed eyes and one look at Katie and me struggling to stay upright on our feet, and immediately picked up a brass master key.

“Deck 4 Security just radioed up after reviewing the stairwell alcove security camera feed, Mr. Prairie,” the Chief Purser said quietly. “Our camera recorded your wife’s outburst in the corridor and her attempt to swing at your son on the bench before you stepped in. We hold two wheelchair-accessible contingency staterooms right off the Deck 6 midship elevators for medical and family safety emergencies. I am placing a confidential Domestic Separation Flag on your manifest right now and moving you, Nathaniel, and Katie into Stateroom 6004. Only your three soda-package keycards will open that door, and our staff is strictly prohibited from disclosing your new cabin number to your wife.”

Dad let out a long breath of pure relief, then glanced down at Katie’s shaking ankles and mine.

“Is there any chance the ship has two manual wheelchairs my twins can use for the rest of the cruise?” Dad asked, looking back at Katie and me to make sure we agreed.

Both Katie and I nodded immediately. Neither of us cared what strangers on a cruise ship thought—we were exhausted from fighting our own legs every time we crossed a deck.

“Consider it done, sir,” the Chief Purser replied. “I’ll have the Medical Center bring two folding *SwiftChair* manual wheelchairs straight up to Stateroom 6004 while our stewards transfer your bags and your library books from Deck 4.”

By five o'clock that afternoon, Dad, Katie, and I were safely upstairs inside Stateroom 6004—a wide, quiet room five steps from the elevator lobby with a clean double sofa bed that unfolded without a single obstacle and two folding manual wheelchairs waiting by the door.

At seven-fifteen that evening, while Katie and I were sitting together on the sofa bed reading Dad's *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book, a polite knock sounded on our cabin door. When Dad opened it, the Chief Purser stood in the corridor with a clipboard under his arm.

"I wanted to check on you and the twins in person, Mr. Prairie, and let you know that you won't have to worry about running into your wife on the decks for the rest of the voyage," the Chief Purser told Dad evenly, his voice carrying clearly to where Katie and I sat. "About an hour ago, Mrs. Prairie returned to Stateroom 4118, found your luggage gone, and came down to the Atrium Lobby after her keycard was declined at the Lido Bar. When we refused to disclose your new cabin number or unblock her alcohol privileges, she tried to climb over the Purser's counter and swung a fist at one of our Security officers. The Staff Captain has placed her in the ship's brig down on Deck 2."

Katie's hand tightened around mine on the sofa cushion as we listened.

"Because we have already cleared our final Caribbean port of call and are steaming north," the Chief Purser continued, handing Dad a thick, sealed manila envelope, "she will remain in security custody until we dock at Port Canaveral on Saturday morning, where she will be escorted off the vessel and handed a permanent lifetime ban from *Sunward Cruise Lines*. Inside this envelope is a certified copy of our Shipboard Security Incident Report along with a duplicate VHS tape from the Deck 4 stairwell security camera documenting the 3:30 PM corridor incident, in case your family attorney in Virginia needs official documentation. I also want to assure you, Nathaniel, and Katie that your names are completely clear—none of the three of you are excluded from sailing with us in the future."

Dad thanked him quietly and closed the door. Mom had managed to get herself banned from a cruise line yet again—not that Dad, Katie, or I ever wanted to set foot on a cruise ship again in the first place.

Thursday, August 23, 2001, 6:30 PM — Pizza & Soda Refills on the Aft Deck

"Two pepperoni slices, two extra-cheese slices, and three fifteen-minute fountain refills—two colas and an orange juice," Dad announced with a genuine smile on Thursday evening as he set a steaming stainless-steel pizza platter and three tall plastic tumblers down on our round table out on the open wooden aft deck.

Sitting side by side in our two ship-provided folding manual wheelchairs right at the back rail of Deck 9, watching the white foaming wake of the ship stretch out across the turquoise Caribbean Sea under a golden-orange sunset, Katie and I reached across the space between our wheelchair armrests and laced our fingers together.

Inside the main dining rooms tonight was Captain's Formal Night, where hundreds of passengers were crammed into noisy banquet halls in stiff suits and high heels. Out here on the breezy fantail deck, wearing comfortable t-shirts and jeans with zero

pain in our calves or knees thanks to the manual wheelchairs, the last two days of the voyage had finally become what Katie had whispered in the corridor alcove: a peaceful cruise for three.

“How do the chairs feel?” Dad asked softly, pulling his deck chair right up beside our wheels and picking up a slice of pizza.

“So much better, Dad,” Katie said, leaning her head briefly against my shoulder as she took a sip from her straw. “My legs aren’t shaking at all.”

“Mine either,” I agreed, looking down at our three soda-sticker keycards resting together on the table next to Dad’s library copy of *Quantum Basic 5.0*. For the first time all week, nobody was yelling, nobody was trying to force Katie to dance or shove us into a room with foam parrot mascots, and as the warm ocean breeze blew past the stern rail, the three of us talked for two straight hours about the programs we were going to write when we got home to Virginia Beach.

Part 4: Back on Dry Land & The Twelve-Hour Drive Up I-95

Date: 2001-08-25 at 08:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 25, 2001, 8:30 AM — Back on Dry Land

“Nathaniel. Katie. I’m sorry that your first cruise was wrecked, and somehow I want to make it up to both of you,” Dad said earnestly as two crew members helped us transfer out of the ship’s loaner wheelchairs onto the gray cloth back bench seat of our Holt sedan at the Port Canaveral pickup curb. Resting a steady hand on each of our shoulders through the open door, Dad continued, “Here is what we will do: neither one of you wanted to go on that cruise, but your mother insisted. I want to finish school at CCHR so that I can do a better job at being a dad without having to worry about money as much.”

Before Katie or I could answer him, an angry screech tore across the concrete baggage drop from behind us.

“You! You told the ship to stop my drinks!”

Looking through the open rear doorway, I saw our mother being escorted out of the customs terminal doors by two *Sunward Cruise Lines* security officers after being released from the ship’s brig, clutching a folded white sheet of permanent lifetime ban paperwork in her fist. Her face was flushed dark red in the morning Florida heat as she stormed up to the rear fender of our car.

Every muscle in Dad’s jaw tightened as he straightened up beside our open door and looked at her.

“If we were anywhere near Hampton Roads right now, Brenda, I would hand you twenty dollars for a bus fare and leave you standing on this curb,” Dad told her, his voice as cold and flat as steel. “The only reason I am unlocking this front door is because we are seven hundred miles from Virginia. Get in the front passenger seat, and don’t say a single word to the kids for the next twelve hours. The second this car pulls into our driveway in Virginia Beach, you are packing your bags and getting out of our house.”

Without waiting for her to reply, Dad closed our rear door securely, walked around to the driver's side, and pulled out of Port Canaveral toward Interstate 95 North.

12:15 PM — Exit 94 Near Savannah, Georgia: The Gas Pump, The Restrooms, & Brenda's First Angle

For the first three and a half hours heading north out of Florida across the Georgia state line, the inside of the car was dead silent except for the hum of the tires and the air conditioner. In the back seat, Katie and I sat pressed shoulder-to-shoulder with our inner hands laced together and Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook resting across our knees.

Just past noon, the low-fuel chime dinged on the dashboard, and Dad signaled right at Exit 94 near Savannah, pulling under the canopy of a highway travel plaza so we could get gas and use the restrooms.

That stop was when the physical reality of leaving the ship hit Katie and me all over again.

On Thursday and Friday aboard the *Sunward Tropics*, we had rolled everywhere in the Medical Center's two folding loaner wheelchairs. Those wheelchairs belonged to the ship, which meant they were still back at Port Canaveral. When Dad opened our rear door beside Pump 6 and I swung my sneakers out onto the ninety-degree Georgia concrete, my knees and calves trembled so violently that I had to grab the roof frame with both hands just to keep from sliding onto the pavement. Beside me, when Katie tried to push herself up off the bench cushion, the strength in her right forearm gave out halfway up, and she gasped softly as she sank back against the seat.

Up front, Mom didn't even glance back at our door. She slammed the front passenger door shut and marched briskly across the concrete apron toward the air-conditioned travel store restrooms on her own.

Dad saw us struggling immediately. Leaving the gas nozzle clicking in the tank, he stepped right between Katie and me, braced his left arm firmly around Katie's waist and his right hand under my elbow, and took half of our weight onto his own shoulders.

"Take your time, kids—I've got both of you," Dad murmured close to our ears as he walked us slowly, step by shuffling step, across the hot pavement and up the curb ramp to the restroom hallway. He stood waiting right between the men's and women's doors until both of us came back out, then supported us all the way back to the back seat of the Holt before topping off the tank and paying at the window.

When Mom finally strolled back out of the convenience store carrying a bottle of water and buckled herself into the front passenger seat, her furious scowl from Port Canaveral was suddenly replaced by self-pity. As Dad checked in the rearview mirror to make sure Katie and I were buckled securely into our back-seat shoulder belts, shifted into drive, and merged back onto I-95 North, Mom launched into a bitter, non-stop tirade about how "unfairly" she had been treated down in the ship's brig.

“David, honey, look—let’s be reasonable now that we’re off that awful boat,” Mom complained, turning slightly toward him in the front seat. “Do you have any idea how terrible life in a cruise ship brig actually is, or what I just went through for sixty-two straight hours? It was completely unfair! That purser had it out for me from the moment we boarded, and those security guards treated me like a common criminal over a couple of drinks!”

In the back seat, Katie and I glanced at each other and squeezed hands as Mom kept going, oblivious to the way Dad’s jaw was clenching harder with every word out of her mouth.

“They put wrist restraints on me and marched me down a steel freight elevator to the Deck 2 crew corridor below the waterline, right on top of the diesel engine room!” Mom ranted, her voice rising with indignation. “They confiscated my cabin card, my wristwatch, my belt, and even my shoes! For two and a half days I was locked inside a windowless steel box that vibrated twenty-four hours a day from the ship’s engines. No porthole, no clock, no television, no pillow—just a hard vinyl mat bolted to the steel floor with a stiff Velcro blanket, an institutional stainless-steel toilet welded to the sink in the corner, and a blinding fluorescent ceiling light with a security camera staring at me that never turned off once!”

Beside me, Katie leaned her head close to my shoulder. Both of us could see the muscles in Dad’s neck and shoulders stiffening against the driver’s backrest. Mom thought she was winning sympathy, when in reality every single complaint she made was hardening Dad’s resolve like poured concrete.

“And the food!” Mom went on, gesturing with her water bottle. “While the three of you were upstairs doing whatever you wanted, they wouldn’t even let me have a soda! Every four hours the ship’s doctor or some nurse slid open the metal slot in the door to take my blood pressure and hand me paper cones of lukewarm tap water and salt packets while my head was splitting open! Three times a day a guard shoved a paper plate of bland crew-galley mush through the slot with a bendable plastic spoon, and every fifteen minutes day and night a guard slid the peephole open to write on a clipboard! Then yesterday afternoon they had the nerve to tell me that stewards had packed my clothes out of Cabin 4118 with red security tape and handed me a lifetime ban! I’ve been punished enough, David—there’s no reason to talk crazy about me packing bags when we get home.”

Katie looked at me and gave a tiny, unmistakable shake of her head. *Every argument she makes,* Katie’s eyes said to mine, *just weakens her case even more.*

I thought the exact same thing. For sixty-two hours down on Deck 2, Mom hadn’t spent a single minute worrying about her sixteen-year-old twins or her husband—she had only cared about her confiscated watch, her crew-galley trays, and her cut-off beer tab.

From the back bench seat, I watched Dad’s knuckles turn white against the top of the steering wheel. In the rearview mirror, his eyes met mine and Katie’s for a brief, steady second before he answered without even looking at Mom.

“You swung a fist at a ship security officer because they wouldn’t serve you beer at four o’clock in the afternoon, Brenda,” Dad said in a low, gravelly voice that carried clearly to the back seat. “That headache you had down on Deck 2 was sixty-two hours of forced sobriety. And while you were passed out drunk on the kids’ sofa bed before security locked you up, I had to hold our sixteen-year-old son and daughter

up by their elbows because their legs and arms were giving out on them. Just ten minutes ago at that gas pump, neither one of them could stand up out of the back seat without leaning on me, and you walked right past them to the store without looking back once. That brig wasn't unfair. It was the consequence of who you've chosen to be."

4:45 PM — Rocky Mount, North Carolina: Drive-Thru Dinner & Cementing the Lawyer Decision

By quarter to five that afternoon, as the green highway signs ticked past Fayetteville and into Rocky Mount, North Carolina, the three of us were starving and needed another restroom stop.

After Dad helped Katie and me carefully in and out of the roadside rest-area bathrooms just off the exit—where my wrists shook so badly I could barely push the heavy metal restroom door open by myself—Dad didn't make us walk inside a crowded highway sit-down restaurant and try to carry plastic food trays on trembling arms. Instead, he pulled the Holt sedan straight into the drive-thru lane of a *Penny's* hamburger restaurant next to the interstate ramp, ordered four cheeseburger meals, and handed a warm white paper bag of cheeseburgers and fries back to Katie and me before merging back onto the highway.

Buckled safely into our three-point shoulder seatbelts side by side on the gray cloth rear bench seat as the pine trees and green *I-95 NORTH* signs rolled past our rear window, Katie held the white paper *Penny's* bag on her lap while Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook rested open across mine, with our inner hands clasped tightly together on the cushion between us.

Up in the front passenger seat, as Mom finished her sandwich, I heard her abandon the brig complaints and try a second angle—cold financial bargaining.

"Think about this logically for two seconds, David," Mom said, her voice sharp and calculating in the quiet car. "You're taking classes at CCHR. How exactly do you think you're going to pay the house note in Virginia Beach, buy groceries, finish your degree, and take care of two sixteen-year-olds all by yourself without my income? Look—I'll cut back to drinking only on Friday and Saturday nights. We can put this behind us and go back to normal on Monday."

Beside me in the back seat, Katie squeezed my left hand with her right. Neither of us was even afraid that Dad would give in anymore—watching the back of Dad's shoulders, both of us could tell that Mom was digging her own grave deeper with every sentence.

"She doesn't get it at all," Katie whispered so softly that only I could hear her over the hum of the highway tires.

"Not even a little," I whispered back, looking down at our joined hands between my open *Quantum Basic* book and her lunch bag. Since the day we were born, Katie and I had been each other's anchor, best friend, and safe harbor—and in the lifelong bond the two of us shared, there was simply no room left for someone as bitter, selfish, and mean as our mother. All we needed was each other and our dad.

Up front, I watched Dad slowly set his cup into the center console holder, glance briefly toward the passenger seat, and speak in a calm, ironclad voice I had never heard from him in my life.

“Thank you for saying that out loud, Brenda—because if I had one percent of doubt left about seeking a lawyer’s advice when we get home, every argument you’ve made since Florida just erased it,” Dad told her evenly. “You spent three hours complaining about a steel bunk in the brig, and now you’re bargaining to drink on weekends—and you still haven’t asked Nathaniel or Katie a single time in eight hours why their legs and arms are failing them. I don’t care if I have to work double shifts around my CCHR classes to pay the bills. First thing Monday morning at eight-thirty, I am calling a divorce lawyer to file for divorce and full custody of the twins, and my very next call is going to be to Dr. Chen’s office to get both of them examined. We are never going back to ‘normal.’”

Mom opened her mouth, saw the look on Dad’s face, and snapped her jaw shut without another word for the rest of North Carolina and Virginia.

9:15 PM — Home in Virginia Beach: Packing the Bags

At nine-fifteen that night, after more than twelve hours on the road, the headlights of our Holt sedan finally swept across our driveway in Virginia Beach.

Before touching a single suitcase in the trunk, Dad walked around to our rear door, helped Katie and me out of the back seat, and supported both of us up the front steps and straight inside to the living room sofa, propping two throw pillows behind our backs and setting his *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book on the coffee table within easy reach.

Then, true to his word from Port Canaveral, Dad walked back out into the front foyer, folded his arms across his chest, and stood watch at the bottom of the stairs for forty-five straight minutes while Brenda packed her suitcases, dragged them out the front door to her car, and backed out of the driveway.

When Dad clicked the front deadbolt shut and walked into the living room to check on us, our house was finally, mercifully peaceful.

Part 5: Monday Morning in Virginia Beach — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

Date: 2001-08-27 at 10:15 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 10:15 AM — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

“Squeeze my fingers as hard as you can, Nathaniel, and hold it for five seconds,” Dr. Evelyn Chen instructed gently inside Exam Room 2 of her Virginia Beach family practice clinic on Monday morning.

Sitting side by side on the crinkly white paper of the padded exam table in our t-shirts and jeans, Katie and I kept our inner hands laced tightly together between our knees while I reached my left hand out to squeeze Dr. Chen's fingers.

Earlier that morning at eight-thirty, while Katie and I sat at the kitchen table eating cereal with the sealed *Sunward Cruise Lines* manila envelope resting beside the napkin holder, we had listened as Dad stood by the kitchen wall phone and kept the first half of his highway vow—calling a family law and divorce attorney's office off Independence Boulevard.

When Dad told the attorney on the line that he had a certified Shipboard Security Incident Report and a duplicate VHS security camera tape from Deck 4 showing Brenda's corridor outburst and her attempt to swing at me on the bench over the character meet-and-greet, we watched a wave of relief wash across Dad's face. Hanging up the receiver, Dad had turned to Katie and me and explained what the lawyer had just told him: under Virginia law, the one-year separation waiting period only applied to no-fault divorces. Because the ship's security camera had caught her attempt to strike a minor child and her subsequent detention in the brig, Dad qualified to file immediately on fault grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt—allowing the lawyer to petition the Virginia Beach court right away for sole custody of the two of us, exclusive possession of our house, and a protective order without waiting a single year.

The moment he finished writing down our afternoon appointment time with the lawyer, Dad dialed Dr. Chen, our Primary Care Physician, and explained how badly our arms and legs had been giving out on the cruise and at the Interstate 95 rest stops. Dr. Chen's nurse had told him to bring both of us straight in at ten o'clock.

For the first two seconds, my grip held around Dr. Chen's fingers—and then, no matter how hard I concentrated, the strength in my forearm and wrist drained away like water through a sieve. When Dr. Chen tested Katie's grip, her shoulder resistance, and the dorsiflexion in both of our ankles, the exact same drop-off happened.

Dr. Chen stepped back, slipped her reflex hammer into the pocket of her white coat, and looked gravely at Dad, who was standing protectively right beside us.

"David," Dr. Chen said quietly, "bringing them in immediately after you got back from Florida was the exact right call."

"They've had mild cerebral palsy since they were little," Dad said, his hand resting warmly on Katie's shoulder. "Brenda always ignored it and acted like they were two completely typical kids, so at first I assumed the ship's movement was just aggravating their balance. Why are both their arms and their legs getting worse at sixteen?"

"Because cerebral palsy does not degenerate over time," Dr. Chen answered clearly, looking from Dad to Katie and me with deep compassion. "Cerebral palsy is a static, non-progressive condition. When sixteen-year-old twins begin losing measurable motor strength in both their lower extremities and their upper extremities over the course of a single summer, something else is happening."

Beside me on the exam table, Katie squeezed my fingers with every ounce of strength left in her hand, and I squeezed right back.

“I’m ordering a full neuromuscular blood panel, nerve conduction studies, and a genetic workup this morning,” Dr. Chen continued gently, picking up her chart clipboard. “Until those test results come back and tell us exactly what condition we are dealing with, I need all three of you to prepare yourselves for the reality of what I’m seeing in their muscle tone today. When it comes to walking, Nathaniel and Katie are on borrowed time. Eventually, neither of them is going to be able to walk, and because their upper arms and wrists are fatiguing too, they are eventually going to need power wheelchairs.”

The quiet exam room seemed to hold its breath around those words—*on borrowed time*.

“How soon will the test results be back, Evelyn?” Dad asked quietly, his hand resting steady and warm on Katie’s shoulder.

“The genetic and nerve-conduction panel takes about two and a half weeks,” Dr. Chen answered, writing an appointment card at her desk and handing it to Dad. “Let’s schedule their next checkup for Friday afternoon, September fourteenth, at three o’clock—right after their two o’clock dismissal at Northwood High School. You can pick them up when the final bell rings at two, bring them straight here for their three o’clock appointment, and we’ll check how their arms and legs are holding up and go over every test result together.”

Yet as I looked sideways at my twin sister, and felt Dad’s steady, unwavering arm wrap around both of our shoulders at once, the fear didn’t break us. Whatever the test results showed when we came back for our three o’clock checkup after school on September fourteenth, Mom’s screaming was gone, Daddy was standing right beside us, and Katie and I were going to face every single mile of it together.

Junior Year at Northwood High & The Prognosis

Part 1: The Fault-Grounds Filing, The Protective Order, & Junior Year at Northwood High School

Date: 2001-09-04 at 11:40 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 2:00 PM — The Lawyer’s Office off Independence Boulevard

“Timestamp fifteen-thirty-two and eighteen seconds,” family law attorney Arthur Vance read aloud in his quiet, wood-paneled conference room off Independence Boulevard, pressing the pause button on his office VCR remote so the grainy black-and-white frame from the *M/S Sunward Tropics* Deck 4 stairwell camera froze on the television screen.

Sitting side by side on the leather sofa across from Mr. Vance’s desk with our inner hands clasped tightly together, Katie and I looked at the frozen image on the screen. Right there beneath the ceiling camera’s timestamp—*AUG 22 2001 15:32:18 CAM-04B*—was our mother lunging toward our alcove bench with her arm raised, and Dad standing like a shield squarely between her and the two of us.

“Mr. Prairie, in twenty-four years of practicing family law in Virginia Beach, I have rarely seen a cleaner, more airtight evidentiary packet,” Mr. Vance said, setting the remote down beside the Staff Captain’s notarized *Shipboard Security Incident Report* and permanent lifetime exclusion notice. “Normally in Virginia, when minor children are involved, a couple has to live separate and apart for one full year before filing for a no-fault divorce. You do not have to wait a single day.”

Across from us, Dad leaned forward in his chair, his hands folded on the edge of the mahogany table.

“How fast can we get the court orders in place so Brenda can’t come back to the house or show up at their high school when classes start next week?” Dad asked.

“This afternoon,” Mr. Vance answered firmly. “Because the ship’s security camera captured her attempting to strike sixteen-year-old Nathaniel while intoxicated—and because the ship’s brig and medical logs corroborate every word—we are filing a fault-based Complaint for Divorce on grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt under Virginia Code Section 20-91(A)(6) before the Circuit Court clerk’s office closes at four o’clock. Alongside it, I am walking an emergency *pendente lite* petition and family protective order straight in to the duty judge.”

Mr. Vance counted the points off on his fingers so Katie and I could follow every step.

“First, you get immediate temporary sole legal and physical custody of Nathaniel and Katie,” Mr. Vance said. “Second, you get exclusive use and possession of the marital home in Virginia Beach—meaning you are legally authorized to change every lock on the doors tonight, and Brenda cannot set foot on the property. Third, the protective order bars her from coming within five hundred feet of the twins or setting foot on the campus of Northwood High School. And fourth, because fault grounds of cruelty bar an offending spouse from receiving alimony under Virginia law, she won’t get a dime of spousal support.”

Beside me on the leather sofa, Katie let out a long, quiet breath and leaned her shoulder against mine. That evening before dinner, Dad bought three brass deadbolt kits at the hardware store, changed every lock on our front, back, and garage doors, and handed the shiny new keys to Katie and me.

Tuesday, September 4, 2001, 11:40 AM — Junior Year at Northwood High School

“We actually pulled it off, Nate—fourth-block lunch and study hall together every single day,” Katie said with a relieved smile the Tuesday after Labor Day as the two of us eased down side by side onto the bench of a quiet, sunlit corner table near the tall windows of the Northwood High School cafeteria.

Back in July, when we had given up half of our mornings to sit through high-school summer school and knock out a required academic credit early, this exact forty-five-minute sanctuary in the middle of our Junior year schedule was what we had worked for. Earlier that morning at seven-forty-five, Dad had walked into the Northwood

High main office with us to hand-deliver a certified copy of the Virginia Beach judge's custody and protective orders to the principal's secretary, removing Brenda's name from our emergency contact cards for good.

Yet as grateful as Katie and I were to be sitting together with our brown paper lunch bags, juice boxes, and our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook open on the tabletop between us, getting through the first three class periods of eleventh grade had been a sobering wake-up call for our bodies.

Even without the roll of a cruise ship beneath our feet, the long linoleum hallways and concrete stairwells of Northwood High School had pushed our legs and arms to the brink before noon. Halfway up the B-Wing stairs to second-period Chemistry, my left calf had cramped and given out so suddenly that I would have gone down on the steps if Katie hadn't grabbed my belt loop—and when she tried to pull my weight upright against the handrail, her own right wrist and forearm had trembled so violently that she dropped her binder across the landing. By the time we reached the cafeteria doors at eleven-forty, my thighs felt like lead weights and Katie's fingers were shaking so hard that I had to help her pinch open the top of her straw wrapper.

Reaching across the table between our lunch bags, I laced my right fingers through Katie's left hand and rested our joined hands flat on the cool laminate tabletop so neither of our wrists had to work to hold them up.

"How bad are your legs shaking right now?" I asked her quietly beneath the chatter of the cafeteria.

"From my knees down to my ankles," Katie admitted softly, her thumb brushing against the back of my hand as she glanced down at the event-loop diagram in my notebook. "And my right shoulder still hurts from carrying my backpack down the upstairs hall. Our next scheduled checkup with Dr. Chen is next Friday afternoon after school, right?"

"Friday at three o'clock," I nodded, squeezing her hand gently. "Dad's picking us up right at the two o'clock dismissal bell so Dr. Chen can see how our arms and legs are doing. Whatever happens, we've got Dad on our side now, and we've got this lunch table every day. We'll get through eleventh grade together."

Part 2: When Borrowed Time Runs Out — The Collapse at School, The Emergency Room Escalation, & Time for Powerchairs

Date: 2001-09-14 at 13:15 America/New_York

Friday, September 14, 2001, 1:15 PM — When Our Legs Finally Gave Out at School

"Just forty-five more minutes until the two o'clock dismissal bell, Katie, and Dad'll be waiting for us right out front in the pickup loop," I whispered at a quarter past one on Friday afternoon as the two of us walked slowly down the quiet first-floor B-Wing hallway of Northwood High School on our way back from the guidance office.

All week long, all I knew was that Friday afternoon at three o'clock was our next scheduled checkup with Dr. Evelyn Chen. Dad had arranged his Friday schedule at the Community College of Hampton Roads so he could pick Katie and me up right

when school let out at two o'clock and drive us straight over to Dr. Chen's office for our three o'clock appointment to see how our arms and legs were doing and go over whatever test results had come back from the lab.

All we had to do was make it thirty more feet down the waxed linoleum corridor to our sixth-block classroom door.

We were holding hands between us for balance, walking close to the lockers so we could brush our free fingertips against the metal doors if our ankles wobbled, when the sensation below my knees suddenly vanished.

It wasn't a slow cramp like on the stairwell the week before, and it wasn't just our calves getting tired. Halfway past Room 112, it felt as though someone had reached inside our spines and pulled the electrical plug on both of our lower bodies at the exact same second.

My right knee buckled inward without an ounce of resistance. Beside me, Katie let out a sharp gasp as both of her ankles folded underneath her at the exact same instant, and before either one of us could catch the locker handles, the two of us collapsed straight down onto the hard linoleum floor.

"Nathaniel! Katie!" Mr. Henderson, our eleventh-grade U.S. History teacher, called out in alarm from his open classroom doorway ten feet ahead of us, dropping his dry-erase marker onto his podium and hurrying out into the hallway. "Are you two all right?!"

My heart was hammering against my ribs from the shock of going down so fast, and my instinct—the stubborn sixteen-year-old instinct that had kept both of us forcing our legs down hallways all week—was to get right back up before the rest of the class saw us on the floor.

"We're okay, Mr. Henderson—just let us stand back up," I gasped, planting my left palm flat on the cold floor while Katie braced her hands against the tiles beside me.

Straining with every muscle left in our shoulders, wrists, and thighs, Katie and I tried to push ourselves back up onto our feet.

We didn't even make it halfway to our knees.

The moment we put weight on our legs and trembling forearms, both of our legs and arms crumpled completely out from under us a second time—sending both of us pitching forward and sideways with nothing left to break our fall.

Crack. Thud.

The right side of my forehead slammed hard against the unforgiving linoleum-over-concrete floor, sending a bright, stinging flash across my vision, and six inches away I heard the sickening thud of the left side of Katie's head striking the tiles right beside the locker base.

Before the ringing in my ears even settled, my very first instinct—and Katie's—was the exact same one we had had since the day we were born. Lying flat on the cold linoleum floor with a hot, throbbing knot rising on my forehead, I reached my right

hand blindly across the six inches of tile between us, and Katie's left hand met mine in midair, our fingers locking together in a vise grip so neither of us was alone on that floor.

"Stay down! Do not try to get up again!" Mr. Henderson shouted, his voice dropping an octave in urgent alarm as he saw both of our heads strike the floor and our hands clasp together between us.

He sprinted three steps to the classroom wall intercom just inside his doorway and pressed the red emergency call button. "Main Office, get Nurse Callahan to the first-floor B-Wing hallway outside Room 112 immediately! I need a Clinic Emergency escalation right now—Nathaniel and Katie Prairie both collapsed in the hallway, their legs gave out a second time when they tried to get up, and both of them hit their heads on the floor!"

Friday, September 14, 2001, 1:18 PM — Manual C-Spine Stabilization & The Emergency Room Escalation

Within forty-five seconds, Nurse Callahan, the school's registered nurse, arrived at a dead run with her orange trauma bag, followed closely by Assistant Principal Brooks and the clinic aide.

One look at the two of us lying flat on the hard tile floor holding hands with red, swelling contusions rising on our foreheads—and Mr. Henderson's report that our arms had given out on the second collapse so nothing had cushioned our heads—was all Nurse Callahan needed to escalate the protocol straight to the Emergency Room.

"Nobody lift them and nobody let them sit up!" Nurse Callahan ordered immediately, dropping to her knees behind my head while her trained clinic aide knelt behind Katie's head. Gently but firmly, Nurse Callahan placed both of her palms along the sides of my head to hold my neck in manual inline cervical stabilization, while her aide stabilized Katie's head the exact same way so neither of us could turn or nod our necks.

"Mr. Brooks," Nurse Callahan commanded, "we have an unbroken dual head strike against concrete-backed tile plus acute bilateral lower-extremity paralysis. Under school division head-and-spine protocol, they cannot be lifted into clinic wheelchairs and they cannot go home in a passenger car until an Emergency Room CT scan clears their heads and cervical spines. Call 911 right now for Virginia Beach EMS transport to Bayside General Hospital Emergency Room, put B-Wing on a temporary Hold in Place so the hallway stays clear when the bell rings, and call their father to meet the ambulance at the ER!"

"Calling 911 and Mr. Prairie right now," Assistant Principal Brooks said, unclipping his radio and telephone handset as Mr. Henderson closed the classroom doors along the corridor.

Down on the floor, even with Nurse Callahan's hands cradling the sides of my head so I couldn't turn my neck, I kept my right hand laced tightly through Katie's left hand on the tiles between us.

“Nathaniel, Katie—keep looking straight up at the ceiling tiles so your necks stay completely still, and keep holding each other’s hands,” Nurse Callahan said calmly as she checked my pupils and then Katie’s with her penlight. “Can both of you hear me and tell me your full names?”

“Nathaniel Prairie,” I answered clearly, squeezing Katie’s fingers twice so she knew I was okay.

“Katie Prairie,” Katie answered right after me, squeezing my hand back just as tightly.

“Did either of you black out when your heads hit the floor? Do you know where you are, what day it is, and what happened right before you fell?” Nurse Callahan asked.

“No, ma’am, neither of us blacked out,” I said, my voice steady despite the throbbing ache over my right eyebrow. “It’s Friday, September fourteenth, and we’re in the B-Wing hallway at Northwood High School. Our dad was supposed to pick us up at the two o’clock dismissal bell to take us to our three o’clock appointment with Dr. Evelyn Chen to see how our arms and legs were doing—and while we were walking down the hall, our legs just gave out all at once.”

“And when we tried to push ourselves back up,” Katie added clearly from beside me, “our legs and arms crumpled again and we hit our heads.”

“Can either of you wiggle your toes or push your feet forward against Mr. Henderson’s palms?” Nurse Callahan asked.

I concentrated with everything I had, ordering my ankles and calves to move. Nothing happened. Neither of my feet moved a fraction of an inch, and neither did Katie’s.

“All right, don’t strain,” Nurse Callahan told us gently as the distant wail of sirens approached down the boulevard outside. “Your dad is already on his way to the Bayside General Emergency Room to meet you, and I had the front office call Dr. Evelyn Chen’s clinic too—she has hospital privileges at Bayside General and she’s bringing your test results straight over to the Emergency Room to meet your dad there.”

Four minutes later, four Virginia Beach EMS paramedics wheeled two ambulance stretchers through the B-Wing double doors, where Nurse Callahan handed the lead paramedic two printed clinic sheets from her clipboard.

“Both patients are sixteen-year-old fraternal twins on the autism spectrum, Glasgow Coma Scale fifteen, with an unbroken dual head strike and acute bilateral lower-extremity motor loss,” Nurse Callahan briefed the lead paramedic right beside us so I could hear every word. “Look at their hands right now—they ground themselves and prevent sensory panic by holding hands and hugging. Obviously they can’t sit up or hug while they’re in C-collars on backboards, but please keep their stretchers close enough together in the rig and at triage that they don’t have to let go of each other’s hands, and brief the ER Charge Nurse before you roll in.”

“Copy that, Nurse—we’ll keep them side by side in Squad 14 and call it in to Bayside General Triage on the radio,” the lead paramedic nodded.

Working with practiced precision so our spines never bent or twisted, the paramedics fitted soft foam cervical collars around our necks, unclipped two-piece aluminum scoop stretchers that slid underneath our backs and hips from both sides on the floor, and lifted Katie and me smoothly onto the two padded gurneys—locking the two stretchers side by side in the back of the dual-patient squad rig so my right hand and Katie's left hand stayed clasped between the rails the entire ride to the hospital.

Friday, September 14, 2001, 2:10 PM — Hospital Rules, The CT Doorway, & Dr. Chen's Verdict in the ER

Because the Community College of Hampton Roads campus was only ten minutes from Bayside General Hospital, Dad actually beat our ambulance to the Emergency Room entrance by two minutes.

When the rear doors of Squad 14 swung open at the ER bay, Dad was already standing right beside the ER Charge Nurse, having briefed her himself that we were sixteen-year-old twins on the autism spectrum who grounded ourselves through physical contact—and that Dr. Evelyn Chen had already called down from her clinic across the medical plaza to let the ER team know she was bringing our neuromuscular lab packet over in person.

Even with Nurse Callahan's handoff and Dad's briefing, however, there were still real hospital rules for sixteen-year-old minors that the Emergency Room couldn't bend.

First, because Katie and I were opposite-sex sixteen-year-old minors, hospital policy required the triage team to wheel us into two separate adjacent trauma bays—Bay 3 and Bay 4—divided by a heavy fabric privacy curtain while the ER nurses checked our spines and stuck cardiac monitor leads under our shirts. While we lay flat in our rigid foam cervical collars unable to sit up or hug, the Charge Nurse compromised by leaving a six-inch gap at the bottom of the curtain between our two bays so I could reach my right hand under the curtain hem and hold onto Katie's left hand while the monitors beeped overhead.

Second—and hardest of all—was the hospital's radiation safety rule at the CT scanner.

"Mr. Prairie, I know they ground themselves by holding hands, but federal radiation rules only allow one patient inside the CT scanner room at a time," the radiology tech explained gently when the orderlies arrived at two-twenty to wheel us down the hall for our head and cervical spine scans. "We'll scan Katie first while Nathaniel's gurney waits right outside the lead glass door with you, and then we'll swap them. They'll only be apart for five minutes each."

Letting go of Katie's fingers outside the heavy lead-lined doors of the CT suite while my own neck was strapped flat in a foam collar was the longest five minutes of my life. As the sliding door closed behind Katie's gurney, my heart rate monitor began to beep faster—until Dad stepped right up beside my stretcher, took my right hand in both of his warm palms, and stood where he could see through the control-room glass.

“I’m looking right at her through the window, Nate—she’s lying totally still inside the scanner ring and giving us a thumbs-up with her left hand,” Dad narrated calmly, squeezing my fingers until my breathing steadied. “Ninety more seconds and she’s coming right back out, and then I’ll watch you through the glass while Katie waits right here.”

True to his word, ten minutes later both of our CT scans were finished. By three-ten that afternoon, when the radiologist called down to confirm that neither Katie nor I had a skull fracture, concussion, or cervical spine injury, the ER trauma doctor unstrapped our foam cervical collars, the Charge Nurse pulled the dividing curtain between Bay 3 and Bay 4 all the way open, and the orderlies pushed our two hospital beds right up against each other with the inner side rails lowered.

The instant the beds locked together and the doctor raised the heads of our mattresses to forty-five degrees, Katie and I didn’t just hold hands—we leaned across the narrow seam between the two hospital mattresses and wrapped both of our arms tightly around each other’s shoulders in the long, deep grounding hug we had needed ever since we hit the hallway floor at school.

Seconds later, walking into the combined ER bay alongside the emergency physician was Dr. Evelyn Chen, wearing her white coat and carrying the thick manila lab folder from her clinic across the medical plaza.

“First things first—the head and cervical spine CT scans for both Nathaniel and Katie are completely clean,” Dr. Chen announced with a warm, relieved smile as Katie and I eased back against our pillows with our inner hands locked together between our beds and fresh ice packs resting against the matching goose eggs on our foreheads. “Nurse Callahan followed the exact right protocol calling EMS after a dual head strike on a concrete school floor, and thank goodness neither of you suffered a fracture or intracranial bleed.”

Then Dr. Chen stepped to the foot of our two ER beds and tested the reflexes and motor response in our knees, calves, and ankles.

Just like on the hallway floor outside Room 112 at Northwood High School, when she tapped our patellar tendons and asked us to lift our shins against her fingers, our lower legs didn’t budge.

Dr. Chen pulled a rolling stool up beside our two beds, opened the thick manila lab folder containing the genetic sequencing and nerve-conduction studies that had arrived from Norfolk that morning, and looked at Dad, Katie, and me with deep, solemn compassion.

“David, Nathaniel, Katie,” Dr. Chen said quietly, “two and a half weeks ago, when you came to see me the Monday morning after your cruise, I told you that Nathaniel and Katie’s legs were walking on borrowed time—and that they would eventually need power wheelchairs. We had scheduled your three o’clock checkup today to review these test results and talk about transitioning to powerchairs.”

She looked straight into my eyes, and then into Katie’s.

“What happened in the B-Wing hallway at Northwood High School at one-fifteen this afternoon wasn’t a temporary spell, and it wasn’t just end-of-the-week fatigue,” Dr. Chen said gently. “Your borrowed time is up. Neither of your legs can support your body weight anymore, and from this afternoon forward, neither of you can ever

try to stand or walk again—because trying to push yourselves up will only cause another collapse like the one that sent you to the Emergency Room today. It is officially time for powerchairs."

Even though Katie and I had known in our hearts from the second we reached for each other's hands on that linoleum floor that our walking days were over, hearing Dr. Chen say the words out loud made everything real. Beside me, Katie's fingers tightened around mine between our two hospital beds, and I squeezed her hand right back with everything I had.

"Tell us what the test results showed, Evelyn," Dad said steadily, standing right between our beds with one hand resting on my shoulder and the other on Katie's. "Why did their legs give out completely today, and what does it mean for their arms?"

"When you two were toddlers," Dr. Chen explained clearly, "your uneven balance was diagnosed as mild spastic diplegic cerebral palsy. Because mild CP is static and non-progressive—and because your mother always brushed off any new symptoms—nobody realized that your early balance issues were masking a second, genetic condition that both of you inherited as fraternal twins: a juvenile-onset progressive axonal motor neuropathy."

Dr. Chen pointed to the nerve-conduction graphs inside the folder.

"In this condition, the longest motor nerves in the body—the ones running from the lower spine down to the feet, ankles, calves, and quadriceps—lose their electrical signal amplitude first, and the sixteen-year-old adolescent growth spurt pushes those nerves past their threshold," Dr. Chen said. "Today at school, those lower-extremity motor nerves finally dropped below the threshold required to keep your knees locked upright. And as you both felt when you tried to push yourselves up off the hallway floor and crumpled the second time, the neuropathy is also causing progressive weakness in your shoulders, biceps, and forearms—which is why standard manual wheelchairs that you have to push with your hands are out of the question."

"What about our fingers, Dr. Chen?" Katie asked, her voice small but brave as she held onto my hand. "Are we still going to be able to type on our computers and write *Quantum Basic* code?"

Dr. Chen's face warmed with an immediate, reassuring smile.

"Yes, Katie—and that is the best news in your entire lab packet," Dr. Chen answered. "As long as we stop you from straining your shoulders and wrists trying to lift your body weight or push manual wheelchair rims, your fine finger dexterity at a keyboard will remain intact for years to come. You will both be able to type, write computer code, use a mouse, and hold hands—and with a fingertip joystick on your power wheelchair armrests, you'll be able to glide through Northwood High School all day without tiring your arms at all."

Dr. Chen pulled three prescription and accommodation forms from her folder and signed them right on the bedside tray table.

"First," Dr. Chen said, "I have signed an urgent hospital prescription for two SwiftChair compact, portable take-apart power wheelchairs—small-footprint motorized chairs with ten-inch drive wheels, right-hand armrest joysticks, and

removable battery boxes and seats that you can break down to fit inside the trunk of your sedan, David, along with a smooth composite transfer sliding board so Nathaniel and Katie can slide horizontally from their wheelchair seats onto the back seat of the car or onto their beds without ever putting weight on their legs. Second, Hospital Physical Therapy is bringing up two loaner wheelchairs and a transfer board right now so Dad can take you home safely tonight until the custom powerchairs are delivered in two weeks. And third, here is your updated Section 504 Plan for Northwood High School: elevator keys, duplicate classroom textbooks so you never lift a heavy bag, and full-time wheelchair access starting Monday morning."

Dad picked up the signed forms, then leaned down between our two hospital beds and wrapped one arm around Katie and one arm around me, kissing the top of Katie's head and then mine just above our bruised foreheads.

"I was never so scared in my life as when Mr. Brooks called me and said you two were headed to the Emergency Room," Dad whispered, his voice thick with emotion as he held us both close. "Wait until you see how fast I learn to break those two powerchairs down for the trunk of the car. Your legs may have run out of borrowed time today, but as long as the three of us have each other, nothing is going to stop you."

Part 3: Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk, Downsizing to Military Highway, & CVTA Route 15

Date: 2001-10-06 at 13:10 America/New_York

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:10 PM — Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk & Our New House off Military Highway

"Unclip the two under-seat battery boxes first, pull the quick-release pins to lift both padded seats off their posts, fold the backrests and footrests flat, and set the two compact motorized drive bases side by side in the trunk with two inches to spare under the hinges," Dad said with a proud grin on the first Saturday of October, wiping his brow as he demonstrated how both of our brand-new SwiftChair compact portable power wheelchairs broke down to fit inside the open trunk of our silver-blue Holt sedan.

Sitting side by side on the back bench seat of our Holt sedan with the rear passenger doors swung wide open to the concrete driveway of our new rental house and our inner hands clasped together, Katie and I watched Dad practice the disassembly routine he had timed with his wristwatch all morning.

Four days earlier, the seating clinic had delivered the two compact, take-apart power wheelchairs Dr. Chen had prescribed for us after our legs gave out for good in the hallway at Northwood High School—nimble, small-footprint power bases with ten-inch solid drive wheels, under-seat battery packs, and feather-light right-hand armrest joysticks that let us glide down the long corridors of school with a gentle nudge of one finger without ever straining our wrists or shoulders on manual hand rims. Because Dr. Chen had documented our progressive axonal motor neuropathy down to the millimeter, Dad's health insurance had covered ninety percent of the chairs.

What health insurance didn't cover, however, was a vehicle to carry them assembled.

A full-size conversion van equipped with a hydraulic wheelchair lift or fold-out side ramp cost upwards of thirty-five thousand dollars—an astronomical sum that might as well have been thirty-five million on Dad's tight budget. Between trying to finish his computer science degree at the Community College of Hampton Roads, losing Brenda's paycheck—meager as her income had been—and getting stuck with the crushing credit card debt from the seven-day Caribbean cruise that Brenda had booked behind his back, Dad was scraping by to make every dollar count.

Thankfully, because the seating clinic had ordered portable take-apart power chairs whose battery packs, seats, and drive bases separated into manageable thirty-five-pound components—and had supplied us with a smooth composite transfer sliding board that bridged the gap between the wheelchair seat and the back seat of our family Holt sedan—we could still get around by car without a lift van. Whenever we drove somewhere, Katie and I would roll our compact power chairs right up to the open rear passenger door, switch off our joysticks, flip up the inner armrest, and slide horizontally across the transfer board onto the back bench seat with Dad's steadying hands before buckling our three-point seatbelts while Dad broke both chairs down like a pit crew and loaded the bases, battery boxes, and folded seats into the trunk.

Even so, Dad had been completely honest with Katie and me around the kitchen table two weeks earlier when he opened his budget ledger.

Without a second income—and with the cruise credit card bill and legal fees hanging over our heads—we couldn't afford the mortgage on our old two-story house anymore. More importantly, even if we could have paid for it, our old house had fourteen steep wooden stairs leading up to the bedrooms and the only full bathroom—stairs that neither Katie nor I could ever climb again now that the borrowed time in our legs had run out.

So Dad had put the two-story house up for sale—using the modest equity to wipe out Brenda's cruise debt completely—and spent every evening for two weeks poring over rental listings, Virginia Beach school-zone boundary maps, and printed bus schedules from the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority.

What Dad found was a stroke of pure logistical genius: a small, single-story brick ranch house for rent on a quiet side street just off Military Highway near the Indian River Road intersection, right where Virginia Beach met Norfolk and Chesapeake.

First, the rent was nearly four hundred dollars a month less than our old mortgage, bringing our monthly bills comfortably inside Dad's budget while he finished school at CCHR. Second, every single room in the little house—the living room, the eat-in kitchen, the hallway bathroom with its roll-up sink and shower transfer bench, and both bedrooms—sat on one flat ground floor, with a gentle aluminum ramp Dad had bolted over the two brick front porch steps. Third, because the house sat just inside the western edge of Northwood High School's zoned attendance boundary, Katie and I didn't have to change high schools in the middle of our Junior year, and a lift-equipped Virginia Beach school bus could pick us up right at the end of our driveway every weekday morning.

And fourth—the detail Dad was proudest of as he reassembled our two compact power wheelchairs beside the open rear doors of the car, locked the seats onto their posts, and dropped the battery boxes back into place—was what ran right along the massive eight-lane corridor of US-13 (Military Highway) at the end of our block.

“Slide back into your chairs and let’s head out to the corner on Military Highway before the one-twenty-five bus gets here,” Dad said, closing the trunk lid of the Holt sedan, helping Katie and me slide across the transfer board from the back seat into our waiting power chairs, and holding up a yellow-highlighted paper pamphlet folded in his hand. “Since Route 15 stays strictly out on Military Highway and doesn’t turn into the neighborhood streets, I want to show you two how fast we can get out to the main road without having to break your power chairs down at all.”

Clicking our lap belts shut and flipping our armrests back down, Katie and I pressed the green power buttons on our armrest joysticks and hummed side by side down the smooth concrete sidewalk behind Dad. In less than three minutes, we turned the corner from our quiet residential block onto the wide sidewalk bordering Military Highway and Indian River Road, where four lanes of northbound traffic and four lanes of southbound traffic roared past a raised center median.

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:25 PM — Catching CVTA Route 15 on Eight-Lane Military Highway

“Look at the timetable right here under Military Hwy. & Indian River Rd.,” Dad said over the steady hum of eight-lane highway traffic as the three of us stopped beside the metal bus stop post in the crisp October sunshine, unfolding the printed **CVTA Route 15 — *Naval Base Norfolk / Robert Hall Blvd.*** schedule so both Katie and I could read it.

Holding Katie’s left hand with my right hand between our two compact power wheelchairs, I leaned in with my sister to follow the yellow highlighter line Dad had drawn across the grid of numbers.

“Wait a second,” Katie said, her eyes widening as she traced the columns from left to right. “It runs every thirty minutes all day Monday through Saturday?”

“Like clockwork,” Dad smiled, tapping each column with his index finger. “Going northbound up Military Highway, Route 15 stops right across the highway at Military Highway and Indian River Road at :01 and :31 past every hour from six-thirty-one in the morning until six-thirty-one at night, and then once an hour until ten-thirty-one. In exactly fourteen minutes—at :15 and :45 past the hour—it drops you right at the doors of Glenrock Mall, where you can transfer to Routes 20, 23, 25, or 27, or stay right on Route 15 past Glenrock Shopping Center, Little Creek Road, and Hampton Boulevard all the way to Naval Base Norfolk.”

“And what about going southbound on our side of the road?” I asked, looking at the lower table where Dad had highlighted two alternating rows in yellow and green.

“That’s the best part,” Dad said, pointing to the bold route note printed across the center of the timetable: *On arrival at Old Emerald Creek Rd. and Military Hwy., every other trip will alternate between Robert Hall and Emerald Creek Mall Monday through Saturday.* “Southbound buses leave Glenrock Mall at :15 and :45 past the hour and get right here to Military Highway and Indian River Road ten minutes later, at :25 and :55 past every hour. Every bus that stops here at :25 past the

hour—like the 1:25 PM bus coming down the right-hand lane right now—turns onto the Emerald Creek Mall branch and puts us at the mall entrance twenty minutes later at 1:45 PM. And every bus that stops here at :55 past the hour goes straight down to Robert Hall Boulevard and Tidewater Square by :15 past the next hour."

Right on cue, signaling across the four southbound lanes of US-13 (Military Highway) toward our curb was one of the classic forty-foot high-floor workhorses of the fleet: a 900-series Beacon V transit bus (Fleet #914) that operated alongside the agency's high-floor MetroCoach buses. Because Tidewater Regional Transit (TRT) on the Southside and Peninsula Transit (PenTran) across the harbor had only merged two years earlier in October 1999 to form the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority (CVTA), Bus #914 was still wearing its original 1990s TRT paint scheme—a crisp white body banded with horizontal navy-blue and green stripes down its flanks—with a rectangular CVTA logo vinyl decal sticker applied right next to the front boarding doors below the *15 EMERALD CREEK MALL* destination sign.

As Bus #914 hissed to a stop parallel to the concrete curb, the bi-fold front doors swung open. Because the 900-series Beacon V was a true high-floor bus whose main passenger deck sat three full feet above the street at the top of a three-step stairwell, there was no sloped ramp. Instead, standing high up on the elevated driver's platform, the uniformed operator pulled the parking brake knob, flipped up the two forward priority benches behind the driver's area, and switched on the Elevate-U electro-hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift.

"Afternoon, folks! Welcome aboard The 15," the operator called down warmly from the elevated doorway as the three deep front steps flattened into a level horizontal steel elevator platform, telescoped outward on twin vertical hydraulic lift arms with yellow-and-black tubular side handrails, and lowered straight down to rest flat on the concrete sidewalk before dropping the yellow outer safety barrier flap flush against the curb. "Come on onto the elevator platform one at a time—I've got both wheelchair bays folded up and ready for you!"

Katie and I glanced at each other with identical grins. Nobody had to struggle with a car transfer, and Dad didn't have to unclip battery boxes or lift thirty-five-pound power-chair bases into a trunk. Giving Katie's hand a quick squeeze before letting go for thirty seconds, I nudged my right-hand joystick forward and rolled my compact power chair onto the flat horizontal steel platform between the two side handrails first; the outer yellow safety barrier flipped up behind my rear wheels to lock me in, the twin vertical hydraulic arms raised my chair straight up three feet in the air like an elevator to the high interior floor of Bus #914, and I backed neatly into the right-hand securement bay. Seconds later, the elevator platform lowered straight back down to the sidewalk for Katie and lifted her power chair right up to the high deck across the aisle from me before folding seamlessly back into three staircase steps so Dad could climb up into the bus and drop our fares into the farebox.

Once the operator had clicked the four-point floor straps onto both of our power-chair frames, the front doors hissed shut and Bus #914 merged back into the four southbound lanes of Military Highway.

Across the center aisle of the high-floor bus, Katie reached her left hand out over her armrest, and I reached my right hand out to meet hers, our fingers lacing together in the warm afternoon sunlight streaming through the tall transit windows.

“We don’t need a thirty-five-thousand-dollar van to go wherever we want, Nate,” Katie said softly over the deep diesel rumble of the Beacon V engine as we cruised south toward Emerald Creek Mall. “Between the school bus on weekdays, breaking our chairs down for the trunk of Dad’s car, and Route 15 out on Military Highway at the end of our block, we’ve got the whole city back.”

“And a house with zero stairs,” I agreed, squeezing my sister’s hand as Dad smiled at the two of us from the seat beside her. “We’re going to be just fine.”

Sixteen on Four Wheels & Finding Dates

Part 1: Navigating Northwood High on Four Wheels, Two First Dates, & Why We Ride on Saturday

Date: 2001-10-15 at 07:10 America/New_York

Monday, October 15, 2001, 7:10 AM — Rolling the “Blue Mile” & The Brass Elevator Key

“Keep your speed dial on two until we clear the Commons tiles, Nate, or the vibration is going to rattle our teeth right out of our heads,” Katie said with a wry smile on Monday morning as the two of us rolled our compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs through the pinned-open double fire doors of Northwood High School.

Beneath our ten-inch solid drive wheels, the textured quarry tiles of the Northwood High Commons buzzed like a washboard before giving way to the smooth, polished linoleum of the main academic corridor everyone called the “Blue Mile.”

It was the start of our second full week navigating eleventh grade on four wheels instead of two feet, and physically, the difference was like night and day.

Back in September, walking from the morning bus loop to first period had left our calves cramping, our knees trembling, and our shoulders aching from the weight of our backpacks before the first bell even rang. Now, thanks to the Section 504 Medical Mobility Plan that Dr. Chen had signed and Dad had walked into the principal’s office, neither Katie nor I carried a single textbook between classes. A duplicate set of our Junior-year textbooks sat on a designated shelf in each of our classrooms, and clipped to our lanyard ID badges alongside our house keys were two shiny brass Vanguard Elevator keys issued by the school custodian.

Socially, however, showing up to your Junior year of high school in matching power wheelchairs was like dropping a boulder into the middle of a swimming pool.

As Katie and I glided side by side down the right-hand lane of the Blue Mile with our right index fingers resting lightly on our armrest joysticks, the noisy wall of lockers ahead of us reacted the exact same way it had all last week. Conversations dropped to sudden, awkward whispers as we rolled past. Kids who had known us since sixth grade either stared straight down at their sneakers as if looking at a power wheelchair might be rude, or leaped three feet out of our path against the lockers as though we were driving runaway forklifts.

When we reached the B-Wing stairwell at the end of the hall—where two hundred students were jostling up the concrete steps toward the second floor—I pulled my brass key on its retractable lanyard reel, inserted it into the keyhole beside the heavy gray door of the school's service elevator, and turned it clockwise.

With a slow mechanical clunk, the sliding metal door rattled open, releasing the familiar scent of lemon floor wax and damp mop buckets. Katie and I rolled our compact power chairs straight inside side by side, and as the door slid shut, sealing out the roar of the stairwell, Katie reached her left hand across the two inches between our armrests and laced her fingers through mine.

"Did you see Todd Jenkins jump into the water fountain alcove when we turned the corner by the trophy case?" I asked as the old hydraulic elevator groaned upward toward the second floor at roughly half a mile an hour.

"He nearly knocked his own varsity jacket off his shoulder," Katie laughed, squeezing my hand as the floor indicator light blinked from 1 to 2. "Remind me again why we used to be afraid of using this elevator?"

"Because we didn't know how nice it was to get to second period without our legs shaking," I said honestly as the elevator chimed and the door rattled open onto the upstairs landing. "See you at eleven-forty at our table?"

"Count on it," Katie smiled, giving my hand one last squeeze before we released our fingers and steered in opposite directions down the hall—Katie toward first-period U.S. History, and me toward first-period English.

Monday, October 15, 2001, 11:45 AM — Head Over Heels for Heather & Katie's Guarded Heart

"You were smiling all the way from the milk cooler to the table, Nate," Katie teased gently four hours later as the two of us parked our compact power wheelchairs side by side at the open end of our sunlit corner cafeteria table and clicked our joystick motors off. "Let me guess: Heather Collins sat next to you in second-period Computer Lab again?"

I felt my ears turn warm all the way to the tips as I set my brown paper lunch bag beside our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook.

"She moved her chair right next to my power chair for the whole ninety-minute block," I admitted, unable to keep the grin off my face as I poked Katie's straw into her apple juice box for her and handed it across our armrests. "When everybody else in the row stepped around my wheelchair like it was radioactive, Heather didn't even blink. She showed me wallet photos of her family, helped me pick a color palette for our *Quantum Basic* menu screen, and asked if I wanted to sit with her at the computer table every day this semester."

The truth was, I wasn't just crushing on Heather Collins—at sixteen years old, I was completely, head-over-heels in love with her. From the first week of Junior year in Room 204, Heather had treated me with a warm, effortless kindness that made my heart race every time she walked through the classroom door.

Beside me, Katie took a sip of her juice box, her expression softening with genuine happiness for me before a quieter, more thoughtful look crossed her face.

“What about Ryan Miller in third-period Chemistry?” I asked, reaching my right hand across the gap between our chairs to take Katie’s left hand on the laminate tabletop. “You said on Friday that he kept leaning across the lab bench to talk to you.”

“He did again today,” Katie said, though her voice was noticeably more reserved than mine. Ever since seventh grade—when Brandon had dumped her in the middle of the hallway and left her sobbing beneath the blue butterfly in her bedroom—Katie had kept a careful, protective wall around her heart when it came to boys. “Actually, while we were cleaning up our beakers at the accessible lab sink, Ryan asked if I wanted to go out with him to Emerald Creek Mall this weekend. And he asked if you had a girlfriend you wanted to bring along so we could make it a double date.”

My breath caught in my throat. Neither Katie nor I had ever been on a real high-school date before. Before our legs gave out in September and we got our compact power wheelchairs, Katie and I had gone to both Emerald Creek Mall and Chesapeake Bay Mall all the time—with Chesapeake Bay Mall out on Lynnhaven Parkway always being our favorite “big trip” mall (which we still hadn’t visited yet since getting our powerchairs), and Emerald Creek Mall becoming our favorite regular teenage hangout because we only needed to ride a single bus from Military Highway to get there.

“Wait—what did you tell him?” I asked.

“I told him I’d talk to you at lunch first,” Katie said carefully, her fingers tightening around mine. “Honestly, Nate, I don’t know about Ryan. He’s nice enough when we’re lab partners, but I can’t tell if he actually likes *me* or if he just likes having someone who balances his chemical equations for him. Still… I see the way your whole face lights up whenever you talk about Heather. And if we go together as a double date on Saturday afternoon, neither one of us has to go through our first high-school date alone.”

“Why Saturday specifically?” I asked, glancing at the calendar inside my binder.

“Because I checked Dad’s printed CVTA Route 15 schedule on the refrigerator this morning,” Katie explained, tapping the timetable notes she had copied into the margin of our notebook. “Remember the alternating branch rule at Old Emerald Creek Road and Military Highway? Route 15 only serves Emerald Creek Mall Monday through Saturday. On Sundays, every single trip runs straight down to Robert Hall Boulevard and skips Emerald Creek Mall completely. So if we want to take the bus to the mall ourselves, it has to be on Saturday.”

“Then let’s do Saturday,” I said earnestly, squeezing her hand so she knew my promise from seventh grade hadn’t changed one bit. “I’ll ask Heather in Computer Lab on Wednesday morning, and you tell Ryan we’ll meet them at the Emerald Creek Mall upstairs food court at twelve-forty-five on Saturday. And Katie—if Ryan acts weird for even one second, you and I have our bus fare in our pockets and each other right beside us.”

Wednesday, October 17, 2001, 10:05 AM — Two Very Different Reactions

“A Saturday afternoon double date at Emerald Creek Mall with you and Katie?” Heather Collins repeated on Wednesday morning in second-period Computer Lab, her warm hazel eyes lighting up with an immediate, genuine smile that made my chest feel weightless. “I would love to, Nate! How are you and Katie getting over to Emerald Creek?”

“We live right near Military Highway and Indian River Road now, so we’re taking CVTA Route 15 at twelve-twenty-five,” I explained honestly, bracing myself just in case a high-school girl thought riding the city bus on a first date was uncool. “The high-floor bus has a hydraulic wheelchair lift in the front stairwell, so Katie and I can roll our power chairs right aboard together without Dad having to break them down for the trunk of his car.”

Heather didn’t flinch or look embarrassed for a fraction of a second. Instead, her smile grew even warmer.

“That is so smart—my dad can drop me off at the main mall entrance at twelve-forty, and I’ll ride the back glass elevator right up to the second-floor food court to meet you and Katie,” Heather said brightly, reaching over to touch the sleeve of my flannel shirt. “I can’t wait for Saturday, Nate.”

Two hours later at Fourth-Block lunch, however, when Katie rolled up to the corner table and parked beside me, I could see immediately from the tight set of her jaw that her conversation with Ryan Miller in third-period Chemistry had gone very differently.

“Ryan agreed to meet us at twelve-forty-five on Saturday,” Katie said quietly, unwrapping her sandwich and taking my right hand across the table, “but we didn’t even make it out of the Chemistry lab before he got weird about two things.”

“What did he say?” I asked, frowning.

“First, when I told him we were meeting at Emerald Creek Mall, Ryan puffed his chest out and said, *‘Oh, I’ll drive over to your house in my coupe and pick you up—just fold your wheelchair up and throw it in my trunk,’*” Katie recounted, shaking her head in disbelief. “I tried to explain to him twice that a motorized power wheelchair with a battery box and solid drive wheels doesn’t just fold flat like an umbrella stroller, and that even if Dad disassembled it into four pieces, it wouldn’t fit inside a two-door sports coupe.”

“And what was the second thing?” I asked.

“When I told him that you and I were riding CVTA Route 15 to the mall together because we always travel as a pair,” Katie said, her blue eyes steady and guarded as she looked at me, “Ryan frowned and said, *‘Wait—you’re bringing your brother on the bus instead of riding with me? Don’t you ever go anywhere without Nate?’* I looked him straight in the eye and told him, *‘No, Ryan. Nate is my twin brother, and he comes first.’* He backed down and said he’d meet us at the food court at twelve-forty-five, but… I have a feeling Saturday is going to be a very short test for Ryan Miller.”

Part 2: Cousin Wesley, Ryan's Escalator Exit, & Two Dates at Emerald Creek Mall

Date: 2001-10-20 at 12:45 America/New_York

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 12:45 PM — The Second-Floor Food Court & Cousin Wesley

"Nate! Katie! You guys made it right on time!" Heather Collins called out with a radiant smile at twelve-forty-five on Saturday afternoon, waiting for us on the terracotta-tile landing right outside the brushed-brass sliding doors of the freestanding early-1980s glass elevator on the main retail concourse—its warm cream-colored corner columns framing multi-pane glass and topped with a small glass pyramid cap beneath the white steel roof trusses—right where the elevator connected the first floor of the main concourse up to the second-floor food court wing of Emerald Creek Mall.

Twenty minutes earlier, Dad had walked with us out to the corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road, pressed a twenty-dollar bill into each of our hands, and waved from the sidewalk as Katie and I rode the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift aboard the 12:25 PM Saturday southbound CVTA Route 15 (Bus #914). Right on schedule at 12:45 PM, the high-floor Beacon V bus had dropped us off at the bus stop on the mall's outer ring road, straight across the parking lot from the first-floor exterior entrance of Wellington's, the two-story anchor department store at the end of the wing. Rolling side by side from the ring road through the ground-floor cosmetics and apparel aisles of Wellington's into the first-floor main concourse, Katie and I had stepped right into the glass-backed scenic elevator directly in front of the department store's mall entrance and ridden it up to the second floor.

Before I could even click my joystick speed dial down to one on the upper landing, Heather stepped straight up to my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair, leaned down without a trace of hesitation, and wrapped her arms around my shoulders in a warm hello hug that sent my heart soaring into the skylights.

"Hi, Nate," Heather said softly against my cheek before straightening up and smiling just as warmly at my twin sister. "And hi, Katie! My dad dropped me off at the lower Wellington's entrance and I rode the glass elevator right up here from the first-floor concourse so we could roll into the food court wing together—and whenever we go downstairs to browse the lower level, I'm riding the elevator right alongside you two."

"Thanks for waiting for us by the elevator, Heather," Katie said, her guarded posture relaxing noticeably at how naturally Heather included both of us and had zero problem being seen riding the mall elevator with two kids in wheelchairs.

Turning 180 degrees away from the glass elevator and the two-story interior entrance of Wellington's behind us on the main retail concourse, the three of us rolled straight into the bustling second-floor food court wing—where the high white tented fabric canopy ceiling and skylights echoed with weekend chatter, the far exterior glass exit doors at the back of the wing opened straight out onto the graded upper section of the mall parking lot that gently sloped up to the second-floor level,

and Bobby Vanguard's 1982 synth-pop classic *"Moving Up the Escalator"* drifted down from the PA speakers above the food court escalators—just as Ryan Miller strolled over from the brass-and-glass mezzanine railing in his letterman jacket.

Unlike Heather, Ryan didn't look thrilled to see our two compact power wheelchairs rolling side by side.

"Hey," Ryan said, glancing down at Katie's motorized drive wheels as we picked a four-top table positioned right on the tile concourse between the two central escalators—with the up escalator rising from the first floor on Katie's and my side, and the down escalator descending to the first floor on Heather's and Ryan's side—and pulled two plastic chairs away so Katie and I could park our power chairs side by side facing Ryan and Heather. "Katie, I still don't get why you made me meet you here instead of letting me pick you up in my car. You seriously couldn't just fold that chair up and stick it in my trunk?"

"Ryan, I told you on Wednesday—it's a power wheelchair," Katie replied evenly, tapping the black battery box beneath her seat. "It has electric motors and heavy batteries. It doesn't fold up like a beach chair, and Nate and I ride Route 15 together."

Ryan let out a loud, skeptical sigh, slumping into his seat across from Katie as Heather and I brought back our lunch trays from Crown Burger and Annie's Pretzels.

Halfway from the counter to the table, the progressive neuropathy weakness in my left forearm flared under the weight of the plastic food tray. My left wrist trembled, tipping my large cola cup toward the edge of the tray. Instantly—without me having to say a single word—Katie glided her power chair half a foot to her right, slid her left hand under the corner of my tray to steady it onto the table, pinched open the paper wrapper on my straw, and laced her left fingers through my right hand between our armrests while my wrist tremor settled.

Across the table, Ryan stared at our joined hands as if we had just committed a felony.

"Are you kidding me right now, Katie?" Ryan snapped, setting his burger down on its wrapper and leaning forward across the table. "First you refuse to ride in my car unless your brother comes along, and now you're sitting here holding his hand and opening his straw while you're supposed to be on a date with *me*? Who's number one here—me or your brother?"

The noisy food court seemed to fade into background static around our table. Beside me, Katie didn't flinch, and she didn't let go of my hand.

"Nate is number one in my life, Ryan," Katie said clearly, looking him straight in the eyes. "He is my twin brother. We've been through everything together, and he is always going to come first."

Ryan scoffed, his face flushing red as he turned toward Heather next to him, clearly expecting her to back him up. "Heather, are you seeing this? Doesn't it bother you that your date is sitting here holding his sister's hand and acting like they're glued together?"

Heather looked at Ryan with calm, unmistakable steel in her hazel eyes—and then reached across the tabletop to lay her right hand warmly over my left hand.

“No, Ryan, it doesn’t bother me one bit,” Heather said firmly. “In fact, I love how close Nate and Katie are.”

Ryan blinked at her. “What? Why?”

“Because my fourteen-year-old cousin Wesley—my mom’s sister’s son—is severely developmentally disabled,” Heather explained, her voice steady and proud as she looked from Ryan to Katie and me. “Wesley and I grew up together, and whenever the two of us go anywhere, I hold Wesley’s hand, I hug him, and we look out for each other the exact same way Nate and Katie do. If I ever screamed at Nate or got jealous of him for holding his twin sister’s hand and hugging her, I would be disrespecting the exact relationship I have with Wesley.”

Heather turned her gaze back to me, her eyes shining with so much warmth and affection that my throat went tight.

“I knew before I ever said yes on Wednesday that Nate and Katie travel as a pair,” Heather continued softly. “And watching the way they take care of each other only makes me love Nate more.”

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 1:20 PM — Ryan’s Escalator Exit & “Did You Bring Two Dates?”

Ryan stared from Heather to Katie and me, his ego visibly bruised beyond repair as he realized neither girl at the table was going to bend to him.

“Whatever,” Ryan muttered bitterly, shoving his plastic food-court chair back across the quarry tile and standing up. “If I wanted to play second fiddle to your twin brother and a pair of wheelchairs all afternoon, I would’ve stayed home. Have fun riding the city bus, Katie.”

Heather, Katie, and I watched in silence as Ryan snatched his jacket off the back of his chair.

Beside me, Katie kept her chin up, but I felt the slight tremor in her left hand where her fingers were still laced with mine, and I saw the hurt glistening at the corners of her blue eyes. Even though Katie had stayed guarded with Ryan all week—and even though part of her had figured from the start that this wouldn’t work—having a boy walk out on her in the middle of a crowded food court still stung.

And then Ryan did something that turned my blood to ice.

Because our table sat right between the two central escalators—with the up escalator on Katie’s and my side, the down escalator right on Heather’s and Ryan’s side, and the glass elevator back behind us—the entrance to the down escalator was to Ryan’s immediate right as he stood up from his chair. Instead of walking back toward the elevator or the upper-level parking-lot doors, Ryan turned to look directly at Katie sitting in her compact power wheelchair, took two steps to his immediate right, and stepped deliberately onto the moving metal steps of the down escalator—riding it

down to the first floor in a massive, calculated show of disrespect because he knew Katie's disability made it physically impossible for her to follow him down those stairs.

As the top of Ryan's head sank below the second-floor floorplate on the escalator, a long, quiet breath left Katie's lips.

"I kind of figured before we even got off the bus today that it wouldn't work with him," Katie admitted quietly, blinking back the moisture in her eyes as she looked down at her lap belt. "Still… taking the escalator just to rub it in that I can't follow him was pretty low."

"It wasn't just low, Katie—it was disgusting, and he didn't deserve five minutes of your time," Heather said immediately, stepping around the corner of the table to rest a gentle, supportive hand on Katie's shoulder while I squeezed Katie's left hand with everything I had. "And we are *not* letting him ruin our Saturday. Come on—finish your pretzels, and let's the three of us go walk the second floor of the mall together!"

Katie looked up at Heather in surprise, then glanced at me.

"You're sure you don't mind me tagging along on your date, Heather?" Katie asked softly.

"Are you kidding? You're not tagging along—we're a team today," Heather smiled warmly.

Ten minutes later, after we cleared our trays, the three of us rolled out of the food court and into the wide, sunlit second-floor concourse of Emerald Creek Mall. I rolled down the center of the polished terrazzo walkway in my compact power chair, with Katie rolling right beside my left armrest holding my left hand, and Heather walking right beside my right armrest holding my right hand.

Halfway past the Oak & Iron Outfitters and The Literary Alcove upper-level windows, three guys from our Junior-year History and English classes at Northwood High School—Marcus, Devon, and Chris—came walking out of the music store carrying CD bags.

None of the three had ever had a class with Katie and me at the same time, so they had no idea Katie was my twin sister—and as their eyes landed on me rolling down the mall in my power wheelchair flanked by two pretty sixteen-year-old girls holding both of my hands, all three of them stopped dead in their tracks.

Marcus grinned from ear to ear and gave me an impressed salute.

"Whoa, Prairie—save some for the rest of us, man!" Marcus laughed, nudging Devon's elbow as they walked past. "Did you seriously bring *two* dates to Emerald Creek Mall today?!"

For one second, Heather, Katie, and I blinked at each other—and then all three of us burst out laughing so hard that every bit of the sadness Ryan had left behind vanished into the vaulted ceiling of the mall.

“Tell them yes, Nate!” Heather giggled, squeezing my right hand as Katie laughed beside us. “Let the whole eleventh grade think you’re the smoothest guy at Northwood High!”

“With the two prettiest girls in Virginia Beach on either side of my chair,” I grinned, looking from Katie’s bright, restored smile on my left to Heather’s glowing face on my right, “I’m definitely not correcting them.”

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 2:40 PM — A Hug for Me, A Handshake for Katie, & Route 15 Home

We spent the next hour browsing the second-floor music and book aisles at The Literary Alcove together before riding the freestanding glass-enclosed elevator down to the first-floor main concourse at two-forty and rolling out through the first-floor entrance of Wellington’s toward the ring road so Katie and I could catch the 2:48 PM northbound CVTA Route 15 bus back up Military Highway.

Just outside the automatic sliding glass doors in the crisp October sunshine, Heather’s father pulled up to the pickup curb in his burgundy sedan and gave a friendly wave through the windshield. Fifty feet down the wide concrete sidewalk, the blue-and-yellow CVTA bus stop sign stood waiting for the 2:48 PM bus.

Stopping beside us on the sidewalk, Heather turned to me first. Bending down in front of my power chair, she wrapped both arms warmly around my neck and hugged me close, her cheek pressing against mine for a long, unhurried moment.

“Today was the best first date I’ve ever had, Nate,” Heather whispered in my ear before pulling back with a bright smile. “Same computer table on Monday morning?”

“Same computer table on Monday morning,” I promised, my face glowing.

Then Heather turned to Katie’s power wheelchair right beside mine. Instead of giving a polite wave from a distance, Heather stepped squarely in front of my twin sister, met Katie’s blue eyes with genuine warmth and respect, and extended her right hand.

“It was really great hanging out with you today, Katie,” Heather said earnestly. “Next Saturday, maybe the three of us can bring my cousin Wesley along and get pretzels together.”

Katie looked at Heather’s outstretched hand, and a real, unguarded smile broke across my sister’s face as she reached out with her right hand and shook Heather’s hand warmly.

“I’d really like that, Heather,” Katie said. “See you at school on Monday.”

We watched from the sidewalk as Heather climbed into the front passenger seat of her father’s car and waved out the window until the sedan merged onto the ring road. As soon as her dad’s car turned the corner, Katie and I steered our compact power wheelchairs side by side down the sidewalk to the CVTA Route 15 bus stop and laced our inner hands together while we waited for the 2:48 PM high-floor Beacon V bus to round the loop.

“Well,” I said quietly, looking over at my twin sister as the familiar white bus with its horizontal blue-and-green TRT stripes and CVTA door sticker signaled toward our curb, “one out of two first dates wasn’t bad.”

“Are you kidding, Nate?” Katie smiled, squeezing my hand as the bus pulled up and the operator switched on the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift. “Finding out in twenty minutes that Ryan was a jerk—and finding out that Heather loves you *and* gets us completely because of her cousin Wesley? I’d call that a hundred percent success.”

Seventeen & Senior Year

Drunken New Year

Part 1: The Gas-Station Run, A Box of Dry Cereal, & Why I Never Had a Twenty-First Birthday Drink

Date: 2002-12-31 at 21:30 America/New_York

Tuesday, December 31, 2002, 9:30 PM — The Broken Ground Rules & The Gas-Station Run

“Brittany, Dad and Aunt Liz laid down the ground rules before they walked out that front door—nobody is allowed over here tonight, and there is zero alcohol allowed in this house!” I said sharply at nine-thirty on New Year’s Eve, sitting in my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair in the front hallway beside Katie’s chair as our seventeen-year-old cousin Brittany pulled the front door open to the cold December night.

Tonight was supposed to be simple, quiet, and safe.

It was Tuesday, December 31, 2002—the middle of our Senior year at Northwood High School, just over three months before Katie and I would turn eighteen on April 8. Ever since the Friday afternoon in September of our Junior year when the borrowed time in our legs had finally run out in the hallway at school, both Katie and I had used our compact power wheelchairs full-time from the moment we woke up until we went to bed at night.

Because Grandma had come down with a bad winter bronchitis over Christmas and couldn’t travel on the ARTS train, Dad, our Aunt Elizabeth, and our older cousin Chelsea had driven across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel to Newport News at seven o’clock that evening to check on Grandma, drop off her prescriptions, and have a quiet New Year’s Eve dinner with her before driving back after midnight. Meanwhile, our seventeen-year-old cousin Brittany—who was staying over at our house for the second half of winter break—had stayed behind in Virginia Beach with Katie and me. Before Dad and Aunt Liz left with Chelsea, they had stood right in the center of our living room and laid down the law to the three of us: the front door was

to stay deadbolted, nobody was allowed inside the house, and Katie, Brittany, and I were supposed to spend New Year's Eve eating pizza, drinking sparkling apple cider, and watching the Times Square ball drop together on television.

Instead, the second Dad's Holt sedan had turned onto Military Highway, Brittany had picked up the cordless kitchen phone.

Now, standing on our aluminum front porch ramp in the porch light were five teenagers Brittany had met earlier that week—along with a tall, scruffy twenty-one-year-old guy named Derek who had just used his vertical driver's license to do a run to the corner gas station out on Military Highway, carrying two heavy plastic grocery bags clinking with glass bottles and cardboard twelve-packs.

"Oh, chill out, Nate—don't be such a pair of babies," Brittany scoffed, waving Derek and the other four kids past our wheelchairs into our small living room. "Uncle David and Aunt Liz won't be back from Grandma's in Newport News until one in the morning. We'll throw the empties in the outside trash bin before midnight and nobody will ever know unless you two snitch."

"This isn't your house, Brittany, it's ours!" Katie said firmly, her left hand reaching across our armrests to grip my right hand as Derek dumped the plastic bags onto our kitchen counter with a loud crash of bottles. "Our dad works his tail off to pay the rent on this place, and we don't want strangers drinking in our living room!"

"Well, they're already here, and Derek already spent forty bucks at the gas station," Brittany shot back, grabbing two plastic cups from the dish rack as one of her friends cranked the volume knob on our living-room stereo up until the bass rattled the window blinds. "If you two don't want to party, go play on your computers in your room and leave us alone."

Tuesday, December 31, 2002, 11:15 PM — Hiding Behind a Locked Bedroom Door

By eleven-fifteen that night, our living room had devolved into a loud, sour-smelling war zone.

Katie and I had stayed near the hallway threshold as long as we could to make sure nobody broke Dad's things, but as the gas-station bottles emptied over the next ninety minutes, Brittany's guests turned into every kind of drunk at once.

Over on the living-room sofa, one boy in a hooded sweatshirt was already passed out cold with his mouth open and an empty can rolling across the carpet beneath his sneakers, while a girl beside him was slumped sideways over the armrest, half-conscious and groaning that the room was spinning. Near the kitchen doorway, Derek and another guy in a baseball cap had turned mean and belligerent—shouting profanities inches from each other's faces and shoving kitchen chairs out of the way in an angry argument over who owed whom ten dollars for the gas-station run. And right in the middle of the rug, Brittany and her friend Jenna were completely loopy—stumbling into the coffee table, slurring every third word, and cackling at the top of their lungs as they spilled sticky soda and liquor across the floor.

For Katie and me, the smell of stale alcohol drifting down the hallway and the sound of angry, slurred shouting inside our own home hit every raw nerve left behind by our mother on the cruise ship sixteen months earlier.

When Derek slammed his palm against the kitchen wall so hard that the framed family photos in the hallway crooked on their nails, Katie looked at me with wide eyes and gripped my wrist.

“Nate, I don’t want to be out here near them anymore,” Katie whispered over the roar of the stereo and the shouting. “If Derek or that other guy trips over our wheelchairs while they’re fighting, neither of us can stand up to get out of the way.”

“Grab that unopened box of dry cereal off the lower pantry shelf so we have food for the rest of the night and don’t have to come back out here,” I told her immediately, snagging two cans of ginger ale on my lap tray while Katie tucked the family-size box of toasted oat cereal onto her lap. “We’re locking ourselves in your room until Dad gets back.”

As we backed our two compact power wheelchairs down the short hallway toward Katie’s bedroom at the back corner of the house, one of Brittany’s guests—a loudmouth senior from Northwood High named Tyler who had been chugging out of a plastic cup by the stereo—spotted us retreating and stumbled down the hall after us.

“Hey! Where do you two think you’re rolling off to?” Tyler slurred, thrusting a red plastic cup toward my face as I steered Katie inside the bedroom ahead of me. “Come on, Prairie, stop acting like you’re too good for the rave and take a drink!”

“We don’t drink, Tyler—stay out of our hallway,” I told him flatly.

Before Tyler could take another step, I backed my power chair across the threshold into Katie’s bedroom, swung the solid wooden bedroom door shut right in his flushed, angry face, twisted the brass privacy lock until it clicked, and wedged the heavy rubber doorstop beneath the bottom gap.

On the other side of the oak panel, Tyler banged his fist twice against the door and yelled spitefully over the bass of the stereo, *“Fine, lock yourselves in a bedroom all night, you stuck-up losers! See if anybody cares!”*

For good measure, once Katie and I used our armrests to transfer onto the edge of her bed side by side beneath the framed blue butterfly print from our old house, I used my joystick to inch my fifty-pound power wheelchair right up against the inside of the doorknob like a steel roadblock.

Even through the closed door, we could still hear the muffled thudding of boots, the angry shouting from the kitchen, and the loopy, off-key shrieking from the living room.

Pulling Katie’s green-and-gold quilt around both of our shoulders, I opened the top flaps of the cardboard cereal box between us so we had handfuls of dry cereal to munch on for dinner, switched the small thirteen-inch television on her dresser to the GBS New Year’s Eve broadcast from Times Square with the volume turned low, and wrapped my right arm around my twin sister’s shoulders while my left hand held hers.

Wednesday, January 1, 2003, 12:00 AM — Why I Never Had a Twenty-First Birthday Drink

"Ten minutes to midnight," Katie murmured, resting her blonde head against my shoulder as the crowd in Times Square cheered on the small screen and another loud crash of glass echoed from the kitchen on the other side of our locked bedroom door. "Can you believe we have to hide in a locked bedroom in our own house on New Year's Eve because Brittany couldn't follow one simple rule?"

"Dad is going to hit the roof when he pulls into the driveway," I said quietly, glancing at the two unopened cans of ginger ale we had brought into the bedroom with us on our lap trays before the party got out of hand.

For a long moment, I sat there listening to the contrast between the two sides of that bedroom door: out in the living room, kids our age were passed out on the floor, screaming at each other in drunken rage, or stumbling around out of their minds—while in here, Katie and I were safe, clear-headed, and holding onto each other.

Up until that exact night at seventeen years old—four months shy of my eighteenth birthday in April—I had always assumed that when it came to alcohol, I was just waiting until my twenty-first birthday like everybody else to have my first legal drink. I was a rule-follower by nature; I didn't break laws, so I had figured that once I turned twenty-one, I'd probably try a glass of beer or wine just to see what the big deal was.

Sitting on the edge of that bed with Katie's hand in mine, listening to Derek's slurred shouting and Brittany's loopy giggling through the drywall—and remembering the look on our mother's face on Deck 4 of the *Sunward Tropics* right before she landed in the ship's brig—something settled permanently inside my chest.

"Katie?" I said softly as the digital clock on the television screen ticked to 11:59 PM and the glittering crystal ball began its sixty-second descent down the flagpole in Times Square.

"Yeah, Nate?" Katie asked, looking up at me.

"You know how I always said I was waiting until my twenty-first birthday to have my first legal drink?" I said, popping the tabs on our two cold cans of ginger ale and handing one to my sister. "Listening to what's going on in our living room tonight—some of them passed out cold, some of them furious and trying to fight each other, some of them acting like they lost half their brains—I don't ever want to end up like that. Not even once. When we turn twenty-one, I'm not having a twenty-first birthday drink. I'm never touching the stuff for the rest of my life."

Katie looked at the can of ginger ale in her hand, then looked up into my eyes with a fierce, unmistakable pride.

"Me neither, Nate," Katie said, clinking her ginger ale can gently against mine just as *12:00 AM — HAPPY NEW YEAR 2003* flashed across the small screen and confetti snowed over Times Square. "Why would either one of us ever put something in our bodies that turns people into *that*—when we can stay sharp, write our code, and take care of each other?"

“Happy New Year, Katie,” I whispered, setting my ginger ale on the nightstand and pulling my twin sister into a tight, two-armed hug under the quilt.

“Happy New Year, Twin Brother,” Katie whispered back, hugging me tight while the noises in the living room finally began to stumble toward the front door—just twenty minutes before Dad’s headlights swept up the driveway and Brittany’s New Year’s Eve privileges came to a permanent, unceremonious end.

Part 2: The Drunken New Year Lie, Heather’s Bitter Goodbye, & Twin Sisters Always Stay

Date: 2003-01-06 at 08:05 America/New_York

Monday, January 6, 2003, 8:05 AM — Blindsided Outside Room 204

“Save it, Nathaniel—don’t you dare roll up to my locker with that innocent smile on your face and pretend you didn’t do anything wrong!” Heather Collins snapped at five minutes past eight on Monday morning, slamming her locker door shut so hard that the metal vents rattled down the second-floor hallway of Northwood High School.

My right thumb froze on the joystick of my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair, bringing my chair to an abrupt halt three feet from her locker outside Room 204.

It was Monday, January 6, 2003—the very first morning back at school after winter break. Because Heather’s parents had taken her and her cousin Wesley up to the Shenandoah Valley to visit her grandparents between Christmas and New Year’s Day, I hadn’t seen her in person for over a week. All morning long on the CVTA Route 15 bus ride and up the school elevator with Katie, I had been grinning from ear to ear, carrying a small folded note in my jacket pocket asking Heather if she wanted to meet Katie and me at Emerald Creek Mall that coming Saturday afternoon.

Instead, as Katie rolled her power chair up beside mine in the busy hallway before first period, I found myself staring into a face I barely recognized.

The warm, gentle girl who had held my hand on the second-floor bridge of the mall, who had defended my bond with my twin sister because of how fiercely she loved her cousin Wesley, was staring down at me with hard, glassy eyes and a jaw clenched so tight her chin was trembling.

“Heather, what’s wrong?” I asked, completely blindsided as my stomach dropped into my shoes. “Did something happen over break? I don’t even know what you’re talking about!”

“Oh, you don’t know what I’m talking about?” Heather laughed—a short, jagged, bitter sound that made several students walking past us turn their heads. “Really, Nate? Look down the hall by the stairwell!”

I glanced over my shoulder toward the east stairwell. Leaning against the cinderblock wall in his varsity jacket with a smug, spiteful smirk plastered across his face was Tyler—the loudmouth senior who had stumbled down our hallway with a red plastic cup on New Year's Eve and banged his fist on Katie's bedroom door when we refused to join Brittany's drunken rave.

"Tyler was in my homeroom ten minutes ago bragging to half the senior class about the wild New Year's Eve rave at your house off Military Highway," Heather said, her voice shaking with a cold, venomous fury that cut straight through the hallway chatter. "He told everybody how you got yourself and some girl wicked drunk on gas-station liquor, locked the two of you inside a back bedroom with a chair wedged against the doorknob, and spent the whole night hooking up behind a locked door while the party went on outside!"

For two full seconds, my brain couldn't even process the sheer absurdity of what I was hearing.

"What?!" I gasped, staring at her in disbelief. "Heather, that's a complete lie! Neither one of us drank a single drop of alcohol!"

"And you know what the worst part is, Nate?" Heather cut me off, her voice cracking with bitter humiliation as angry tears welled in the corners of her eyes. "When Tyler first started laughing in homeroom about how you locked yourself in a back bedroom all night with a girl, I actually defended you! I immediately assumed you were in that room with *Katie*—because I know the two of you always stick together and look out for each other! I looked right at Tyler in front of everybody and said, *'That was his twin sister Katie, you idiot!'* And Tyler looked me dead in the eye, laughed in my face, and told the whole room it *wasn't* Katie—that it was some blonde girl from the party who got wasted with you before you locked the door in his face!"

Beside me, Katie's blue eyes went wide with outrage.

"Heather, Tyler *only* saw the back of my blonde head from the hallway before Nate shut the door in his drunken face!" Katie spoke up immediately, rolling her power wheelchair six inches forward to put herself right alongside me. "It *was* me in that bedroom! Our cousin Brittany broke our dad's ground rules and invited strangers with alcohol into our house while our dad, our aunt, and our cousin Chelsea were in Newport News! Nate and I grabbed an unopened box of dry cereal out of the pantry so we'd have food to eat and locked ourselves in my bedroom all night just to stay safe and away from them! Tyler was furious that Nate wouldn't drink with him or join the rave—he's lying to get back at us!"

I reached into my jacket pocket with a shaking hand, desperate to make Heather hear the truth.

"Heather, please, listen to me—Katie's telling the absolute truth!" I pleaded, my chest aching as if someone had dropped a cinderblock onto my sternum. "We ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box and drank two cans of ginger ale while watching the ball drop on a thirteen-inch TV! I literally promised Katie at midnight that I'm never even having a twenty-first birthday drink because watching Tyler and those kids act like drunken idiots disgusted me so much! You know me, Heather—how could you ever believe I would get drunk or cheat on you?"

Slowly, painfully, I realized from the cold, shuttered look on Heather's face that the damage was already done.

Sitting in front of twenty kids in homeroom while Tyler laughed in her face and told everyone her boyfriend was locked in a bedroom all night with another girl had humiliated her to the core—and once that bitter poison had taken root in her chest, no amount of truth about a cardboard box of dry cereal was going to undo it.

"Save it for somebody gullible enough to buy it, Nathaniel," Heather said coldly, stepping back from our two wheelchairs as the five-minute warning bell rang overhead. "I stuck up for you in front of everybody because I thought you were different from every other guy at this school, and you made me look like a complete fool. Don't call my house, don't wait for me at the bus loop, and don't ever talk to me again. We're done."

Before I could get another word out of my throat, Heather spun on her heel, walked briskly down the hallway past Tyler—who flashed me one last triumphant, nasty grin before disappearing into his classroom—and vanished around the corner toward the science wing.

Monday, January 6, 2003, 3:45 PM — Roles Reversed Under the Blue Butterfly

All through first period, lunch, and afternoon classes, I felt like I was moving underwater.

What hurt more than anything wasn't just that my very first relationship had ended in less than sixty seconds on a Monday morning—it was the crushing, helpless injustice of being condemned for the exact opposite of who I was. I had followed every rule my father had laid down; I had protected my twin sister from a living room full of reckless drunks; I had sworn off alcohol for the rest of my life; and yet because one angry liar wanted revenge for having a bedroom door closed in his face, the girl I had been head over heels in love with for a year and a half now hated my guts without ever knowing I was innocent.

By the time the CVTA Route 15 Beacon V bus lowered us down the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell lift onto the sidewalk along Military Highway at three-thirty that afternoon and we rolled up the aluminum ramp into our house, the knot in my throat was so tight I could barely breathe.

Without saying a word, Katie steered her power chair ahead of me down the short hallway into her bedroom—the exact same room where we had hidden six nights earlier—and patted the edge of her mattress beneath the framed blue butterfly print on the wall.

Just like we had done on that afternoon in seventh grade when Chad had dumped Katie in the cafeteria of Bayside Middle School—except with our roles completely reversed—we locked our wheelchair brakes side by side and transferred onto the edge of her bed.

As soon as I sat down, I buried my face in my hands, my shoulders shaking as the bitter sting of Heather's final words replayed in my ears.

Beside me, Katie didn't lecture me or tell me to tough it out. Instead, she wrapped both of her arms tightly around my shoulders, pulled my head down against her shoulder, and rested her cheek against my blonde hair while her hand rubbed slow, steady circles across my back.

"It isn't fair, Katie," I choked out against the sleeve of her sweater, my voice breaking in the quiet bedroom. "I didn't even know what she was talking about when I rolled up to her locker. We were sitting on this exact bed eating dry cereal out of a box to stay away from Tyler's booze, and she thinks I betrayed her."

"I know, Nate. I was right there with you every single second," Katie whispered fiercely, holding me with every ounce of strength in her seventeen-year-old arms. "Tyler is a vindictive jerk who couldn't stand that you wouldn't act like an idiot with him, and if Heather threw away everything she knew about your character over one drunk liar's story without even listening to the two of us, then she didn't deserve my brother's heart in the first place."

I lifted my head, wiping my eyes with the back of my wrist as I looked at my twin sister.

In seventh grade, when Chad had walked out on Katie and left her crying in the middle school hallway, I had held her right under that same framed blue butterfly print and promised her that I would never leave her behind. Now, five years later at seventeen—with both of our power wheelchairs parked side by side at the foot of the bed—Katie reached out, laced the fingers of her left hand tightly through my right hand, and gave me the exact same unbreakable anchor.

"Remember what you told me in seventh grade when Chad broke my heart, Nate?" Katie said softly, her blue eyes locked onto mine. "Boyfriends and girlfriends can walk away over a rumor in a sixty-second hallway conversation. Twin Sisters never walk away. You and I know the truth about who you are, and we've got each other for life."

Taking a long, steadying breath, I squeezed Katie's hand back and leaned my head against her shoulder until the shaking in my chest finally subsided—knowing beyond a shadow of a doubt that as we headed toward high school graduation and our adult lives together, the only person in the world I would ever completely trust was sitting right beside me.

West Ocean View & The End of Hell

My Brother Only & The Speak Now Vow

Ocean View Station, The Green Sofa Confrontation, & Speak Now or Forever Hold Your Peace

Date: 2004-09-18 at 19:30 America/New_York

Saturday, September 18, 2004, 7:30 PM — Ocean View Station & The Green Sofa Confrontation at Sea Breeze West

“This is going to be a great weekend,” I said, rolling my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair right up to the curb cut at Ocean View Station as the hydraulic front ramp of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 1 bus folded down onto the concrete and my nineteen-year-old twin sister Katie wheeled off the bus straight into my arms.

Wearing her favorite royal-blue long-sleeve V-neck sweater with black trim at the collar and cuffs and light-blue jeans, with an overnight backpack clipped to the rear frame of her matching SwiftChair, Katie threw both arms around my shoulders across our armrests and hugged me tight in the warm September evening air blowing off the Chesapeake Bay.

“I’ve missed you all week, Nate,” Katie said happily, resting her cheek against mine for a second before we released our brakes and rolled side by side down the sidewalk along West Ocean View Avenue. “Two whole days of just brother-and-sister time, coding on your computer, and no drama.”

“We’ve got the whole weekend,” I smiled, checking my watch on my left wrist as we turned past the low white two-rail fence into the small, tree-shaded courtyard of Sea Breeze West.

Our complex consisted of two low-rise early-nineteen-seventies buildings facing each other across the narrow courtyard and asphalt parking lot—the red-brick building with the script Sea Breeze West sign and the quarter-operated laundry room on one side, and our white-painted two-story courtyard building on the other, where the exterior unit doors and wide double windows were lined up side by side like an old coastal motel. My unit—Apartment 3—sat on the ground floor at the very far end of the white-painted building, furthest from the parking lot.

When I unlocked the wooden front door in the right-hand corner and rolled inside ahead of Katie, the single six-hundred-square-foot apartment opened straight into our combination living room and kitchen. Immediately to the left of the front door, directly beneath the two wide front windows covered by white horizontal mini-blinds looking out onto the courtyard, sat our bright green three-cushion sofa with an oval weathered-wood coffee table in front of it and a black cathode-ray-tube television on a two-shelf black-and-glass stand in the opposite front corner. Just beyond the oval coffee table stood a large dining table that I used as a computer desk for my desktop tower PC running Quantum OS XN Pro, looking straight ahead into the open kitchen with its olive-green base cabinets, speckled laminate prep counters, slate-blue four-burner electric stove, sink, and full-size top-freezer refrigerator.

Standing near the corner television stand in a mint-green short-sleeve graphic T-shirt, charcoal-gray pants, and black-rimmed rectangular glasses, my nineteen-year-old girlfriend Tiffany Sloan froze and stared at Katie’s wheelchair rolling through the doorway behind me.

“Wait, what?” Tiffany snarled, her voice dropping into a harsh, hostile edge behind her glasses.

I blinked, braking my chair beside the bright green sofa while Katie transferred smoothly from her SwiftChair onto the left cushion of the couch and patted the middle cushion for me to sit beside her.

“I thought we discussed this on Thursday, Tiffany,” I said, transferring onto the green sofa next to Katie as my twin sister naturally draped her right arm around my shoulders the way we had sat together our entire lives. “My sister wants to see me for the weekend.”

Tiffany shot me a venomous dirty look, her face flushing dark red behind her black-rimmed glasses as she stared at Katie’s arm around my brick-red polo shirt. It baffled me why Tiffany always acted so bitterly jealous whenever another woman—even my own fraternal twin sister—hugged me, especially when I had never once had a problem with Tiffany being close with her own brother.

“Katie is going to sleep right here on the green sofa, just like we discussed,” I added, trying to keep my voice calm and even so an argument wouldn’t start before Katie even unclipped her overnight bag.

Across the oval wooden coffee table, I could feel Katie’s shoulders tense as she watched Tiffany and me fighting yet again.

“I wanted some time with my brother, Tiffany,” Katie said firmly, looking straight across the living room at her. “You get to see him twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. I don’t.”

“I am his girlfriend!” Tiffany snapped at the top of her lungs.

Katie’s blue eyes flashed with instant, protective fire.

“Don’t yell at me like that,” Katie retorted, transferring straight off the green sofa back into her SwiftChair in one fluid motion. Reaching across her armrest, she took me firmly by the hand and snarled, “Come on, Nate.”

Turning her head toward Tiffany by the corner television stand, Katie growled three words that echoed off the drywall from the front window blinds all the way back to the open kitchen stove:

“My brother only!”

Saturday, September 18, 2004, 7:55 PM — The Courtyard Walk & “Speak Now or Forever Hold Your Peace”

I wasn’t sure how to react—my head was spinning in complete confusion as I transferred back into my own SwiftChair and rolled out the front door of Apartment 3 right behind Katie into the cool September twilight of the Sea Breeze West courtyard.

The moment the wooden door clicked shut behind us and we rolled past the white two-rail fence toward the quiet sidewalk along West Ocean View Avenue, Katie braked her wheelchair, pivoted to face me under the streetlamp, and got straight to the point.

“Why do you stay with her, Nate?” Katie demanded.

I gave her what must have been a bewildered, defensive look, my hands tightening on my armrest pads.

“I’m your twin!” Katie said, leaning forward in her chair so her blue eyes locked directly onto mine. “I know when something’s up before you even say a word. Now please, tell me the truth. Why do you stay with her?”

“Katie, I… uh… well, I finally found someone,” I stammered in frustration, my voice cracking as the familiar ache of nineteen years of awkwardness and rejection after Heather Collins at Northwood High School knotted my chest. “A real, actual girlfriend.”

“She’s hurting you,” Katie said, her voice dropping from anger to an aching, urgent plea. “Why can’t you see it?”

“You’re just mad that I found someone!” I snapped back before I could stop myself.

Katie didn’t flinch, though I saw the hurt flash across her face under the streetlamp.

“Listen to you!” Katie replied softly, shaking her head. “I’m your sister, Nate. You shouldn’t be snapping at me like that. Your own twin sister.”

The second those words left her mouth, the defensive wall inside my chest collapsed. Hot tears leaked from my eyes and spilled down my cheeks as I realized I was blowing up at Katie—the one person on earth who had never left my side through our parents’ divorce on Delaney Street, through the September Friday in eleventh grade when our legs gave out, and through every lonely bus ride across Hampton Roads.

“It’s alright,” Katie whispered immediately, rolling her SwiftChair two inches closer and reaching across to hold my hand in both of hers. “I’m not mad at you, Nate. Not ever. But I still don’t approve of her, and I never will.”

My sister gripped my hand more tightly, her fingers warm and steady around mine while my thoughts collided inside my skull. Katie had always been there for me, yet part of my stubborn nineteen-year-old brain kept clinging to the illusion that having a girlfriend meant I had finally built a normal adult life—even if that life meant walking on eggshells around Tiffany’s temper and Tiffany’s overbearing mother every single day.

Looking straight into my tear-streaked eyes, Katie spoke in a clear, solemn voice that sounded like a sworn oath in a courtroom.

“If she ever pops the question, Nate, I am telling you right now,” Katie said, squeezing my hand so hard I could feel the pulse in her fingers. “When the minister or the judge stands up in front of the room and says, *Speak now or forever hold your peace*, I will be speaking up. I will roll my wheelchair right down the center aisle, I will look the officiant in the eye on the record, and I will tell the whole room that my autistic twin brother is being coerced, isolated from his family, and pressured into a marriage against his will so they have to stop the ceremony on the spot. It is my duty as your twin sister to protect you—and no, I never thought it would come down to this.”

It was too much for my brain to comprehend all at once. Between Tiffany screaming at us inside Apartment 3, the humiliating memory of Tiffany's mother glaring at me, and Katie swearing on the West Ocean View sidewalk that she would literally halt a wedding ceremony under Virginia law to rescue me, my autistic sensory circuits hit total overload. I felt like my head was about to explode, and all I wanted to do was crawl into a dark, quiet closet away from the rest of the world.

Katie saw my shoulders trembling and read my silence before I could even form a sentence.

"You can't think straight right now," Katie whispered gently, stroking the back of my hand with her thumb. "You know I can read your mind. Please be honest with me."

She paused for a long breath, letting the distant rumble of a Route 1 bus rolling down West Ocean View Avenue pass behind us before she plunged on.

"To tell you the truth, Nate, I do not approve of Tiffany," Katie said quietly. "I do not like her, and I will never like her. She will never earn my respect, and I really want you to leave her. You're not happy, and you need to get rid of her. Whenever you're ready to see that—no matter how long it takes or how bad it gets—I'm right here."

The End of Hell & Reclaiming Apartment 3

Part 1: A Sister's Worst Nightmare, Tiffany Forces a Choice, & Scrubbing Out the Filth

Date: 2005-11-12 at 20:20 America/New_York

Saturday, November 12, 2005, 8:20 PM — A Sister's Worst Nightmare & Five Buses from Williamsburg

"Please let me in!" a voice cried out over the roar of the cold November rain hammering the courtyard pavement outside my front door.

It was just after eight-twenty on Saturday evening inside Apartment 3—the far-end ground-floor apartment of the white-painted building at Sea Breeze West, right off Portview Avenue and West Ocean View Avenue, where our door was the very first door on the right as you turned in from Portview Avenue. When the first loud knock rattled the wooden front door, my instinct had been to ignore it. West Ocean View could be a rough neighborhood after dark, and I wasn't about to open my door to a stranger on a rainy November night.

Then I heard that voice through the rain—and my heart stopped.

I recognized my fraternal twin sister's voice instantly. Braking and pivoting my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair around the oval wooden coffee table, I rolled straight up to the wide front windows above the bright green three-cushion sofa and parted two slats of the white horizontal mini-blinds to peek out into the courtyard.

There on the concrete walk under the flickering porch light, drenched to the bone in the driving rainstorm, sat nineteen-year-old Katie in her compact SwiftChair.

I unlocked and threw open the wooden front door in the corner so fast the latch banged against the drywall. Rolling her wet tires across the threshold into the living room, Katie threw both arms around my neck across our armrests and sobbed against my shoulder.

“Katie—what happened?!” I asked, holding my twin sister tight as I felt her whole body trembling through her soaking-wet jacket and jeans. Cold rainwater was dripping from her blonde hair onto the green sofa cushion as she transferred out of her wet wheelchair frame onto the couch beside me.

Katie sobbed harder, shivering uncontrollably before letting out a sharp sneeze.

“Brandon lost his mind today because he wanted me to run away with him to Canada to start a new life, and when I told him no, I realized I had to get out of there and start riding buses home to you!” Katie cried, clutching both of my hands as her teeth chattered. “I’ve been riding five city buses since four o’clock this afternoon just trying to get here from Williamsburg!”

“Tiffany, please get my sis a dry bath towel,” I called out toward the hallway as Katie sneezed a second time, before turning my stunned eyes back to my twin sister. “Wait—what? Run away to Canada? Katie, what are you talking about?”

“He wanted me to pack up, leave Virginia behind, and run away across the border to Canada with him to start a whole new life where I’d never see you or Dad again,” Katie sobbed, wiping her rain-soaked face with the back of her trembling hand. “He is plain off-his-rocker crazy, Nate! He thought because I’m in a wheelchair and can’t drive, I was trapped up there in that Virginia Avenue apartment in Williamsburg with no way to escape. The moment I got out the door, I rolled straight to the Williamsburg Transportation Center and caught the four o’clock afternoon Colonial Triangle Transit Authority Grey Line bus down to Lee Hall, where we pulled in at four-thirty for the handover to Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 116 on the Mall-Hall Loop. I rode the 116 to the corner of Warwick Boulevard and Denbigh Boulevard, arriving at four-forty-five. Route 106 was due there at five o’clock, but I was starving and needed to use the restroom, so I went inside the Crown Burger at Warwick and Denbigh to get something warm to eat and use their bathroom, and then I caught Route 107 towards Sixth and Ivy at five-thirty, which got me into Newport News Transit Center at six-ten.”

Katie shuddered at the memory before continuing, her voice shaking.

“I had a thirty-five-minute wait at Newport News Transit Center, so I went inside the transit center building to use the women’s restroom—and Nate, it was the most disgusting bathroom I have ever seen in my life,” Katie said, grimacing. “Half the mirror over the sinks had been ripped off the wall leaving bare plywood covered in black glue blobs, the metal toilet paper holder was broken and hanging crookedly off the stall wall by one bolt, there was filthy graffiti scrawled all over the stall doors and white tiles, and the toilets weren’t even flushed. I got out of that restroom as fast as I could and caught the very last Route 61 of the night leaving Newport News Transit Center at six-forty-five—the Expressways trip that goes to Downtown Norfolk instead of Virginia Beach. That got me across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel to Wards Corner at seven-nineteen. I waited in the rain at Wards Corner until the eight o’clock Route 1 Granby Street bus pulled up, rode it to Duffy’s Lane at

eight-thirteen, crossed the shopping center parking lot, and rolled half a block up Portview Avenue until I saw Sea Breeze West on my right and knocked on the first door on my right!"

I could see my sister was frightened beyond belief as Tiffany walked slowly back down the short hallway from the bathroom carrying a folded bath towel. Katie sneezed again, shivering so hard her shoulders shook.

"Do you have anything dry in your bag to change into?" I asked gently, draping the dry towel around Katie's shoulders. "I want you to get out of those sopping-wet clothes before you catch pneumonia."

"No," Katie sobbed, shaking her head. "I didn't even have time to pack a bag when I escaped—I just had to get out of there and get to you."

"Alright, here's what we'll do," I said immediately. "Take my oversized dry flannel shirt and sweatpants from my dresser so you can get out of those soaked outer clothes in the bathroom, and I've got my warm sleeping bag you can zip up in on the green sofa for tonight. There's a quarter-operated laundry room right across the courtyard in the red-brick Sea Breeze West building, and I can run your wet clothes through the washer and dryer right now so you have your own clean clothes to wear in the morning."

Standing awkwardly beside the repurposed dining table that held my desktop tower PC running Quantum OS XN Pro, Tiffany cleared her throat. "Let me go wash her clothes," Tiffany said. "You need to comfort your sister."

Once Katie had changed out of her drenched outer clothes into dry layers and wrapped the bath towel and my sleeping bag around herself on the green sofa, Tiffany picked up Katie's soggy mustard-yellow shirt and jeans, grabbed the bottle of laundry soap and our roll of quarters off the laminate kitchen counter, and stepped out the front door across the rainy courtyard toward the red-brick building's laundry room.

The moment the door closed and it was just the two of us inside the living room, Katie zipped the sleeping bag up to her collarbone, reached out, and gripped my hand with both of hers.

"I'm just so scared, Nate," Katie sobbed, her blue eyes wide as she held onto my fingers like a lifeline. "Please don't leave my side."

"I'm right here, Katie—nobody is getting past that door tonight," I promised, squeezing her hand back until a loud rumble echoed from her stomach. "You haven't eaten anything since that stop at Warwick and Denbigh before five o'clock, have you? Would you like something to eat?"

"Please," Katie whispered, wiping her eyes. "Some real food, please."

I rolled twenty feet forward to the open kitchen—feeling a wave of hot embarrassment in the pit of my stomach as my wheels navigated around the cluttered piles of unemptied trash bags, greasy fast-food wrappers, and crusty dishes that Tiffany had left littering the floor and counters—and reached into the cabinet for the only clean, sealed package I could find: a box of low-fat baked potato chips.

Rolling back to the bright green sofa, I opened the box and offered a small handful of chips to my sister. Sitting up against the arm of the green sofa inside the sleeping bag, Katie ate the chips gratefully while keeping her free hand linked with mine.

“They really thought they could force me to move to Canada and cut me off from you and Dad forever,” Katie whispered, her voice still shaking from the five-bus ordeal through the rain. “Nate, do you mind if I take a hot shower? I’ve been riding five city buses all afternoon and evening trying to get here from Williamsburg. I’m hungry, I’m exhausted, I’m scared, and I’m still freezing from the rain.”

“Come on, let’s get the hot water running for you,” I said, helping Katie out of the sleeping bag and steadying her arm as we rolled down the straight right-hand hallway past the two white bi-folding doors of the closet on the left hallway wall.

At the end of the hallway—where there was no door or doorway at all, and the space opened directly to the left into the back bedroom under the through-wall air conditioner on the back exterior wall—we turned left into the bedroom toward the bathroom entrance door, which opened inward from the bedroom into the small bathroom equipped with a sink, toilet, and a bathtub fitted with steel grab bars—though to my disgust, I first had to push aside a stack of dirty kitchen pots and pans that Tiffany had bizarrely dumped inside the tub instead of washing them. After showing Katie how to adjust the hot-water faucet and making sure a fresh dry towel was within easy reach of the grab bars, I rolled back out into the living room and closed the bathroom door so she could warm up in privacy.

By the time Katie finished her hot shower and transferred back into the warm sleeping bag on the green sofa beneath the front window blinds, Tiffany had returned from across the courtyard with Katie’s freshly dried clothes folded in her arms.

Even with the warm water taking the chill out of her bones, Katie was still too traumatized to close her eyes unless she was holding my hand. Parking my SwiftChair right beside the oval wooden coffee table at the edge of the green sofa, I held my twin sister’s hand for the next hour while she whispered every terrifying detail of how Brandon had tried to isolate and trap her in Williamsburg.

“I promise you’re safe here tonight, Katie,” I told her gently as the clock on my Quantum OS XN Pro computer monitor near the kitchen ticked toward midnight. “Since the connecting bus routes don’t run on Sundays into our neighborhood in Virginia Beach, you can rest right here all day tomorrow and we’ll figure everything out on Monday.”

Katie pulled me into a tight hug from the sofa and wept softly against my collar. “Thank you, Nate.” She let out a long, exhausted yawn, though her eyes still darted nervously toward the front window blinds.

“We really need to get some sleep—it’s almost midnight, and after five buses from Williamsburg, you especially need your rest,” I said softly, squeezing her hand one last time before rolling down the hallway toward the open-doorway back bedroom where the through-wall box air conditioner hummed opposite its wall-mounted temperature switch. “Tomorrow morning, we’ll help you get everything sorted out.”

Sunday, November 13, 2005, 8:15 AM — Dry Cereal Without Milk & Tiffany Forces a Choice in the Open Kitchen

Morning barely filtered through the white horizontal mini-blinds at the front of the apartment when the sound of muffled crying from the living room jolted me awake.

Transferring out of the queen bed into my SwiftChair in seconds, I rolled straight out of the doorless back bedroom down the hallway to the green sofa.

Katie was sitting upright inside the sleeping bag with both hands pressed over her face, sobbing uncontrollably.

“I had a nightmare,” Katie cried as I rolled right up to the sofa cushion and wrapped both arms around her shoulders. “They were forcing me across the border into Canada and locking me in a room where I couldn’t call you or Dad. It felt so real, Nate!”

“You’re right here in Ocean View with me—Brandon can never touch you again,” I said, holding my twin sister close until her breathing steadied. “Let me make you some breakfast. How does cereal sound?”

“Please,” Katie said, wiping her cheeks. “And could you hand me my clothes from the chair? I want to get dressed.”

I handed Katie her clean mustard-yellow short-sleeve T-shirt and blue jeans from the laundry pile, giving her privacy while she got dressed and transferred into her SwiftChair, while I rolled straight ahead into the open kitchen under the hanging amber cone pull-chain lamp—along the narrow lane of linoleum I had cleared earlier that morning by shoving the worst floor piles into black garbage bags just so both of our wheelchairs could maneuver—and took two bowls and a box of toasted oat cereal down from the counter.

When I rolled back to the oval wooden coffee table and set the two bowls down in front of us, Katie looked down at the dry cereal and blinked in surprise.

“No milk?” Katie asked.

“Tiffany claims she’s lactose intolerant,” I explained, unable to hide the weary frustration in my voice as I glanced back toward the black top-freezer refrigerator. “She says even the sight of a jug of milk in the refrigerator makes her sick, so she won’t let me keep any in the apartment.”

Katie ate her dry cereal grudgingly without saying another word about the milk—she knew me well enough to see that complaining to me about Tiffany’s rules right now was barking up the wrong tree—until she set her spoon down and looked quietly into my eyes.

“Nate,” Katie said in a low voice, “sometime today, when it’s just you and me, I want to talk.”

“What is it?” I asked.

“I want to talk to you—just you,” Katie repeated evenly, glancing toward the hallway. “Ask me again when it’s just you and me.”

Before I could answer, footsteps shuffled down the hallway from the back bedroom.

Wearing her black-rimmed rectangular glasses, her mint-green short-sleeve graphic T-shirt, and her charcoal-gray pants, Tiffany stepped out of the hallway into the open kitchen right in front of the slate-blue four-burner stove and the black top-freezer refrigerator. Stopping beneath the hanging amber cone pull-chain lamp and the olive-green upper cabinets, she folded her arms, glared at Katie and me sitting together by the oval coffee table, and spoke in a loud, accusatory sneer.

“You know, you seem to be cuddling with Katie a whole lot more than me,” Tiffany snapped. “Do you not love me?”

Beside me, Katie looked at Tiffany with pure disgust. To my twin sister, the very idea that anyone would try to force an ultimatum between a loyal twin sibling and a romantic partner—after Katie had just escaped an abusive nightmare in Williamsburg the night before—was repellent.

“Uh, excuse me?” Katie spoke up, rolling her SwiftChair two feet forward toward the open kitchen.

I knew the two of them had disliked each other ever since Tiffany ruined our brother-and-sister weekend fourteen months ago, but one rule had been carved into my soul since the day we were born: no one insults my twin sister. Watching Tiffany glare at Katie felt like that awful day in Newport News when Tiffany had disrespected our developmentally disabled cousin Chelsea all over again.

“Of course I love you, Tiffany,” I replied, rolling my chair up beside Katie’s in front of the stove, “but why can’t you accept that I love my twin sister too?”

“You really need to think about what you just said, Tiffany,” Katie said firmly, looking straight up at her. “I’m his twin sister; you’re his girlfriend. There is zero reason on earth why you should be getting jealous of me hugging my brother after what I went through yesterday.”

Tiffany’s face contorted with fury behind her black-rimmed glasses, and she lunged half a step forward in front of the slate-blue stove, screaming straight into Katie’s face:

“Don’t you talk to me like that!”

Right then and there, standing in front of that filthy kitchen counter between the slate-blue stove and the black refrigerator, every warning Katie had given me outside in the Sea Breeze West courtyard fourteen months ago clicked into focus. My girlfriend hated my twin sister, disrespected my family, and wanted me isolated in the dark—and I was never going to choose anyone who treated Katie like that.

Katie and I sat side by side in our wheelchairs, staring daggers straight back at Tiffany without giving an inch.

Seeing the look in my eyes—realizing for the first time that her temper tantrum wasn’t going to make me apologize or push Katie away—Tiffany looked at me with deep loathing and rage.

“Forget it!” Tiffany shrieked, grabbing her purse and jacket off the corner of the repurposed dining-table computer desk. “You don’t love me! Good riddance!”

“No, he doesn’t love you!” Katie snarled, wheeling forward toward the front door as Tiffany yanked it open. “Go on! Get out of here! Stay away from me, and stay away from my brother! Don’t ever come back!”

The wooden front door slammed so hard the white horizontal mini-blinds rattled against the glass.

In the sudden, ringing silence of Apartment 3, Katie turned her wheelchair toward me and spoke gently.

“You’re probably going to hate me for saying this right now, Nate, but I’m glad she’s leaving you,” Katie said softly. “If your girlfriend can’t even accept you hugging and comforting your own twin sister, then you don’t need her in your life.”

All at once, the dam inside my chest broke. Even though Katie was still raw and traumatized from her escape from Williamsburg, I started crying right alongside her as the reality registered in my nineteen-year-old mind: my girlfriend had just dumped me and walked out the door.

Katie immediately rolled flush against my chair, pulled me into a deep, grounding hug across our armrests, and held the back of my head against her shoulder.

“Would you like me to stay here with you for now?” Katie whispered as she wiped the tears from my eyes and I wiped hers. “This way you won’t have to be alone.”

“Please—would you, Katie?” I asked, my voice shaking.

Katie knew how much I hated being alone. Holding both of my hands, she offered a brave little smile. “Want me to make us some lunch?”

Rolling four feet forward into the open kitchen, Katie opened the black top-freezer refrigerator and the olive-green base cabinets, then grimaced as she surveyed the crusty counters, the overflowing trash bags, and the sour smell hanging in the air.

“You know, Nate, she really is a pig,” Katie said bluntly, closing the empty refrigerator door. “I still have my paycheck money in my wallet. How about we roll down to the shopping center and grab a real hot lunch, and pick up some basic groceries while we’re out?”

“Alright, Katie,” I nodded, wiping my face. “And while we’re at the grocery store in the shopping center, you can buy a Norfolk CVTA bus pass right at the front customer-service desk.”

“Do they sell a monthly pass?” Katie asked as we rolled out the front door into the sunny Sunday courtyard.

“Fifty dollars for thirty days,” I told her as we wheeled down the sidewalk along West Ocean View Avenue. “It’s a thirty-day magnetic card, and the thirty-day clock doesn’t start ticking until the first time you swipe it in the farebox on a CVTA bus.”

Sunday, November 13, 2005, 1:00 PM — Crown Burger & The Heavy-Duty Deep Clean of Apartment 3

Twenty minutes later, after picking up Katie's new thirty-day bus pass at the grocery store counter, the two of us sat across from each other at an accessible table inside the Ocean View Crown Burger right down West Ocean View Avenue with hot burgers, crispy fries, and two tall cups of soda in front of us.

Now that we were out of the apartment and away from the stench of Tiffany's mess, Katie leaned forward across the table and looked me straight in the eyes.

"Now that she's not around, Nate, I'm going to be blunt and I'm going to be completely honest with you," Katie said evenly. "She was treating you like trash—and I know this isn't polite to say when you just broke up, but I wanted you to leave her."

I opened my mouth to say something, only for Katie to hold up her hand and continue.

"I know your bedroom—and mine too—have gotten a little messy with computer books or laundry at times when we were teenagers," Katie said, her voice tight with protective anger. "But never in our entire lives have I seen you live in filth like what's back in that apartment right now. That apartment isn't just cluttered, Nate—it is trashed. It's overstuffed with rotting garbage bags that haven't been taken to the dumpster in weeks, crusty takeout containers stacked on every surface, and filthy dishes everywhere. Tiffany is a pig, and I don't want you associating with her ever again."

Again I tried to speak, and Katie immediately reached across the burger wrappers to take my hand so I wouldn't misunderstand her.

"It's not you I'm mad at, Nate," Katie said softly. "I know how your mind works when somebody bullies you and shuts you down until you freeze up. I'm mad at her for treating my twin brother like trash. But now it's over and done with. Welcome back to the light."

Those four words—*welcome back to the light*—brought fresh tears welling into my eyes. With Tiffany officially my ex, the heavy, suffocating fog that had trapped me inside Apartment 3 for the last year was finally lifting, and I could see clearly that every word my twin sister was speaking was the truth.

"You're saying…" I started, my voice choking up.

"Truth is," Katie whispered, her own blue eyes tearing up across the table, "I never approved of Tiffany. Remember that weekend last September when I took the Route 1 bus here because I wanted a brother-and-sister weekend with you and just you?"

"Yeah," I answered quietly, remembering how I had snapped at Katie outside in the courtyard before she swore her *Speak now or forever hold your peace* vow.

"That's the exact day she lost every shred of my trust—when she threw a fit and insisted she wouldn't allow the two of us to spend a weekend together," Katie said. "I wanted a brother-and-sister weekend with my twin. I wasn't going to bring an ex-boyfriend between us, and I never wanted a girlfriend coming between us either."

When we rolled back down West Ocean View Avenue and returned to Apartment 3, the sight of the trashed combination living room and kitchen hit me like a physical blow. Transferring onto the bright green sofa beneath the front window blinds, I felt so emotionally drained that Katie transferred onto the cushion beside me, opened her arms, and let me rest my head in her lap while she wrapped her arms around my shoulders.

“Katie,” I whispered, staring at the worn carpet by the oval coffee table, “do you promise not to tell anyone what I’m getting ready to tell you?”

“Twin’s promise,” Katie said softly, curling her arms more tightly around me to let me know I was completely safe.

Resting my cheek against my sister’s knee, I finally let out everything I had kept locked inside my chest for a year—how Tiffany and Tiffany’s manipulative mother had coerced and guilt-tripped me from the very beginning, using affection as a weapon to separate me from my family, and how toward the end Tiffany’s mother had turned on me with open hatred while Tiffany let the apartment rot around us.

After holding me in silence for a long time and letting me cry until my chest stopped aching, Katie made her decision.

“I want to live with you, Nate,” Katie said, looking down into my eyes with steady, unbreakable resolve.

My heart leaped with relief, and I loved what she said next even more.

“We’re going to get this apartment into decent, spotless condition until your lease is up, I promise you,” Katie said, pulling me upright into a fierce hug. “We’re going to pack every single one of Tiffany’s things into separate bags by the door, and we’re going to make Apartment 3 a real home for you and me—a place that both of us can be proud to show our friends and Dad. First question: what bus takes us from here to the Community College of Hampton Roads in Virginia Beach?”

“Thank you, Katie,” I said, wiping my eyes with a real smile breaking across my face. “Tomorrow morning, we can catch the Route 1 bus that leaves Ocean View Station at thirteen minutes past the hour—it’s about a ninety-minute ride down to the Virginia Beach campus. Or if you want a shorter commute, maybe you could register for classes at the Norfolk campus downtown? That’s only forty-five minutes on the Downtown 1 or about an hour on the Downtown 3.”

“All my friends are at the Virginia Beach campus,” Katie replied without hesitation.

“Alright,” I smiled. “Tomorrow morning, I’ll take you on the bus down to the Beach campus and we’ll register together.”

“Thanks, Nate,” Katie said, transferring back into her SwiftChair and rolling her sleeves up past her elbows. “Now, let’s get this apartment cleaned up. Priority one: where are the heavy-duty trash bags? Anything that’s garbage, throw it straight in. Anything that belongs to Tiffany, put it in a separate bag by the front door in case she and her mother come back to collect her things. You’re going to hate me for how hard I push us today, because this filth won’t be cleaned in five minutes—but I promise you, it will get done, and we are going to do it together.”

The truth was, the deeper we dug into the apartment, the more mortified I felt. It wasn't just untidy; it was an overwhelming disaster of uncollected trash and grime that needed heavy-duty scrubbing from floor to baseboards. To keep our spirits up, Katie rolled over to the large repurposed dining table on the left side between the living room and the kitchen, woke up my seventeen-inch off-white CRT monitor and my 2004 desktop tower PC—which ran Quantum OS XN Pro and still sported the salvaged off-white three-and-a-half-inch floppy drive, CD-ROM drive, and CD-RW drive from our older desktop computer—and queued up a playlist of our favorite upbeat nineteen-eighties synth-rock and pop tracks through the desktop speakers.

For the next two hours, working side by side from our compact power wheelchairs, Katie tackled the overflowing trash around the green sofa, the oval coffee table, and the open kitchen counters while I bagged up the piles of garbage choking the back hallway and the open-doorway bedroom. Sweat poured down my forehead as I tied off bag after heavy black bag, my gag reflex kicking in half a dozen times whenever we uncovered week-old takeout containers festering at the bottom of a pile.

"Nate, come help me clean the bathroom!" Katie called out from the short hallway on the far right.

"Coming," I called back, rolling out of the doorless bedroom and turning left toward the inward-opening bathroom door.

Katie was sitting in her wheelchair just inside the bathroom doorway, staring in disbelief at the bathtub beneath the steel grab bars.

"Why on earth are all of these kitchen pots and pans stacked inside the bathtub?!" Katie demanded.

"Ask Tiffany that," I groaned in pure disgust. "Whenever she didn't feel like washing a pot in the kitchen sink, she just dumped it in the tub so she wouldn't have to look at it."

"Here is what we're going to do," Katie said, pinching the bridge of her nose. "Let's haul every single one of those pots and pans out of the bathtub and stack them by the kitchen sink for now. Then we're going to scrub this entire bathroom down together with heavy-duty cleaner from the grab bars to the tile floor. Once the bathroom is sparkling, I'll help you go through the pots and pans to see which ones are even salvageable and which ones go straight in the dumpster."

"Alright, Katie," I said.

Both of us gagged out loud as we lifted the crusted, foul-smelling pots and pans out of the bathtub onto a plastic tray on our laps and ferried them back to the open kitchen.

"That old bat was absolutely disgusting," Katie shuddered, wiping her hands with a soapy paper towel. "Let's haul all of these tied-up trash bags out to the dumpsters behind the complex first so we can breathe, and then we'll scrub the bathroom together."

Rolling back into the living room and looking around at the newly cleared carpet between the bright green sofa, the oval wooden coffee table, and the Quantum OS XN Pro computer table, I realized just how deeply Katie cared about me. Tears stung my eyes again, and I braked my chair beside hers and pulled her into a grateful hug.

“Thank you, Katie,” I sobbed quietly against her shoulder. “The place is starting to look so much better already.”

“She was a pig, Nate, and you deserve to live in a clean, decent home where you feel comfortable having family and friends over,” Katie said warmly, hugging me back before tapping my armrest with a grin. “Now let’s keep rolling and finish the job, because this place is nowhere near done yet!”

Side by side, balancing the heavy black garbage bags across our footplates and armrests, we rolled out the front door of Apartment 3, wheeled down the courtyard walk past the white two-rail fence, and heaved bag after bag into the steel dumpsters behind the complex.

“Do we have any air fresheners inside?” Katie asked as we rolled back through the courtyard.

“I don’t think so,” I admitted.

By late Sunday afternoon—after hours of scrubbing the grab-bar bathtub, the bathroom sink and toilet, the olive-green kitchen cabinets, the speckled laminate prep counters, the slate-blue stove, and the inside of the black top-freezer refrigerator—Apartment 3 finally looked and smelled like a human home again.

“I actually feel like we could have company over now,” Katie said with a tired, proud sigh as she surveyed the clean living room and kitchen. “We just need to air the rooms out and pick up some air fresheners to clear out the last of that stale smell. How about we roll straight down to the shopping center first to grab a nice dinner and some plug-in air fresheners? Then when we get back home, we can take hot showers and relax for the rest of the night.”

“Yeah—after hauling all those bags to the dumpster, I’m wiped out,” I smiled. “Food first.”

An hour later, after celebrating with a hot dinner at the shopping center and plugging fresh linen-scented air fresheners into the outlets by the green sofa and the open kitchen, Katie and I braked our compact SwiftChairs facing each other in front of the bright green three-cushion sofa beneath the white horizontal window mini-blinds.

Outside the front windows, the November night was dark and quiet. Inside the warm, lamp-lit living room we had just spent the entire afternoon reclaiming from the filth, Katie looked across the space between our wheelchairs at me—and all of a sudden, fresh tears welled up in her blue eyes and spilled down her cheeks.

“Katie?” I asked softly, rolling half a foot closer and reaching across our armrests to take her hand. “What’s wrong?”

“I’m just thinking about everything that happened to the two of us over the last fourteen months,” Katie wept, gripping my fingers tightly with hers as the tears streamed down her face. “Look at how badly both of us got hurt the first time in our lives we ever let people pull us apart, Nate. Brandon had me trapped up in Williamsburg trying to force me to run away to Canada where I’d never see you or Dad again, and Tiffany and her mother had you trapped right here in the dark, bullying you and treating you like garbage.”

My throat tightened as I watched the tears glistening on my twin sister's cheeks. All afternoon she had been the fierce, unstoppable one pushing us through bag after bag of rotting trash, and only now that the apartment was finally clean and quiet did the full weight of what both of us had survived come crashing down on her heart.

"I'm so sorry I didn't listen to you in the courtyard last September, Katie," I whispered, my own eyes stinging as I squeezed her hand. "And I'm so sorry I wasn't up there in Williamsburg to protect you from Brandon."

"We're together now—that's what matters," Katie cried softly, looking straight into my eyes as she held my hand like an unbreakable vow between our two chairs. "I promise you, Nate, right here and right now: we will never separate ever again. No boyfriend, no girlfriend, no distance, nothing. From now on, wherever we go, we go together."

"Never again," I promised her back, leaning across our armrests to hold her until her trembling eased.

After taking hot showers in our freshly scrubbed grab-bar bathtub and changing into soft, comfortable night shirts and sleep shorts, Katie and I rolled out of the bathroom into the doorless back bedroom and stopped side by side in front of the queen bed.

We took one look at that caving-in mattress in the far corner—the bed where Tiffany and I had slept during the worst year of my life—and both of us felt the exact same wave of revulsion at the exact same second.

"I don't want to sleep where you and Tiffany slept, Nate," Katie said flatly, wrinkling her nose at the sagging center of the mattress. "Even if we buy brand-new sheets at the mall tomorrow so the bedroom doesn't look like an eyesore, I do not want either of us lying on that bed tonight."

"Me neither," I agreed immediately. "Looking at that mattress just makes my skin crawl."

Katie sat quiet for a moment in her wheelchair, then turned her head toward the straight carpeted hallway, where the standard-width white bi-folding doors of the hallway closet stood open on the left wall above the freshly vacuumed carpet we had cleared out that afternoon. All at once, a mischievous, brilliant spark lit up her blue eyes.

"I have a crazy idea," Katie said.

"What's your crazy idea?" I asked.

"What if we take the sleeping bag and the pillows I was using on the green sofa last night and move them right onto the carpeted floor inside the hallway closet so the two of us can sleep in the pitch dark?" Katie asked.

The moment she said it, my whole chest relaxed. Because both of us are autistic, vast open rooms with drafty windows and streetlamp glare leaking through mini-blinds could leave our nervous systems on high alert after a traumatic weekend—whereas a small, enclosed, dark space where we could zip up together inside a shared sleeping bag and hold each other close felt like an impenetrable fortress.

"Katie, that isn't crazy at all—that's genius," I smiled.

Rolling back out to the bright green sofa in the living room, we gathered up the warm navy-blue sleeping bag and the two pillows Katie had used the night before, carried them across our laps down the carpeted hallway, and spread the sleeping bag and pillows neatly across the vacuumed carpet on the floor of the hallway closet.

When it was finally bedtime, Katie and I parked our compact SwiftChairs side by side just outside the closet threshold, transferred down onto the soft carpet in our night shirts and sleep shorts, and climbed into the shared sleeping bag together. Reaching up from inside our warm fabric cocoon, I pulled the two white bi-folding closet doors completely closed until they latched, and Katie reached up to click off the overhead closet light.

Instant, velvet darkness wrapped around us from wall to wall.

“I missed sleeping right beside my twin sister,” I whispered inside the snug, pitch-dark quiet of the enclosed closet as a single tear of relief slipped from the corner of my eye onto the pillow.

Turning on our sides facing each other inside the shared sleeping bag, we cuddled up close in the dark, the enclosed walls of the closet and the steady, deep-pressure warmth of our arms around each other calming every last tremor of fight-or-flight anxiety in our autistic minds.

“You’re still shaken up from everything today, aren’t you?” Katie asked comfortingly, resting a gentle hand against my cheek as I laid my head against her shoulder.

Even in the dark, she knew me by heart.

“You just want to hold me, don’t you?” Katie whispered, wrapping both arms securely around my shoulders inside the shared sleeping bag so I wouldn’t burst into tears again. “It’s alright, Nate. Both of us went through hell this weekend, and you’re emotionally exhausted. We had a long afternoon scrubbing this whole apartment back to life—so tonight, inside our own quiet little sanctuary, just hold onto me and get some sleep.”

She leaned over and gently kissed my forehead goodnight, just like we used to do when we were kids on Delaney Street, and bundled together inside that dark, enclosed hallway closet, both of us fell fast asleep feeling completely secure.

Part 2: The 8:13 AM Bus to CCHR, All-New Queen Bedding, Dad’s Pickup Truck, & The Hallway Closet Sanctuary

Date: 2005-11-14 at 07:30 America/New_York

Monday, November 14, 2005, 7:30 AM — Real Milk in the Cereal Bowls & The 8:13 AM Route 1 Bus to CCHR

“Good morning, sleepyhead—look what’s in the bowls today,” Katie called out cheerfully from the open kitchen as I rolled my compact SwiftChair out of the doorless back bedroom down the short right-hand hallway.

Under the hanging amber cone pull-chain lamp, Katie was pouring cold, fresh white milk from a half-gallon carton we had picked up the night before into two bowls of toasted oat cereal on the speckled laminate counter.

“Real milk!” I grinned, rolling up to the oval wooden coffee table in front of the bright green sofa as Katie carried both bowls over on a tray.

“And even better news,” Katie said, setting my bowl down in front of me before parking her SwiftChair beside mine. “I called Dad at his house in Virginia Beach twenty minutes ago. He knows that you and I are living together here in Apartment 3 now, he knows Tiffany left you in that disgusting mess and that the two of us spent all day Sunday scrubbing the apartment clean, and he’s bringing his pickup truck over this afternoon to help us move my dresser and clothes in! Now, what time did you say the bus to Virginia Beach leaves?”

“Thirteen minutes past the hour,” I answered after giving my twin sister a grateful thank-you hug across our armrests. “We just roll right up West Ocean View Avenue to Ocean View Station by the Burger Arch. It’s a ninety-minute ride down to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus—and we just have to remember that the last bus leaving CCHR to bring us back here is at 5:45 PM, because buses in Virginia Beach stop running around dinnertime for some reason.”

“Today I want to get both of us registered for our CCHR classes so we’re right back on track,” Katie said, taking a spoonful of cereal with real milk. “And while we’re in Virginia Beach, I want to take the bus over to Chesapeake Bay Mall and buy brand-new bedding for the queen mattress—sheets, comforter, pillows, everything—because I don’t trust a single thread that’s currently on that bed. Which bus routes go from CCHR toward Dad’s house off Military Highway and Indian River Road?”

“Any of the routes hubbing out of CCHR—Routes 12, 25, 26, 29, 33, and 36,” I told her.

“Perfect,” Katie said. “I told Dad we’d meet him with his pickup truck after we pick up the new bedding at the mall, ride over to his house to load up my basics—my laptop, my dresser, my clothes, my clock radio, and my television and DVD player—and bring them straight back here to Ocean View.”

As soon as we finished eating breakfast, Katie picked up both of our empty cereal bowls and our spoons from the oval coffee table and rolled straight back to the kitchen sink.

“From now on, Nate, we wash as we go,” Katie declared, turning on the hot tap and scrubbing both bowls with dish soap right from her wheelchair. “This way there are never any smelly, crusted dishes lying around the sink or the bathtub ever again.”

Glancing at her wristwatch as she set the two sparkling bowls into the drying rack, Katie dried her hands on a clean dish towel. “I want us on that 8:13 AM Route 1 bus. If we catch the 8:13 at the Burger Arch, what time will we roll into CCHR?”

“Right around 9:45 AM—it’s an hour and thirty minutes end to end,” I said, watching in admiration as she finished wiping down the sink rim. “You really meant it about doing the dishes immediately!”

“We used two cereal bowls for breakfast, and washing them the second we finish takes sixty seconds,” Katie smiled, unlocking her brakes and rolling toward the front door by the white mini-blinds. “I want both of us to feel proud of how neat we’re keeping our apartment. Come on—let’s catch the 8:13!”

Ten minutes later, at the Ocean View Station bus loop near the Burger Arch, the blue-and-silver CVTA Route 1 bus knelt at the curb and lowered its hydraulic front ramp. Rolling up the ramp one behind the other, Katie swiped her brand-new fifty-dollar thirty-day magnetic bus pass in the farebox right after mine, and the driver secured both of our compact SwiftChairs into the front wheelchair bays behind the yellow line.

Even after four years in our powerchairs, the cool damp November air had left a dull ache in my lower legs, and it felt wonderful to sit securely side by side with my twin sister as the bus rolled south down Granby Street and turned east toward Virginia Beach.

“Welcome to our oh-so-wonderful regional transit patchwork,” I joked to Katie as the Route 1 crossed the municipal line out of Norfolk into Virginia Beach. “Back in Norfolk on Route 1, no complaints at all—you can catch a bus late into the night. Cross the city line into Virginia Beach, though, and the whole bus system shuts down at dinner like nobody with a job or a wheelchair ever needs to go anywhere after six o’clock.”

“Wait until we start writing about that online,” Katie murmured, her blue eyes narrowing thoughtfully as she looked out the bus window at the narrow road shoulders without sidewalks.

At 9:45 AM sharp, the Route 1 pulled into the transit loop at the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus. Rolling into the student services building together, we got in line at the registrar’s counter while I pulled out my flip phone and called Dad to let him know we had made it safely down from Ocean View on the bus and were registering for classes.

At the counter, Katie and I came up with a registration plan that gave us the best of both worlds: we signed up to take United States History together in the exact same lecture section—which knocked out our required history credits side by side—while letting each of us pursue our favorite subjects in our other classes, with me diving into computer programming and software architecture while Katie registered for early European literature.

At 11:45 AM, with our printed spring class schedules tucked safely into Katie’s backpack, we rolled out to the CCHR bus loop and boarded CVTA Route 29 up to Chesapeake Bay Mall.

“Priority one,” Katie announced as we wheeled off the Route 29 ramp into the mall entrance: “I’m starving! Let’s grab lunch at the food court first, and then we’re heading downstairs to the department store for bedding. I’m sorry, Nate, but what Tiffany left on that bed was disgusting, and I want all-new everything so you never have to be reminded of her in our bedroom again.”

After eating lunch together upstairs, we took the mall elevator down to the lower level and rolled into the home-goods department among the rows of packaged sheet sets and comforters.

“Can I help you two find anything today?” a friendly sales clerk asked, stepping over to our wheelchairs.

“Yes, please!” Katie replied brightly. “I’m moving in with my twin brother to help him get back on his feet, and I’m looking for a complete, high-quality bedding set for a queen-sized mattress. All we’re keeping is the mattress itself—we’re starting completely over from scratch, so I want new fitted and flat sheets, a warm comforter, new pillows, and new pillowcases.”

Rolling down the aisle together, Katie and I picked out a soft navy-and-slate-blue queen comforter set with crisp cotton sheets and four plush pillows that both of us loved. After Katie paid for the giant zippered bedding bags at the register, my phone buzzed with a text from Dad: he was waiting right outside the mall doors in his pickup truck.

Monday, November 14, 2005, 2:30 PM — Dad’s Pickup Truck, A Real Grocery Run, The Confrontation With Tiffany’s Van, & The Hallway Closet Sanctuary

Rolling out through the automatic glass doors into the Chesapeake Bay Mall pickup zone, we spotted our forty-seven-year-old dad standing beside the open tailgate of his pickup truck with the folding aluminum loading ramps already set in place.

“There are my two favorite college students!” Dad said warmly, hugging Katie and me tightly before helping us load the new queen bedding bags, secure our two compact SwiftChairs in the bed of the pickup truck, and settle into the back seat of the extended cab behind him.

The ride down to Dad’s single-story brick ranch off Military Highway and Indian River Road was quiet and easy, and once we arrived, Dad loaded Katie’s clothes, her wooden dresser, her television and DVD player, her digital clock radio, her laptop, and the other essentials she felt she needed into the bed of his pickup truck. Climbing back into the cab—with Dad up front in the driver’s seat and Katie and me side by side in the back—we spent the drive back across the city line into Norfolk explaining everything that had happened over the last forty-eight hours: from Brandon Mercer trying to force Katie to run away with him to Canada and Katie’s five-bus escape from Williamsburg through the Saturday night rainstorm, to Tiffany screaming at us in front of the stove and dumping me on Sunday morning, to Katie offering to move in and live with me after we spent all day Sunday scrubbing out the filth.

Listening in the driver’s seat, Dad’s knuckles turned white on the steering wheel, a deep, protective fury settling behind his glasses at what both Brandon and Tiffany had put his nineteen-year-old twins through.

When we arrived in Ocean View and Dad backed his pickup truck up to the white two-rail fence at Sea Breeze West, we quickly unloaded my sister’s things into the courtyard of Apartment 3. Looking into the newly scrubbed open kitchen, Dad turned to the two of us.

“Do you two need to go grocery shopping while I have the truck here?” Dad asked.

“That might not be a bad idea,” Katie said immediately. “She did a horrible job keeping food in the apartment, and I didn’t trust any of the food that was left. She was an absolute slob, so I threw everything out into the dumpster yesterday.”

Ten minutes later, Dad pulled into the parking lot of the neighborhood grocery store down West Ocean View Avenue, set the folding ramps against his tailgate so we could roll our two compact SwiftChairs down onto the pavement, and walked right inside through the automatic glass doors with us. In the front vestibule, Dad pulled a full-sized metal shopping cart out of the rack to push right alongside our wheelchairs so that Katie and I could keep both hands free to steer and pick out every item ourselves.

Katie was lovingly stubborn about taking charge of the grocery run for the two of us.

“I want to buy food that we like,” Katie said firmly as our wheelchairs rolled side by side toward the bright produce section with Dad pushing the cart half a step behind us. “Yes, she bought food, but she didn’t take any of your input. You know that as well as I do.”

She thought about it for a moment as her tires hummed across the polished floor, then added, “And I don’t believe she was really allergic to milk, since she ate ice cream.”

“Chocolate ice cream,” I said.

“Point being, if she could eat dairy, she could have milk,” Katie said as we rolled up to the misted produce tables. Reaching out from her wheelchair, she inspected a pyramid of crisp red apples, bagged half a dozen firm ones, and handed the bag up to Dad to set into the shopping cart. “Here—you haven’t had apples in a while.”

“What else do you want to get?” I asked.

Katie pulled out her flip phone, flipped it open, and angled the screen toward my eyes. “I made a list of what we need. I want to completely restock the apartment with you-and-me food.”

Rolling slowly along the produce tables together while Dad followed with the cart, Katie and I picked out a bunch of ripe yellow bananas for morning snacks before our bus rides to CCHR, a head of crisp green leaf lettuce and two vine-ripened tomatoes for sandwiches, a bag of baby carrots, and a five-pound mesh sack of russet potatoes that I lifted off the lower wooden bin and passed back to Dad. Each time we chose something, Dad took it from our hands with an approving nod and arranged it neatly in the basket of the cart so nothing bruised.

From produce, we rolled down the bakery aisle, where Katie reached out to grab a soft loaf of whole-wheat sandwich bread and handed it to Dad, before steering us toward the refrigerated packaged meat wall.

“Lunch meats for us, of course,” Katie said, scanning the pegs of plastic-sealed packages.

“Can we get the meat from the deli instead?” I asked.

“Sure,” Katie said, pivoting her SwiftChair around while Dad turned the shopping cart to follow us back toward the lighted glass deli counter. “What kind of meat would you like?”

“Just some ham will do,” I said as our two wheelchairs rolled up to the deli case.

“Sure, I’ll get some ham. Half a pound sound good?” Katie asked me.

“Sure,” I replied.

Looking up at the clerk behind the glass counter, Katie smiled politely. “I’ll take a half pound of thinly sliced honey ham, please.”

When the clerk handed down the warm, white-paper-wrapped parcel sealed with its printed weight label, Katie checked it with a satisfied nod and passed it back to Dad, who laid it carefully beside the bread in the top basket of the cart.

“We need to get a few more items on my list,” Katie said, glancing down at her phone screen again. “Condiments, of course, to make sandwiches, and breakfast food. Milk and cereal, of course, but I also want to get other breakfast supplies in case we want pancakes or eggs or whatnot.”

“Alright. What about dinner?” I asked.

“That’s why we’re getting meat,” Katie said as we rolled back along the fresh meat case and she eyeballed the cuts arranged on the chilled display trays. “I don’t want to get too much since it will be just you and me.”

Working together from our chairs, Katie and I picked out a smaller two-person package of lean ground beef for skillet pasta nights and a pair of boneless chicken breasts, handing both trays up to Dad to tuck into the lower rack of the shopping cart.

For the next twenty minutes, the three of us went up and down the center grocery aisles in an easy, familiar rhythm—Katie and I rolling side by side down each aisle picking out what we wanted from the middle and lower shelves, while Dad pushed the cart behind us, took each jar or box from our hands, and reached up to the top shelves whenever Katie pointed to something just above our seated reach. In the condiment and pasta aisle, we picked out squeeze bottles of yellow mustard and mayonnaise for our honey-ham sandwiches, two boxes of enriched pasta, and two jars of marinara sauce; in the soup and canned-goods aisle, we picked out cans of chicken noodle soup and green beans to stock the new pantry shelves we planned to put in the hallway closet; and in the baking aisle, Katie grabbed a box of buttermilk pancake mix and a bottle of maple syrup for lazy weekend mornings.

When we rounded the back dairy wall, I reached into the chilled case for a carton of Grade A large eggs and a pack of salted butter while Katie pulled two cold half-gallons of whole milk off the middle rack and handed them to Dad to stand upright in the cart.

Then we turned into the cereal aisle—and without saying a single word to each other, both Katie and I rolled straight to the exact same section of shelving and reached out at the exact same instant for two boxes of the toasted oat cereal we had both loved since we were kids.

Ah, the joys of being twins: we shared pretty much everything.

Dad chuckled warmly behind the handlebar of the shopping cart as Katie and I handed him the matching cereal boxes at the same time.

As we rolled out of the cereal aisle past the glass-door frozen-food cases toward the front checkout lanes, a mischievous grin spread across Katie's face.

"One last thing," Katie suggested, braking her chair beside the ice-cream doors. "Let's get ice cream, just to stick it to that old bat."

Laughing out loud, I pulled open the frosty glass door from my chair, Katie reached in to grab a tub of rich chocolate-fudge ice cream, and Dad grinned as he set it right on top of the cart.

At the front register, Dad refused to let Katie pull out her wallet, paying for our entire cart of groceries himself before pushing the loaded cart out to his pickup truck and helping us load every bag into the cab and truck bed for the two-minute drive back to Sea Breeze West.

"I want to organize everything reasonably, now that she is gone," Katie said as we rolled back toward the courtyard of Apartment 3. "I didn't like how she had everything haphazardly placed."

Before Katie could put her plan into action, we saw a familiar minivan pull into the parking lot right outside the white two-rail fence—and something in my chest told me how glad I was that Dad was right here with us.

I recognized that van from anywhere. Rolling flush against Katie's chair, I threw both arms around my twin sister, hugged her as tightly as I could, and whispered against her shoulder, "It's them. I know that van from anywhere."

Standing beside his pickup truck with Katie's wooden dresser still strapped in the bed, our dad turned around, watched Tiffany and her scowling mother step out of the minivan, and planted himself across the courtyard walk like an immovable wall.

"Get your stuff—my daughter put it all in one pile—give us your key, and leave," our father snarled in a low, iron voice that left zero room for argument. "You are no longer welcome in my family."

Neither Tiffany nor her mother dared to talk back to Dad. Avoiding our eyes, they hurried past him to the front threshold where Katie and I had stacked all of Tiffany's bags and boxes in one giant pile. Because they had only come in a minivan, they could only take what would actually fit inside a minivan. Trip after silent trip, Tiffany and her mother hauled out bag after overstuffed bag of her clothes and personal clutter, shoving them into the back cargo area and across the middle bench seat until the minivan was packed nearly to the roof. There was zero room left in their van for the queen bed or for Tiffany's bulky bedroom dresser.

When Tiffany's mother glanced at the stuffed minivan and muttered that they didn't have room for the television, the rabbit-ears antenna, and the VCR that were still sitting on top of Tiffany's dresser against the right wall of the back bedroom beneath the high-mounted through-wall air conditioner, neither Katie nor I wanted a single piece of her electronics left behind—and Dad wasn't having it either.

“You’re taking that television and VCR with you right now,” Dad said flatly.

Marching straight down the carpeted hallway into the doorless back bedroom, Dad stepped over to the right bedroom wall beneath the high-mounted air conditioner, yanked the power cords out of the wall outlet, unplugged the coaxial lead, lifted Tiffany’s television, rabbit ears, and VCR off the top of her dresser in one load, and carried them right out across the courtyard himself. Opening the minivan’s passenger-side sliding door, Dad wedged the television, the VCR, and the folded rabbit ears firmly onto the floorboard in front of the middle seat, then held out his open palm.

Without a word, Tiffany dropped her brass apartment key into Dad’s hand, climbed into the minivan beside her mother, and backed out of the Sea Breeze West parking lot for the last time in our lives.

Katie promised right away that she would comfort me whenever I needed it—which I did. As the minivan disappeared down West Ocean View Avenue, I could still see the fierce, protective anger burning in my dad’s eyes: anger directed squarely at Tiffany and her mother for everything they had put me through.

Refusing to leave Tiffany’s dresser inside our apartment for one more minute, Dad marched back into the bedroom, muscled Tiffany’s empty dresser away from the right wall below the air conditioner, hauled it out through the straight carpeted hallway and out the front door by himself, and hoisted it into the bed of his pickup truck so he could take it straight to the landfill on his way home. Once Tiffany’s dresser was out of the apartment, Dad, Katie, and I brought Katie’s wooden dresser in from the pickup truck and placed it right against that exact spot on the right wall of the bedroom below the high-mounted air conditioner, setting Katie’s television and her DVD player neatly on top of her dresser. Now the only piece of furniture left behind from Tiffany was the queen bed pushed into the far-left corner of the bedroom—just a box spring and an aging queen mattress whose center was noticeably caving in.

Pressing his hand against the sagging middle of the bare mattress as we stripped it down and fitted our crisp new navy-and-slate-blue sheets, comforter, and four fresh pillows from Chesapeake Bay Mall over it, Dad shook his head at how badly the springs were caving in and promised Katie and me that he would replace the queen bed for us.

As we started arranging our things inside the apartment, Katie rolled up beside me and squeezed my hand.

“You need comfort?” Katie promised gently. “I’m right here for you, and always will be.”

Rolling back out to the large repurposed dining table on the far-left side of the front room—where our seventeen-inch off-white CRT monitor sat beside my 2004 desktop tower fitted with the salvaged off-white three-and-a-half-inch floppy drive, CD-ROM drive, and CD-RW drive from our older desktop computer—I turned to my sister.

“I want to redo the desktop in the front room, so that it’s used for both of us,” I said. “I want to get rid of any traces of her from it.”

“I want to help,” Katie replied, rolling her SwiftChair right up beside mine.

“What I’d like to do is set up the desktop to have user accounts for the two of us,” I said.

“We have laptops,” Katie said.

“I know,” I said, my eyes lighting up as the architecture took shape in my head. “Someday, what I think would be neat is to have it set up so that no matter which computer we log in from, it would have all of our data.” I paused for a moment, glancing at the glowing seventeen-inch CRT screen as I popped open my binder of Quantum OS XN Pro installation discs, then continued, “I just want to get rid of any traces of her from the desktop. Yes, I’m going to reinstall everything, starting from scratch.”

While the fresh installation formatted the desktop hard drive from scratch, Katie and I rolled down the straight right-hand hallway to put fresh bathroom supplies away in the back. Pausing beside the two white bi-folding doors of the hallway closet on the left wall—where the doors opened outward toward the solid right exterior wall—Katie looked thoughtfully at the upper space inside the closet.

“You know?” Katie said. “I think I would like to turn half of this closet into a pantry. We have our dressers for clothes, we have a few coats and whatnot that need to be hung, so there should be plenty of room to get some shelving.”

“We should look for some shelving someday,” I said, noticing how well the half closest to the kitchen would work for pantry shelves while the half closest to the bedroom held our hanging coats above the clear carpeted closet floor.

“Yeah. Meanwhile, we need to finish unloading groceries,” Katie replied as we rolled back out to the open kitchen and she started putting items away in the olive-green cabinets and the refrigerator.

After a few minutes, every last grocery item was put away in our spotless kitchen. Katie transferred onto the bright green three-cushion sofa beneath the front window blinds and allowed me to transfer over and snuggle with my head resting in her lap.

Looking up as Dad stepped back inside from tying down Tiffany’s old landfill-bound dresser in the bed of his pickup truck, Katie smiled warmly.

“Dad, I would like to get some shelving for the closet,” Katie said. “I was thinking it would be perfect for half a pantry, and the other half will be where we hang our clothes up.”

“Next time I am off,” Dad said, resting a gentle, proud hand on Katie’s shoulder and then on mine.

“Alright, Dad. Let us know,” Katie said happily. “Guess you should be heading home.”

When the front door clicked shut behind Dad and the quiet hum of our freshly formatted Quantum OS XN Pro desktop filled the clean, linen-scented living room of Apartment 3, Katie wrapped both arms around my shoulders on the green sofa, and I knew without a shadow of a doubt that the year of hell was over—and that my twin sister and I were never letting anyone tear us apart again.

Part 3: Thanksgiving Dinner at Dad's House, The Black Friday Closet Project, & The Secret on the Closet Floor

Date: 2005-11-24 at 13:00 America/New_York

Thursday, November 24, 2005, 1:00 PM — Thanksgiving Dinner With Dad in Virginia Beach

"Smell that roasting bird!" Dad smiled from the stove of his single-story brick ranch off Military Highway and Indian River Road as Katie and I rolled our compact SwiftChairs down the hallway into the warm, cinnamon-and-sage-scented kitchen.

It was Thursday afternoon, November 24, 2005—Thanksgiving Day—just ten days after Katie had moved into Sea Breeze West Apartment 3 with me and we had reclaimed our lives from fourteen months of isolation. Earlier that morning, Dad had driven up to West Ocean View in his pickup truck with the folding aluminum ramps to bring both of us down to his house in Virginia Beach for the holiday, and for the first time in over a year, there were no jealous partners, no screaming ultimatums, and no walking on eggshells—just our forty-seven-year-old father and his nineteen-year-old twins under one roof again.

"Can we help mash the potatoes or set the table, Dad?" Katie asked, braking her wheelchair beside the kitchen counter and washing her hands at the sink.

"You can take the wooden spoon to the bowl of mashed potatoes while Nate sets the silverware and napkins around the dining table," Dad said, opening the oven door to baste the golden-brown turkey. "I made sure the two places on the long side of the table have plenty of clearance so you two can roll right up side by side."

Sitting together at Dad's dining-room table twenty minutes later—with platters of carved roast turkey, herb stuffing, creamy mashed potatoes and gravy, cranberry sauce, buttered dinner rolls, and green beans spread out between us—Dad raised his glass of iced tea and looked back and forth between Katie and me with quiet emotion in his eyes behind his glasses.

"Last Thanksgiving, our family was scattered in three different places, and I spent every week worrying sick about the two of you," Dad said softly. "Having my son and my daughter back together at this table today—safe, enrolled in classes together, and looking out for each other the way you two always have—is the best Thanksgiving gift a father could ever ask for."

"We're never letting anyone split the three of us up again, Dad," Katie said warmly, reaching over to squeeze my left hand while tapping her glass against Dad's and mine.

Over second helpings of turkey and warm slices of pumpkin pie topped with whipped cream, Dad leaned his forearms on the table with a grin.

"By the way," Dad said, looking at Katie, "I didn't forget what you asked me ten days ago before I hauled that old dresser off to the landfill. I have tomorrow—Black Friday—and the whole Thanksgiving weekend off work. How about we make a weekend project out of building that half-pantry, half-coat closet in your hallway at Apartment 3?"

Katie's face lit up immediately. "Really, Dad? You want to build it with us this weekend?"

"I already measured the standard closet depth in my head," Dad said. "First thing tomorrow morning, we'll pick up a set of heavy-duty white wire pantry shelves, wall standards, drywall anchors, and a sturdy half-width coat rod, and the three of us will build it right into the left wall of your hallway so you have a real pantry."

Friday, November 25 – Saturday, November 26, 2005 — The Black Friday Closet Project & The Secret on the Carpeted Closet Floor

At nine-thirty on Black Friday morning, Dad's pickup truck pulled into the Sea Breeze West parking lot with boxes of white vinyl-coated wire shelving, vertical mounting tracks, a heavy-duty hack saw, a level, and his cordless drill stacked neatly in the bed.

Rolling our wheelchairs down the straight right-hand hallway of Apartment 3 behind Dad as he carried his red steel toolbox inside, Katie and I watched as Dad set his level down and pulled open the two white bi-folding doors on the left wall of the hallway.

Then Dad stopped dead in his tracks.

Looking down at the carpeted floor at the bottom of the hallway closet, Dad went completely quiet.

There, stretched neatly across the entire clear carpeted floor of the closet from the kitchen end to the bedroom end, lay our navy-blue sleeping bag—unzipped and folded over like a double-wide cocoon—with two white pillows nestled side by side at the head against the back corner.

I felt my ears turn warm, and beside me, Katie bit her lower lip. In our excitement over Dad coming by to start the Black Friday shelving project, neither of us had remembered to roll up the sleeping bag and hide the two pillows before he opened the bi-fold doors.

Dad slowly turned his head to the left—looking past the open end of the hallway into the doorless back bedroom, where the queen bed sat pushed into the far-left corner under the window with its brand-new navy-and-slate-blue Chesapeake Bay Mall comforter smoothed flat, crisp, and completely untouched—and then looked back down at the two indented pillows and the shared sleeping bag on the floor of the hallway closet.

Dad knew both of us better than anyone else on earth. He knew that Katie and I are autistic. He knew that ever since we were toddlers in cribs, our deepest source of emotional regulation was hugging and holding onto each other, and he knew that whenever the world got too loud, too bright, or too overwhelming, both of us craved the pitch dark and a tight, confined space where nothing could reach us.

And looking from the pristine, unwrinkled comforter on Tiffany's caving-in queen mattress to the two well-slept pillows inside the hallway closet, our dad put the whole picture together in three seconds flat.

“Kids,” Dad said in a low, gentle voice, crouching down beside the open bi-fold doors and resting a hand on the edge of the sleeping bag, “you two haven’t slept on that bed in the bedroom a single night since she left, have you?”

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests, and then Katie looked up at Dad with honest blue eyes.

“We tried to make the bedroom look nice with the new comforter so you wouldn’t worry when you came over, Dad,” Katie admitted softly. “We even took two of the four pillows off the bed to put in here. Every time we roll into the bedroom at night and look at that mattress caving in down the middle, all either of us can think about is Tiffany. Neither of us wanted to sleep on Tiffany’s bed.”

“So the two of you have been sleeping in the hallway closet every night?” Dad asked quietly, no anger or judgment in his voice at all—only a deep, aching tenderness behind his glasses.

“Every single night since Sunday the thirteenth,” I confessed, looking down at the carpeted closet floor. “When we transfer into the sleeping bag together and pull the two bi-fold doors almost all the way shut, it’s completely dark and snug in here, Dad. It blocks out the draft from the windows, it feels safe and tight around our shoulders, and as long as we’re holding each other inside the sleeping bag, neither of us has nightmares about Williamsburg or about Tiffany.”

Dad stayed crouched beside the closet threshold for a long moment, swallowing hard as he looked at the two pillows pressed side by side in the narrow dark of the closet. I could see how much it broke his heart that his nineteen-year-old son and daughter had been hurt so badly—and left with such a broken, caving-in reminder of Tiffany in their bedroom—that they had retreated into a hallway closet every night just to feel clean and safe in each other’s arms.

When Dad stood back up and pulled his yellow tape measure from his belt clip, his voice was warm and steady.

“Well,” Dad said, tapping the drywall on the left half of the closet nearest the kitchen, “then we are going to engineer this closet around your sleeping spot so nobody ever takes your sanctuary away from you.”

Both Katie and I looked up in surprise. “You don’t think it’s weird that we’re sleeping in the closet, Dad?” I asked.

“Nate, you and your sister just survived fourteen months of hell, and the two of you found a way to keep each other safe and calm through the night,” Dad said firmly, resting a hand on my shoulder and then on Katie’s. “There is nothing weird about two autistic twins who love each other needing the dark, a snug space, and a hug to sleep in peace. Watch what we’re going to do.”

Pulling out his carpenter’s pencil and level, Dad marked the vertical mounting tracks on the kitchen half of the closet wall starting twenty-eight inches above the carpet—leaving the entire bottom level of the closet completely open from end to end so that even with four tiers of white wire pantry shelving mounted on the half closest to the kitchen, and a sturdy coat rod mounted high on the half closest to the bedroom for our winter jackets, the carpeted floor beneath remained a 100-percent unobstructed, full-length sleeping-bag berth for the two of us.

Across Black Friday afternoon and Saturday morning, the three of us worked together in the hallway like a well-oiled crew. From our wheelchairs, Katie and I held the spirit level against the drywall, handed Dad the steel drywall anchors, screws, and wire shelf brackets, and tested the height clearances while Dad drilled the vertical standards into the studs, snapped the four white wire pantry shelves into place on the kitchen side, and anchored the coat rod and upper shelf on the bedroom side.

By Saturday afternoon, when we rolled the boxes of toasted oat cereal, the blue boxes of enriched pasta, and the rows of canned soups and vegetables out of the cramped kitchen cabinets and arranged them neatly across the four white wire pantry shelves on the left half of the hallway closet—with our winter coats hanging on the right half and our freshly fluffed sleeping bag and two white pillows laid smoothly across the vacuumed carpet below—the hallway closet looked like it had been custom-designed from the ground up just for us.

“Half pantry closest to the kitchen, half coat closet closest to the bedroom, and our dark cuddle sanctuary right on the carpeted floor,” Katie beamed, leaning across her armrest to hug Dad around the waist as he packed his drill back into his red toolbox. “Thank you, Dad—it’s even better than I pictured it.”

“You’re welcome, sweetheart,” Dad said, kissing the top of Katie’s head and ruffling my hair as he glanced one more time toward the caving-in queen bed in the back bedroom with a quiet, determined look in his eyes. “And I promise you two—you aren’t going to be stuck with that caving-in mattress forever. As soon as I get things lined up, I’m going to make sure the two of you have a real, brand-new queen bed of your own to share.”

The Senator from Virginia

Election Night, The Decision Desk Call, & The Referendum Mandate

Part 1: Polls Close at Seven, The 8:42 PM Decision Desk Call, & Victory in Virginia Beach

Date: 2026-11-03 at 19:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 7:00 PM — Polls Close & The PHP Precinct Dashboard in Virginia Beach

“Seven o’clock on the dot—polls are officially closed across the Commonwealth of Virginia,” our sixty-eight-year-old dad said, setting three tall paper cups of ice-cold ginger ale down on the folding table beside my MagnaBook Pro inside the quiet green room behind the Virginia Beach convention ballroom. “How fast is the State Board of Elections JSON endpoint pushing the early-vote abstracts tonight, Nate?”

“Refreshing every fifteen seconds, Dad,” I replied, tapping a keyboard shortcut to refresh the custom PHP precinct-aggregation dashboard I had coded on my laptop while Katie rolled her compact silver-and-black SwiftChair power wheelchair flush against my left armrest and laced her fingers through mine.

Through the closed double doors at the end of the carpeted hallway, we could already hear six hundred supporters packing the ballroom floor—Coastal Virginia Transit Authority bus drivers still wearing their navy uniform jackets after finishing their afternoon shifts, community college students from CCHR, shipyard mechanics from Newport News, and nearly two dozen fellow wheelchair users who had ridden the evening bus pulse in from across Hampton Roads because they knew our campaign had picked a venue right on a regular bus line with a permanent, wide stage ramp.

Looking at the clean, color-coded precinct tables rendering on my laptop screen, Katie let out a quiet breath and rested her temple against my shoulder for two seconds.

Twenty-nine years had passed since the autumn of 1997, when Katie and I were twelve-year-old seventh graders at Morrison Middle School learning how to write raw HTML tags by hand in a plain text editor. Back then, watching his two autistic twelve-year-old twins stay up past supper building multi-page HTML websites from scratch had lit a fire under our dad—inspiring him to enroll at the Community College of Hampton Roads so he could earn his computer science degree and build a better life for the three of us. Four years later, during the summer and autumn of 2001—the year of our ill-fated Caribbean cruise on the *Sunward Tropics* and the September Friday when the borrowed time in our legs finally ran out—Katie and I had sat side by side reading Dad’s mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbooks cover to cover so we could learn *Quantum Basic 6.0* right alongside him. And from March 2007 to March 2008, the two of us had lived in the dorms at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville in the Web Applications Developer course, mastering PHP and database architecture right before buying our home in Kempsville fifty-fifty, filming our twenty-three-year-old *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* four-bus mayoral loop in 2008, and building websites and desktop applications for the next eighteen years.

Every single line of code running our statewide U.S. Senate campaign’s turnout model tonight had been written by the two of us at our own desks—without a single K Street data consultant or Washington party contractor touching our servers.

“First batch of Hampton Roads and Richmond early-vote precincts just dropped,” I said at 7:18 PM as the green table rows populated down my screen. “Katie, look at Virginia Beach, Norfolk, and Chesapeake. You’re outrunning the 2024 baseline by nine points in Kempsville and eleven points along the Military Highway Route 15 corridor.”

“What about the Peninsula and the Shenandoah Valley?” Katie asked, leaning closer as her blue eyes tracked the numbers line by line.

“Newport News around Peninsula Commons Mall just came in at seventy-one percent for you, Williamsburg is running fourteen points ahead of projections, and Augusta County right around Fishersville and Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center is giving us the highest Democratic margin in twenty years,” I said, my voice catching as the next wave of JSON packets streamed in from the New River Valley. “And

look at Montgomery County and Christiansburg—the student and faculty precincts around Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute just reported. You're carrying Blacksburg and Christiansburg by thirty-eight points."

Dad adjusted his glasses, leaning over our shoulders as he looked at the four wall-mounted television monitors tuned to Global News Network, GBS News, Beacon News, and the statewide public television desk.

"Remember back in May when Senator Martin Warren's chief of staff told the newspapers that two software developers in wheelchairs riding public buses could never beat the party establishment's handpicked nominee in the June primary?" Dad asked with a quiet, wry smile.

"They thought politics belonged to the people who wrote the biggest checks at Washington cocktail parties," Katie said softly, squeezing my hand across our wheelchair armrests. "They forgot that the people riding the bus vote too."

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 8:42 PM — The Decision Desk Call & Three Constitutional Amendments Pass

At twenty minutes past eight, the raw precinct feeds from Northern Virginia—Alexandria, Arlington, Fairfax, and Prince William County—flooded into our PHP database all at once.

I watched the statewide mathematical regression curve on my terminal window cross the ninety-nine-point-nine percent confidence threshold before any television anchor on the wall monitors even opened their mouth.

"Nate?" Katie whispered, seeing my fingers freeze over my mechanical keyboard.

I turned my head and looked straight into my forty-one-year-old twin sister's blue eyes.

"He can't catch you, Katie," I said softly, my throat tightening. "Even if he won seventy percent of every remaining uncounted precinct west of Interstate 81, our leads in Hampton Roads, Richmond, the CPI corridor, and Alexandria are mathematically insurmountable. You just won the United States Senate seat."

Ten seconds later, at 8:42 PM Eastern Standard Time, a sharp orchestral chime rang out simultaneously from all four television monitors on the green room wall.

On the center screen, the red-and-blue map of Virginia flashed bright gold as the banner across the bottom of the broadcast changed in bold white letters:

GNN DECISION DESK — PROJECTED WINNER: STATE SEN. KATIE PRAIRIE (D-VIRGINIA) ELECTED TO THE UNITED STATES SENATE.

Right beside it, the GBS Evening Report, Beacon News, and the Associated Wire flashed the exact same call within five seconds of one another.

Outside in the main ballroom, a roar went up so loud it rattled the framed pictures on the green room drywall—six hundred voices cheering, stomping, and chanting Katie's name while air horns and applause echoed down the corridor.

Inside our quiet room, Katie didn't look at the television screens first. She turned her wheelchair slightly toward me, threw both arms around my neck across our armrests, and buried her face against my shoulder while Dad wrapped both of his arms around the two of us from behind.

"We did it, Nate," Katie whispered against my collar, her voice thick with tears. "From the Route 15 bus stop on Military Highway all the way to the United States Senate."

"Every single mile together, Senator," I whispered back, holding my twin sister tight while Dad kissed the top of her blonde hair and wiped his eyes behind his glasses.

When Katie sat back and wiped her cheeks with the back of her hand, she looked back at my MagnaBook Pro screen, where the three statewide ballot referendums and the local city question were finishing their final tallies.

"Tell me about the three Constitutional Amendments, Nate," Katie said immediately. "Did all three pass?"

"Every single one of them just crossed the projection threshold with statewide YES majorities," I told her, pointing to the three green confirmation banners at the bottom of our PHP dashboard. "Question 1—the Right to Reproductive Freedom Amendment—just passed by twelve points. Question 2—the Marriage Equality Amendment repealing the old 2006 ban and locking affirmative marriage rights into the Constitution of Virginia—passed by fifteen points. And Question 3—automatic Restoration of Voting Rights upon completion of a prison term—just passed by nine points. Everything you co-patroned and voted for across the 2025 and 2026 General Assembly sessions in Richmond is officially part of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia."

Katie closed her eyes for a heartbeat, nodding with deep, quiet satisfaction. "Then every single oath I ever swore on the Constitution of Virginia was worth it."

"Wait—what's that red banner on the local municipal tab at the bottom?" Dad asked, pointing toward the lower right corner of my screen.

I scrolled down two inches to the local municipal referendum tally—the one-percent local retail sales tax dedicated strictly to public school construction and major facility modernization, which the General Assembly had authorized cities and counties to put before their voters tonight. Remembering the aging classrooms and accessibility hurdles at Northwood High School when our legs gave out in September 2001, Katie and I had both campaigned hard for a YES vote and marked YES on our own ballots in Kempsville.

"The local one-percent school construction sales tax referendum failed," I said quietly, reading the certified precinct totals across the city. "The NO vote carried fifty-four to forty-six. Between grocery inflation and utility bills, working families just didn't have the stomach for another one-percent sales tax at the cash register."

Katie stared at the red NO tally for a long moment, her jaw setting with that familiar, unshakeable resolve I had known since we were children.

"I respect the voters' decision—working families are stretched thin right now, and nobody likes paying higher sales tax," Katie said evenly. "But the roofs on our public schools still leak, and disabled kids in wheelchairs still get stuck behind

broken school elevators. If local taxpayers can't shoulder that burden through a sales tax, then our job in Washington starting in January is to bring federal school infrastructure and IDEA modernization grants straight home to Virginia."

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 9:15 PM — The Ramp to the Podium & A Toast With Three Glasses of Ginger Ale

At five minutes past nine, Katie's smartphone vibrated on the table beside her cup of ginger ale.

It was the Republican nominee calling from his hotel suite in Henrico County to concede the race. The call lasted less than ninety seconds—stiff, formal, and clipped—and when Katie thanked him politely and tapped the red end-call button, the ballroom coordinator knocked on our door with a wide grin.

"Senator-Elect Prairie?" the coordinator beamed. "The crowd out there hasn't stopped chanting for thirty minutes. Are you three ready?"

"All three of us," Katie said, checking that the small gold Seal of Virginia pin was straight on her royal-blue blazer lapel before reaching her left hand across to take mine.

As the double doors swung open and the spotlight beams swept across the base of the wide, gently sloped aluminum stage ramp, Katie and I nudged our right thumbs forward on our SwiftChair joysticks and rolled side by side up onto the ballroom stage with Dad walking proudly on his own two feet right beside Katie's chair.

Above our heads, a shower of blue and gold paper confetti drifted down under the stage lights while the giant projection screen behind us blazed with the GNN Decision Desk banner proclaiming Katie Prairie the newest United States Senator from Virginia.

Looking out across the cheering sea of faces—seeing the CVTA bus operators waving their caps in the front row, the CCHR students holding handmade signs, and the kids in power wheelchairs lined up along the accessible front aisle looking up at a United States Senator whose chair looked just like theirs—Katie squeezed my hand tightly in front of the cameras before rolling two feet forward to the lowered podium microphone.

"Eighteen years ago, my twin brother Nate and I sat at the bus loop at the Community College of Hampton Roads waiting to see if a single candidate for local office would ride four buses across Virginia Beach with us," Katie's voice rang out clear and steady across the ballroom speakers. "We learned that day that if working people, transit riders, and disabled Virginians couldn't even catch a bus home from a six o'clock City Council meeting before the last Route 12 left CCHR at 5:48 PM, nobody was going to hand us a seat at the table—we were going to have to roll up the ramp and build that table ourselves! Tonight, you proved that the Commonwealth of Virginia doesn't belong to billionaire donors or Washington party gatekeepers. You enshrined reproductive freedom, marriage equality, and voting rights directly into the Constitution of Virginia, and on January third, Nate, Dad, and I are taking the morning train up from Norfolk to bring your voices straight to the floor of the United States Senate!"

An hour later, after shaking every hand along the front Rope Line without a single drop of champagne anywhere near our stage, the three of us sat together in the quiet green room while the crew coiled the microphone cables outside.

Raising our three paper cups of ice-cold ginger ale—the exact same toast we had kept since New Year's Eve when we were seventeen years old, and the only drink compatible with the daily maintenance medication that kept all three of us alive—Dad, Katie, and I tapped our rims together in the center of the room.

"To the Senator from Virginia," Dad said softly.

"To the three of us," Katie replied, smiling across at Dad and me. "Now let's go home to Kempsville and get some sleep—because tomorrow morning the real work starts."

Part 2: The Morning After in Kempsville, The School Tax Referendum, & Jess's Open Letter on The Grid

Date: 2026-11-04 at 08:30 America/New_York

Wednesday, November 4, 2026, 8:30 AM — Kempsville Morning, Morning Medications, & The Failed School Construction Referendum

"Pills first before anybody touches a keyboard or answers a press call," Dad said cheerfully at eight-thirty on Wednesday morning, setting the fresh glass carafe of dark-roast coffee down beside the three amber prescription bottles lined up on the roll-under oak breakfast table of our Kempsville kitchen.

Sunlight streamed through the white-trimmed kitchen window onto the hardwood floor of the Virginia Beach house that Katie and I owned fifty-fifty—the house we had bought with the income from our PHP websites and desktop software, where both of our names sat side by side on the City of Virginia Beach deed, and where we were registered to vote. On the warm cream wall right behind our breakfast table hung the framed watercolor print of a blue butterfly that had watched over our sibling sanctuary since childhood.

Wearing a soft lavender fleece zip pullover instead of her Senatorial suit jacket, forty-one-year-old United States Senator-Elect Katie Prairie unscrewed her amber pill bottle, tapped her morning maintenance tablet into her palm, and washed it down with half a glass of ice-cold ginger ale right as Dad and I took ours.

Across the bottom of every one of our three prescription bottles sat the bright red pharmacy auxiliary warning label reminding us that mixing the medication with alcohol or tobacco carried a known side effect of death. Even if Katie and I hadn't already sworn off alcohol for life behind a locked bedroom door during our cousin Brittany's drunken New Year's Eve party back on December 31, 2002, those three amber bottles meant that on the morning after winning a United States Senate seat, our kitchen smelled like toasted bagels, hot black coffee, and cold ginger ale—with zero hangovers in sight.

As Dad stood beside the table pouring fresh black coffee into our ceramic mugs, Katie reached her right hand across the table corner to hold my left hand while we looked together at the screen of our open MagnaBook Pro laptop.

“I just pushed your official morning-after statement on the local one-percent school construction sales tax referendum to our press feed,” I told her, glancing over the clean HTML markup before hitting publish.

On the screen sat the exact words Katie had dictated five minutes after rolling out of our bedroom:

I respect the voters’ decision at the ballot box—working families are stretched thin, and nobody likes paying higher sales tax. But the roofs on our public schools still leak, and disabled students still face broken elevators. If local taxpayers can’t shoulder that burden through a sales tax, then my job in the United States Senate is to bring federal infrastructure dollars home to Virginia so our kids have safe, modern, accessible schools without squeezing local families.

“The Republican campaign committee already put out a press release at eight o’clock claiming voters repudiated ‘tax-and-spend Katie Prairie’ because you voted YES on the school referendum,” Dad noted, taking a sip from his coffee mug.

“Let them spin all they want, Dad,” Katie replied calmly. “We just won the United States Senate race by nine points and passed all three Virginia Constitutional Amendments on the exact same ballot. Telling the truth about why I voted YES—and promising to fight for federal school modernization grants so local homeowners and grocery shoppers don’t get squeezed—is why voters trust us in the first place.”

Wednesday, November 4, 2026, 9:45 AM — Jess’s Open Letter on The Grid & The Ironclad Prenup Mandate

At quarter to ten, while I was checking the morning analytics on our shared network of websites and monitoring the post-election commentary across The Grid, a text post shared by thousands of grassroots Virginia and national voters caught my eye at the top of our feed.

“Katie,” I said, sliding the MagnaBook Pro two inches closer to the center of the table so she could read the screen clearly. “Look at this open letter to the national party that’s going viral on The Grid this morning. Somebody named Jess posted it an hour ago, and forty thousand people have already shared it.”

Katie leaned forward in her SwiftChair, her eyes moving down the paragraphs on the screen. After the third sentence, she began reading the post aloud across our kitchen table in a quiet, electric voice:

“She says: *Recognize that we did this largely despite the Establishment Dems, not because of them… Take the words ‘compromise’ and ‘working with our friends across the aisle’ out of your vocabulary. If the last ten years have taught us anything, it’s that we have no friends across the aisle. This is what an actual referendum looks like. Use it. Don’t just glue what they broke back together. Re-envision it. Re-engineer it. Don’t try to take us back to where we were; take us where we always promised we could be.*”

Dad stopped by the counter with the coffee carafe in his hand, listening intently as Katie kept reading down the screen:

"*Codify all of it. Act like you're headed into your second marriage after a messy divorce and you're writing a pre-nup. Make it iron-clad. Irrefutable. Include every last detail down to who gets the coffee filters. I mean All of it. Release the trafficker files. If you or your friends or colleagues or benefactors are in them, too bad. You abuse children, you're done. That's how this works now. Prove that 'no' means 'no' again. That includes the 'no' in the sentence 'No one is above the law.'*"

Katie's fingertips tightened around the edge of the oak table as she read the final paragraphs aloud:

"*Remember that DEI stands for Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion and then DEI the crap out of the Capitol. No apologies, no excuses. The people leading this country should look like the country they serve, not the billionaires who own them. Trust that they will continue to play dirty. That when, come January, the repercussions of their so-called 'big beautiful bill' begin to rain down on the folks who were bamboozled into thinking that it would somehow make their lives better, they will blame you. Without logic, without rhyme nor reason, they will say it's your fault that their bill is hurting people. They will lie. Because that is what they do. Get ahead of it. Be proactive. Educate. Call out the lies. Bring receipts. Take questions, hold press conferences and town halls… And then get to work. Do EVERYTHING that we sent you there to do. All of it. Shy away from nothing. Blinders on, elbows out, unshakable principles leading the way.*"

For ten full seconds after Katie finished reading, the kitchen was completely quiet except for the morning birds outside in our Kempsville oak trees.

"I have no idea who Jess is," Katie said slowly, looking from the laptop screen up at Dad and me with a fire in her blue eyes that reminded me of the afternoon in January 2016 when she took the microphone in the House General Laws Subcommittee in Richmond and obliterated the bathroom bill in three minutes flat. "But she just wrote our entire six-year Senate playbook."

"Every single word of it," I agreed, opening a fresh Markdown document in Quantum Code right beside our browser window to save the text. "Look at what she said about not just gluing what they broke back together, but re-engineering it and codifying it like a prenup before a second marriage after a messy divorce—down to who gets the coffee filters. That is literally how we write software, Katie. Unwritten Washington 'norms' and gentlemen's agreements are just unpatched security vulnerabilities waiting for a bad actor to exploit."

"And we are going to patch every single one of them into black-letter federal statute," Katie said firmly. "The national party establishment tried to block us in the June primary because they wanted a polite corporate insider who wouldn't rock the boat. We won this seat despite them, not because of them. When we take the train up to Washington on January third, we are not going up there to water down our own bills to appease bullies who voted to strip healthcare and disability rights from people on the bus."

She tapped her finger on the table beside her glass of ginger ale, counting off her mandate right across our kitchen table.

"We codify reproductive freedom, marriage equality, voting rights, wheelchair right-to-repair, and repealing the SSI and Medicaid disability marriage penalty down to the last statutory comma—down to who gets the coffee filters," Katie declared. "We demand the full, unredacted release of the federal child-trafficking files, and I don't

care whose billionaire donors or political friends are named in them—you abuse children, you're done, and no one is above the law. We put Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility at the front door of our Senate office so Capitol Hill looks like the working people, transit riders, wheelchair users, and neurodivergent thinkers we serve. And before the delayed January fallout of the opposition's prior 'big beautiful bill' hits working families and they try to lie and blame us for their own law, you and I are going to build a live public receipts dashboard in PHP and ride local public transit to town halls across every corner of Virginia to show voters the exact roll-call votes and effective dates."

Dad smiled proudly, setting his coffee mug down on the counter. "Blinders on, elbows out?"

"Blinders on, elbows out, Dad," Katie grinned, squeezing my hand across our armrests. "Now let's look at the sixty-day transition calendar between today and January third—because we've got an orientation in Washington next week, a State Board of Elections certification on December seventh, a official Senate website vendor to audit, and a State Senate seat in Richmond I have to formally resign before we can board that five o'clock morning train to Alexandria."

The Minified ZIP File, The Raw HTML Takedown, & Resigning from Richmond

Part 1: The Minified ZIP Trick, Barely Commented Code, & The Live WCAG Takedown

Date: 2026-12-11 at 10:00 America/New_York

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:00 AM — Static MagnaPad Slides & The Minified ZIP Trick in Dirksen

"You don't need to worry your head about the technical weeds, Senator-Elect—our engineering team in Rosslyn handles all the magic behind the curtain! Just tell us if you like this shade of Senate navy blue on the banner!"

Sitting across the polished mahogany conference table in our temporary transition suite in the Dirksen Senate Office Building, Bradford Vance—the Senior Account Director for Capitol Digital Solutions, one of the beltway IT contractors approved by the Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms to build official *senate.gov* websites—beamed with patronizing self-satisfaction as he tapped a static PDF slide deck on his MagnaPad tablet. Beside him sat his junior project manager, Evan, while a black triangular conference speakerphone sat in the center of the table with their lead developers dialed in live from their Rosslyn office across the Potomac.

Four days earlier, on Monday, December 7, the Virginia State Board of Elections had met in Richmond under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-679 to formally certify the November 3 general election results, and the Governor had transmitted Katie's signed Certificate of Election to the Secretary of the United States Senate.

Now, on Friday morning, Katie and I had ridden the morning ARTS train up from Norfolk, detrained on the mobile lift at Alexandria to drop our overnight bags at Dad's two-story brick house on Sunset Drive—where our newly installed interior

vertical platform wheelchair lift was already humming smoothly between the first floor and our upstairs three-desk office in Bedroom 4—and taken the Capital Transit Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge into the District for our ten o'clock website sign-off meeting.

Under United States Senate Internet Services rules, a Senator's official government website—*prairie.senate.gov*—had to be strictly separated from our campaign website, which Katie and I had coded ourselves in PHP, and hosted inside the Sergeant at Arms environment using an approved vendor template.

Watching Bradford talk down to my forty-one-year-old twin sister in the exact overly bright, sing-song voice that non-technical consultants often used when they saw two adults sitting in compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs, I didn't say a word. I just kept my hands resting lightly beside my closed MagnaBook Pro and waited for Katie to lower the boom.

"I don't approve websites from static PDF pictures on a MagnaPad, Bradford," Katie said evenly, folding her hands in the lap of her royal-blue blazer without even glancing at his tablet screen. "Before I put my name on a federal domain that sixty thousand disabled veterans, blind commuters, and working families across Virginia are going to use to request constituent casework, my brother Nate and I want to audit the raw HTML, CSS, and JavaScript source code. Please have your build team on the speakerphone drop the staging repository onto our transition VLAN share folder right now."

Bradford blinked twice, his rehearsed sales smile flickering as he exchanged an amused glance with Evan. Clearly, he assumed some twenty-two-year-old campaign intern had fed the incoming Senator a technical buzzword to sound tough.

"Well, Senator-Elect, normally congressional offices just sign the design approval form and let our certified engineers handle the code," Bradford chuckled condescendingly, leaning toward the triangular speakerphone in the center of the table. "Trevor, are you and the build team hearing this in Rosslyn? The Senator-Elect wants to see a copy of the code before she signs off. Go ahead and drop a ZIP file of the build into her transition share drive so we can check that box."

Over the speakerphone, we heard a muffled snicker from the Rosslyn engineering bullpen—the unmistakable sound of developers who thought a United States Senator wouldn't know an HTML tag from a spreadsheet macro—followed by Trevor's voice:

"Sure thing, Brad. Give me ten seconds… alright, I just dropped *prairie-senate-prod-bundle.zip* into the Dirksen transition share folder for her."

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:15 AM — "Why Is a U.S. Senator Speaking Our Exact Engineering Language?"

Katie and I opened the unbranded matte-aluminum lids of our two MagnaBook Pro laptops at the exact same second.

Without touching a mouse, I mounted the local Senate transition VLAN share in my MagnaOS terminal, unzipped *prairie-senate-prod-bundle.zip* into our shared workspace, and pushed the extracted directory straight across our local peer link to Katie's machine.

Beside me, Katie hit Command and Space, launched Quantum Code—QCode—and opened the extracted folder across two vertical editor panes.

Bradford's patronizing smile vanished the instant he saw the dark syntax-highlighted IDE panes snap open across both of our screens. "Wait… is that Quantum Code?"

Neither Katie nor I answered him, because both of us were staring at the three files Trevor had packed into the ZIP archive: *index.min.html*, *styles.min.css*, and *app.min.js*.

Every single file had been run through an aggressive production minifier. All line breaks, indentation, and whitespace had been stripped out, crushing thousands of lines of code into a single continuous horizontal wall of characters, with every JavaScript variable and function mangled into single-letter identifiers without a single source map in the directory.

Sitting in her SwiftChair, Katie's blue eyes narrowed to ice. She leaned six inches forward toward the black triangular speakerphone in the center of the mahogany table.

"Trevor," Katie said, her voice cutting through the speakerphone mesh with razor-sharp precision. "Did your build team seriously just send a United States Senator-Elect a webpack-minified production bundle with stripped whitespace, mangled single-letter AST identifiers, concatenated CSS rules, and zero source maps because you thought I wouldn't know the difference between compiled build artifacts and raw source code?"

Across the table, Bradford's jaw literally dropped open.

Over the speakerphone, the muffled background chatter in the Rosslyn engineering bullpen stopped dead. For four full seconds, the only sound coming through the speaker was stunned, ragged breathing.

"Uh… wait—who is this speaking?" Trevor stammered over the line, completely bewildered. "Brad, did the Senator-Elect bring an outside DevOps engineer from the Sergeant at Arms office into the room?"

"No, Trevor, this is Senator-Elect Katie Prairie speaking to you, and my twin brother Nate is sitting right beside me with the exact same minified garbage open in Quantum Code," Katie snapped. "I didn't ask for your minified production output. I asked for your raw, unminified source repository—the actual human-readable HTML templates, uncompiled stylesheets, and unminified JavaScript controllers before your bundler strips the tree. Drop the raw unminified repository into the VLAN folder in the next sixty seconds, or I am calling the Senate Sergeant at Arms contract officer to cancel your task order before lunch."

"Yes, ma'am—right away, Senator-Elect! Exporting the raw source branch right now!" Trevor blurted out over the speakerphone, his voice pitching up an octave as frantic keyboard clacking echoed from Rosslyn.

Across the mahogany table, a bead of sweat rolled down Bradford Vance's temple as he stared in utter disbelief at a forty-one-year-old Senator in a power wheelchair who had just dismantled his lead engineer in fluent full-stack developer shop talk.

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:25 AM — Twin Fury Over Barely Commented Code & Every WCAG Failure in the Book

Forty seconds later, a new archive—*prairie-senate-raw-src.zip*—appeared in the network share.

I extracted the raw source tree in terminal, opened *header.html*, *casework-form.html*, *styles.css*, and *nav-controller.js* across my Quantum Code workspace, and glanced over at Katie as she opened the exact same files on her MagnaBook Pro.

The longer the two of us scrolled down those unminified files, the hotter our faces burned. Within two minutes, both Katie and I were flat-out furious.

"Nate, look at *nav-controller.js* and *casework-form.html*," Katie said, her voice vibrating with the cold, surgical fury of a senior software architect who had just uncovered fraud. "There are almost no code comments in this entire repository!"

"Four thousand two hundred lines of unminified HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, and I just ran a grep across the whole source tree," I said angrily, leaning toward the speakerphone so Trevor and his entire Rosslyn team could hear every word. "You have exactly three inline comment lines in the entire project—and one of them on line eighty-four of *nav-controller.js* literally says *TODO: fix keyboard trap later* dated four years ago! There isn't a single architectural block comment at the top of your files, zero function docblocks explaining your state logic, and zero inline comments documenting your DOM event listeners. How is any developer supposed to maintain taxpayer-funded code that isn't even commented?!"

"And the reason you tried to hide it behind a minified ZIP file is even worse," Katie said, pointing her finger straight at her laptop screen while Bradford and Evan shrank back into their leather chairs across the table. "This website as written fails almost every single WCAG accessibility pointer there is!"

Over the speakerphone, Trevor tried to stammer a defense: "S-Senator-Elect, I assure you our template passed our internal visual QA check—"

"Don't you dare talk to me about a visual QA check when I am looking at your raw DOM tree line by line!" Katie fired back. "Let's start at the top of *header.html*. You have no skip-navigation link anywhere in the header, which violates WCAG 2.4.1 Bypass Blocks and forces every keyboard and switch user to tab through forty-two navigation links on every single page load. Your heading hierarchy jumps straight from an H1 banner title to an H4 subheader because your designer used heading tags for font sizing instead of semantic structure, violating WCAG 1.3.1 Info and Relationships. And look at line forty-seven of *header.html*!"

Katie read the offending markup aloud like a prosecutor reading an indictment into the federal record:

"You wrapped the entire *Help With a Federal Agency* constituent dropdown menu inside nested generic div tags with an inline *onclick* attribute—zero semantic button element, zero *aria-expanded* state, zero *aria-controls* binding, and no *tabindex*! Do

you know what that means? It means a blind veteran using a screen reader, or a quadriplegic Virginian navigating with a Sip-and-Puff switch or a keyboard Tab key, cannot even open the menu to ask their United States Senator for help with the VA!"

"And look at line one hundred twelve of *styles.css*," I added fiercely, scrolling my right-hand pane down the stylesheet. "Somebody on your team wrote a global wildcard rule setting focus outlines to *none* with an *!important* flag across the entire website! You literally stripped the visible keyboard focus ring off every link and form control on the page—a blatant violation of WCAG 2.4.7 Focus Visible and federal Section 508 law!"

"Wait until you hear what happens on *casework-form.html* at line two hundred four," Katie said grimly.

That page was the Federal Casework Privacy Act Release Form—the most important page on any Senator's website, where disabled constituents, seniors, and military families submit requests for help with delayed Social Security checks, Medicare power-wheelchair prior authorizations, and veterans' benefits.

"Instead of associating explicit HTML label elements with your form inputs using a *for* attribute, your developers just typed instructions into light-gray *placeholder* attributes colored hex 999999 on a white background—a 2.6-to-1 contrast ratio that fails WCAG 1.4.3 Contrast Minimum AND fails WCAG 3.3.2 Labels or Instructions," Katie said. "And because you stripped the labels, listen to what a blind constituent actually hears when they try to fill out your form."

Katie pressed Command and F5 on her MagnaBook Pro keyboard to turn on MagnaVoice—the built-in MagnaOS screen reader—turned her laptop speakers up to maximum volume right beside the conference speakerphone, and hit the Tab key four times.

Across the mahogany table and straight through the open speakerphone line into the Rosslyn engineering bullpen, the synthesized MagnaVoice voice echoed in the dead-silent room:

"Edit text, blank. Edit text, blank. Image, hero-banner-final-v3.jpg. Unlabeled button."

Nobody on the other side of the table or on the speakerphone dared to breathe.

Katie pressed Command and F5 to silence MagnaVoice and looked straight across the table at Bradford before addressing the speakerphone.

"S-Senator-Elect…" Trevor whispered over the speakerphone, sounding completely shell-shocked. "How on earth do you and your brother know how to audit raw unminified HTML, CSS specificity, DOM accessibility trees, and WCAG pointers like senior software engineers?"

"Because my brother Nate and I learned how to write raw HTML in seventh grade at Morrison Middle School back in 1997—which is what inspired our dad to go back to school at the Community College of Hampton Roads to earn his computer science degree," Katie said, her voice ringing with every year of our lives. "We learned Quantum Basic 6.0 alongside our dad in 2001, we attended Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville from March 2007 to March 2008 in the Web Applications Developer course where we mastered PHP, and we have spent the last eighteen years

building and maintaining production websites and desktop applications from these two wheelchairs! Did your company actually sign a federal VPAT certifying to the Senate Sergeant at Arms that this uncommented, inaccessible garbage complies with Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act, or did you just assume a Senator in a wheelchair wouldn't know how to read your source code?"

Bradford swallowed hard, wiping his forehead with a linen handkerchief. "Senator-Elect, I… we will assign a remediation sprint immediately—"

"You don't need to assign a remediation sprint, because Nate and I don't trust your team to write clean code without supervision," Katie said, her fingers already flying across her mechanical laptop keyboard in tandem with mine. "Sit quietly for twenty-five minutes while we show you how professional Web Applications Developers write and document accessible code."

For the next twenty-five minutes, while Bradford and Evan sat frozen in their suits and the entire Rosslyn engineering bullpen watched our live screen-share in humbled silence, Katie and I refactored their core templates in Quantum Code. We replaced every non-semantic div dropdown with proper semantic HTML5 nav and button elements bound to clean ARIA state toggles, restored high-contrast focus-visible rings, bound explicit label elements and 4.5-to-1 contrast tokens to every single input on the constituent casework form, and padded the top of every file and every single logic block with comprehensive architectural block comments and inline WCAG explanations so any future developer could read and maintain it.

At 10:55 AM, I committed our changes to a clean Git patch file—*wcag-508-and-documentation-fixes.diff*—and pushed it straight back into the Rosslyn staging repository.

"Merge our pull request, apply that exact commenting and WCAG 2.2 AA standard to every remaining subpage in the repository, and have the unminified branch ready for our second inspection by Monday at noon," Katie told the speakerphone as she closed the lid of her MagnaBook Pro.

By the time Katie and I unlocked our wheelchair brakes and rolled out into the Dirksen corridor toward the Capital Transit elevator, word was already ripping through every IT vendor and Senate chief of staff on Capitol Hill: *Whatever you do, never send minified code, uncommented spaghetti, or a fake accessibility report to Senator Prairie's office—she and her brother will demand your raw unminified repo, open it in Quantum Code, and debug you live on speakerphone.*

Part 2: Article IV Section 4, Hand-Delivering Her Resignation in Richmond, & The Writ of Special Election

Date: 2026-12-15 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, December 15, 2026, 2:00 PM — The Clerk's Office of the Senate of Virginia & The Dual-Office Holding Ban

"It feels strange holding this envelope in my hand after twelve years in Capitol Square, Nate," Katie said quietly as our two compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs rolled side by side down the polished black-and-white marble corridor of the Virginia State Capitol in Richmond toward the mahogany doors of the Office of the Clerk of the Senate of Virginia.

Resting across my sister's lap on top of her leather portfolio was a heavy cream-parchment letter embossed with the gold seal of the Senate of Virginia and signed in her crisp blue fountain-pen script.

Under Article IV, Section 4 of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia—as well as Code of Virginia Section 2.2-2800 and the Incompatibility Clause of Article I, Section 6 of the Constitution of the United States—no person holding any office under the United States government is permitted to hold a seat in either house of the Virginia General Assembly. Even more importantly to Katie, the 2027 Session of the Virginia General Assembly was scheduled to gavel in at noon on the second Wednesday in January—Wednesday, January 13, 2027, just ten days after her federal swearing-in in Washington.

If Katie had waited until January 3 to vacate her State Senate seat, the citizens of Virginia Beach and Chesapeake in her district would have been left with an empty chair on the floor of the Senate of Virginia during the opening weeks of the legislative session. By formally submitting her resignation today, on Tuesday, December 15, 2026, she was giving the Lieutenant Governor and the Governor of Virginia the legal window required under the Code of Virginia to immediately issue a Writ of Special Election for early January so her successor could be elected and seated on Opening Day in Richmond.

When we rolled through the tall wooden doorway into the neoclassical Clerk's Office—where white marble Ionic columns framed the floor-to-ceiling bookshelves of Virginia Acts of Assembly dating back to Thomas Jefferson's design—the gray-haired Clerk of the Senate stepped out from behind his high podium and walked straight over to the lowered, wheelchair-accessible mahogany counter that had been built during Katie's very first term in the upper chamber.

"Madam Chair," the Clerk said softly, his voice thick with genuine affection as he looked from Katie to me beside the blue Flag of the Commonwealth of Virginia. "Or I suppose in nineteen days I have to start calling you Senator Prairie of the United States Senate."

"In this building, William, you can just call me Katie," my sister smiled warmly, lifting the gold-sealed cream parchment letter from her lap and extending it across the accessible mahogany counter. "Pursuant to Article IV, Section 4 of the Constitution of Virginia, here is my formal signed letter resigning my seat in the Senate of Virginia, together with the duplicate copy for the Lieutenant Governor so the Writ of Special Election can be issued this afternoon."

With a respectful bow of his head, the Clerk accepted the parchment letter in both hands, stamped the official time and date of receipt onto the ledger copy, and handed the stamped receipt back across the counter to Katie.

“Twelve years between the House of Delegates and the Senate of Virginia, Katie,” the Clerk said, resting his hand over the signed parchment. “When you and Nate first rolled through the Bell Tower entrance in January of 2014, half the historic committee rooms in this Capitol complex didn’t even have flush thresholds or accessible turning radiuses, and nobody in Richmond thought a first-term Delegate from Virginia Beach could force a subcommittee to table its own bill with a single three-minute speech. This Capitol is a vastly fairer, more accessible house of the people because the two of you were here.”

“And we’re holding you to keeping every single ramp and every single late-night transit grant intact while we’re up in Washington, William,” Katie said, her blue eyes shining as she shook his hand across the mahogany counter.

Tuesday, December 15, 2026, 3:15 PM — One Last Roll Down the Senate Ramp & The Bus to Main Street Station

After leaving the Clerk’s Office, Katie and I took the elevator to the second floor and rolled quietly into the empty gallery aisle of the Senate of Virginia Chamber.

The afternoon December sunlight slanted through the tall arched windows across the green carpet and the forty mahogany desks of the upper chamber. Up at the front aisle, right beside the Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services chair desk that Katie had occupied since January 2020, sat the permanent, custom-milled mahogany wheelchair ramp leading up to the Clerk’s well and the dais—installed so seamlessly into the historic woodwork that future generations of Virginians visiting the Capitol would assume it had always been there.

Sitting beside my sister in the quiet chamber, I reached across our armrests and took her left hand.

“Look at that ramp, Katie,” I said softly. “First the Virginia Beach City Council chamber at the Municipal Center in 2011. Then the House of Delegates subcommittees in 2014. Then the Senate of Virginia in 2020. And last month the carpenters in Washington finished widening your aisle and building the permanent ramp on the floor of the United States Senate.”

Katie looked at the mahogany ramp in front of her old desk, then turned her head to smile at me.

“Every time we had to fight for a ramp, Nate, people in suits acted like we were asking for a personal favor,” Katie said quietly. “We weren’t building those ramps just for me. We were building them so the next kid in a SwiftChair who rides a bus to a field trip at the Virginia State Capitol—or the United States Capitol—never has to sit at the bottom of a staircase wondering if the law belongs to them too.”

Twenty minutes later, after carrying the last cardboard banker’s box from her constituent office—holding nothing more than our framed copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia and our twin blue coffee mugs—out the accessible basement entrance onto Bank Street, we didn’t call a state pool car or a limousine.

Just as we had done every winter session in Richmond for twelve years, United States Senator-Elect Katie Prairie and I rolled our two compact SwiftChairs half a block down the brick sidewalk to the regular public transit bus stop at Ninth and

Main, waited alongside the four o'clock state office clerks and hospital workers, rolled up the front bus ramp into the dual wheelchair bays, and tapped our fare cards for the seven-minute ride down the hill to Richmond Main Street Station to catch the evening ARTS train home to Norfolk.

First Train from Norfolk & Swearing In on the Constitution

Part 1: Three Business Class Tickets for Free Café Car Drinks & The Mobile Lift at Alexandria

Date: 2027-01-03 at 05:00 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 5:00 AM — Norfolk Station & Three Business Class Tickets for Free Café Car Drinks

"Make sure you keep your receipt folded in your wallet, Katie—that Business Class barcode gets the three of us unlimited free ginger ale and hot coffee out of the Café Car all the way up to Alexandria," our sixty-eight-year-old dad said with a grin at five o'clock in the morning, holding his leather garment bag in one hand as the uniformed ARTS station attendant finished cranking our second compact SwiftChair power wheelchair up the yellow mobile lift into the warm stainless-steel vestibule at Norfolk Station.

Outside on the low-level brick platform beside Harbor Park, the January predawn wind off the Elizabeth River was cold enough to turn our breath into white plumes under the station lamps. Inside the front end of the combined ARTS Business Class and Café Car, the air smelled like fresh-brewed dark roast coffee, warm baseboard heat, and polished vinyl headrests.

It was Sunday, January 3, 2027—Opening Day of the One Hundred Twentieth Congress of the United States. In exactly seven hours, at twelve o'clock noon in the Chamber of the United States Senate in Washington, D.C., my forty-one-year-old twin sister was going to raise her right hand and be sworn in as the newest United States Senator from the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Four days earlier, on Wednesday afternoon, a polite young protocol liaison from the Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms had called our transition office in Virginia Beach to ask which flight Senator-Elect Katie Prairie was taking into Reagan National Airport, or whether Capitol Police needed to stage a black SUV motorcade at the VIP circular drive outside Washington Union Station.

Katie had looked across her desk at me, smiled, and given the young man the unvarnished truth.

"Neither," my sister had told him over the speakerphone. *"My brother Nate, my dad, and I are taking the first morning ARTS Northeast Regional train out of Norfolk at five o'clock in the morning."*

Because almost nobody inside the Washington beltway bubble could imagine a newly elected United States Senator navigating rail and subway transfers in a power wheelchair without a dozen handlers, every single person in the Sergeant at Arms

office—along with two dozen national television producers who caught wind of her travel plans—had automatically assumed she meant she was riding the train all the way to the end of the line at Washington Union Station.

They didn't know our dad, and they definitely didn't know Katie and me.

Two weeks after Election Night, when Dad had sat down at his kitchen table with his reading glasses on to book our rail tickets for Swearing-In Day on his own credit card, he hadn't booked us to Washington Union Station at all. He had purchased three regular passenger Business Class tickets from Norfolk to Alexandria—station code ALX—on the first train of the morning.

And as Katie and I locked the brakes of our two compact silver-and-black SwiftChair power wheelchairs side by side in the dual accessible bays at the front of the Business Class cabin while Dad hung her pressed royal-blue Senatorial suit bag on the luggage hook, neither one of us was thinking about VIP motorcades.

"First things first before we even cross the river into Suffolk," Katie said, her blue eyes crinkling with the exact same delight she had worn at sixteen on the aft deck of the *Sunward Tropics* with her souvenir soda tumbler as she held up her paper Business Class ticket stub. "Nate, are we getting our free Café Car ginger ales right now, or are we waiting until the conductor scans our tickets?"

"The Café Car attendant just rolled the security grille up on the counter thirty feet behind us," I replied, reaching across the gap between our armrests to squeeze my twin sister's hand as the diesel locomotive gave two low horn blasts and the train glided smoothly away from the Norfolk platform into the dark winter morning. "Let's go get our free ginger ales and Dad's black coffee right now so we get our money's worth before Petersburg."

Besides the promise Katie and I had made to each other behind a locked bedroom door on New Year's Eve when we were seventeen years old, all three of us—Katie, Dad, and I—took a daily prescription maintenance medication where mixing the drug with alcohol or tobacco carried a known, lethal side effect of death. Back in Richmond, and now in Washington, where lobbyists and senior lawmakers loved to clink glasses of expensive cabernet or pass around celebratory cigars in back rooms, that warning label on our pill bottles was our favorite conversational shield: nobody at a Capitol Hill reception ever tried to push a second glass of wine or a cocktail on a Senator after she cheerfully informed them that the known side effect of mixing it with her daily medication was dying on their carpet. For the three of us, cold ginger ale and hot black coffee from the ARTS Café Car were the only celebratory drinks we would ever need.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 9:12 AM — Detraining on the Mobile Lift at Alexandria Union Station

"Next stop, Alexandria—ALX!" the conductor announced over the passenger intercom at ten minutes past nine as our Northeast Regional train slowed past the brick rowhouses and bare winter trees of Northern Virginia. "Passengers detraining at Alexandria, please step toward the vestibule doors. After Alexandria, our final stop will be Washington Union Station in approximately twenty-five minutes."

Up and down the aisle of the Business Class car, several lobbyists and congressional staffers in wool overcoats barely glanced up from their laptops, assuming every person dressed in a suit on a Sunday morning was staying aboard all the way into the cavernous concourse of Washington Union Station.

When Katie and I unlocked our wheelchair brakes, tucked our second round of complimentary Café Car paper cups into our armrest cupholders, and rolled toward the forward vestibule door with Dad walking right behind us carrying his garment bag as the train brakes hissed to a stop beside the low-level red-brick platform of Alexandria Union Station, two passengers in the front row did a sudden double-take over the rims of their coffee cups.

“Wait a second,” a woman in a camel wool coat whispered to her husband as the stainless-steel door slid open to the crisp forty-degree Virginia morning sunlight. “Isn’t that Senator-Elect Katie Prairie? Why on earth is she getting off here at Alexandria instead of riding into Union Station?”

Katie heard every word, and as she glanced back at me over her shoulder, the two of us shared a quiet, unmistakable twin grin.

There were two reasons we were getting off at Alexandria, and every single person who actually lived on the rails and buses of Virginia understood both of them by heart.

First, for two autistic forty-one-year-olds who had spent our entire lives managing sensory noise so we could stay sharp for the work that mattered, Washington Union Station was an echoing, cavernous sensory ambush—twenty tracks of screeching steel flanges under a vaulted ceiling, booming public-address announcements bouncing off marble columns, and a slow, twenty-five-minute train crawl across the Long Bridge and through the dark First Street Tunnel before you even reached the platform.

Here at Alexandria Union Station, right beneath the grassy slope of Shooter’s Hill and the stepped stone tower of the George Washington Masonic National Memorial, the 1905 Federal Revival red-brick depot was small, open-air, quiet, and calm.

Because Alexandria had a low-level red-brick platform rather than a high-level concrete deck, a uniformed ARTS station attendant was already waiting right beside the track, wheeling the yellow-and-silver portable ARTS Mobile Lift flush against the open Business Class doorway.

I rolled onto the steel platform of the mobile lift first. With a smooth hydraulic hum, the attendant lowered me three feet down from the train vestibule onto the herringbone red bricks of the Alexandria platform, where I backed clear and parked beside Dad, who had already walked down the vestibule steps onto the bricks.

Then the attendant raised the lift platform back up to the open doorway for the new junior Senator from Virginia.

Standing in the open doorway between our ARTS Business Class coach and the adjacent ARTS Café Car, the attendant held the yellow safety rail steady as Katie steered her compact SwiftChair onto the elevated metal platform, her royal-blue Senatorial blazer gleaming beneath her open navy wool winter coat. Down on the

red-brick platform, three morning commuters in winter jackets and knit caps stopped dead in their tracks, their eyes widening in disbelief as they recognized the woman descending on the hand-operated station lift.

“Morning, folks!” Katie called out warmly from the lift platform as the attendant lowered her smoothly down to the bricks beside my chair. “Beautiful morning for a train ride up from Norfolk, isn’t it?”

“Senator-Elect Prairie!” a commuter in a puffy down jacket stammered, pulling his smartphone out of his pocket with a huge grin as Katie rolled off the yellow ramp lip onto the red-brick platform right beside me. “Are you taking the train to your own swearing-in?!”

“Every single week the Senate is in session,” Katie replied cheerfully, reaching her left hand across the gap between our two wheelchairs to lace her fingers through mine while she held her plastic CapitalPass transit card ready in her right hand. “And my brother Nate and our dad wouldn’t miss the first ride for the world.”

As the ARTS train sounded its horn and pulled away northward toward the Potomac River—carrying twenty empty seats toward the television cameras and black government SUVs waiting in vain for us at Washington Union Station—Katie and I rolled side by side down the sunlit red-brick platform of Alexandria Union Station with Dad walking right beside us, leaving the railroad depot behind and following the outdoor brick pedestrian walkway over to the completely separate entrance of King Street–Old Town Metro Station.

Part 2: The Yellow Line Over the Fenwick Bridge, The Full-Chair Portrait, & Swearing In on the Constitution

Date: 2027-01-03 at 09:25 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 9:25 AM — King Street–Old Town & The Yellow Line Over the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge

“Excuse me—Senator-Elect Prairie!” a young man in a navy wool overcoat with a congressional staff ID lanyard around his neck called out as Katie and I rolled out of the platform elevator with Dad walking right beside us onto the elevated concrete island platform at King Street–Old Town Station. “If you’re heading to the Capitol for noon, don’t get on that train—that’s a Yellow Line train! The Blue Line on the other track goes straight to Capitol South without having to transfer!”

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests and laughed—the exact laugh of two people who had spent twenty-five years memorizing every route map, transfer pulse, and rail bridge from Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 15 on Military Highway to the Washington metropolitan grid.

“Sure, you can take the Blue Line straight through to Capitol South,” Katie told the young staffer warmly as the silver Capital Transit Yellow Line train glided up to the platform edge and its pneumatic doors chimed open level with the concrete sill. “If you want to take the long way all the way around through Crystal City, Rosslyn, and Foggy Bottom! We’re taking the Yellow Line straight across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge to L’Enfant Plaza and hopping the Blue Line two stops to Capitol South. Come on—you’ll beat your Blue Line train to the Hill by twelve minutes!”

Blinking in surprise as he did the mental map calculation, the staffer grinned and stepped into the Yellow Line car right behind Dad as Katie and I rolled our two SwiftChairs into the center wheelchair bays.

Nine minutes later, right after our train sped past Reagan National Airport and the Pentagon, the tunnel walls fell away and our Yellow Line car burst out into the brilliant January morning sunlight high above the Potomac River on the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge.

Through the wide glass window beside our wheelchairs, the entire skyline of the capital opened up across the sparkling water: the white marble colonnade of the Jefferson Memorial in the foreground, the towering obelisk of the Washington Monument to the left, and straight ahead on Jenkins Hill, the cast-iron dome of the United States Capitol gleaming against the clear blue winter sky.

Right inside the middle of that span over the river, Katie's phone buzzed inside her coat pocket.

She glanced at the caller ID—*Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms*—and tapped the speaker button just loud enough for Dad and me to hear over the rhythmic click of the welded rail joints beneath the bridge.

"Senator-Elect Prairie?" the protocol liaison's voice came through the speaker, breathless and slightly panicked. "Ma'am, I'm standing here with the Capitol Police detail and the press pool at Gate D inside Washington Union Station! The five o'clock ARTS train from Norfolk just pulled onto the track two minutes ago, and the conductor told us you got off the train back in Virginia! Are you alright? Do we need to send a car down the George Washington Parkway to pick you up?"

"Put your SUVs back in the garage, Marcus—we're completely fine," Katie said, her voice calm and ringing with good humor as our Yellow Line train glided off the north end of the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge and dove into the tunnel beneath Seventh Street toward L'Enfant Plaza. "Washington Union Station is way too loud and crowded for my brother and me, and the ARTS train takes twenty-five minutes just to crawl from Alexandria into the terminal. We got off on the mobile lift at Alexandria, walked over to King Street–Old Town, and rode the Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge. We're pulling into the lower level at L'Enfant Plaza right now to catch the Blue Line two stops to Capitol South—we'll see you at the First Street entrance in ten minutes!"

When she tapped the screen to end the call, our dad chuckled, shaking his head as he braced one hand on the stainless-steel grab pole beside us.

"You two just outran a Capitol Police motorcade and twenty television vans on a three-dollar CapitalPass card," Dad said proudly.

"And we're going to keep doing it for the next six years, Dad," Katie said, looking from Dad to me as the doors opened at L'Enfant Plaza and we rolled smoothly out onto the lower-level platform toward the elevator up to the Blue Line track. "When we started *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* back in 2008 and realized we couldn't even stay past five-thirty at the Virginia Beach Municipal Center for a six o'clock City Council meeting because the last Route 12 left CCHR at 5:48 PM, I promised myself I would never turn into one of those politicians who only sees Virginia through the tinted window of a town car. Every single time I visit constituents anywhere in the Commonwealth as their United States Senator—whether it's CVTA

back home in Hampton Roads, Blue Ridge Transit down at CPI in Blacksburg, or Capital Transit up here in Northern Virginia—we are riding that community's public transit system as part of the visit."

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 10:45 AM — "Nobody Crops My Powerchair Out of My Senate Portrait"

Fifteen minutes after our Blue Line train let us off at Capitol South and we rode the street elevator up to the sunny sidewalk at First and C Streets Southeast, Katie and I rolled through the bronze doors of the Russell Senate Office Building with Dad walking alongside us and headed up to the third-floor corner suite overlooking the Capitol grounds for Katie's official Senate photograph.

Inside the high-ceilinged room with its dark mahogany wainscot paneling and classical cream pilasters, the official Senate historical photographer had already positioned the United States Flag with its gold fringe to the left of the tall arched window and the deep blue Flag of the Commonwealth of Virginia to the right, framing the white dome of the Capitol in the morning light directly behind the center mark on the marble floor.

As Katie unbuttoned her heavy winter wool coat and handed it to Dad—revealing her tailored royal-blue Senatorial suit blazer with the small gold circular United States Senate pin gleaming on her left lapel—she steered her compact SwiftChair onto the tape mark between the two flags and rested her right hand naturally on her joystick controller.

Behind the studio umbrella lights, the photographer squinted through the viewfinder of his camera and immediately reached for the crank on his heavy aluminum tripod, raising the lens higher and zooming the barrel inward.

"Alright, Senator-Elect, let's bring the frame in nice and tight from the mid-chest up so we match the standard head-and-shoulders portraits down the corridor," the photographer said briskly. "If you could just fold your hands slightly higher near your lapel so the armrests don't—"

"Stop right there, please," Katie said—not unkindly, but with the unmistakable, quiet authority that had once silenced committee rooms in Richmond and bullies in the hallways of Northwood High School.

The photographer's hand froze on the zoom ring.

"Lower the tripod back down and step back six feet so the entire wheelchair is in the frame from my head down to the wheels and the footplate," Katie instructed him, sitting tall and poised between the two flags. "My twin brother Nate and I have rolled in these compact SwiftChairs from the moment we woke up until we went to bed since the third Friday of September in 2001 when we were sixteen years old. I didn't hide my wheelchair when I knocked on doors for Virginia Beach City Council, I didn't hide it in the House of Delegates or the Senate of Virginia, and nobody is cropping my powerchair out of my United States Senate portrait."

From the doorway beside Dad, I watched the photographer blink once, nod with genuine respect, lower his tripod to waist height, and step back across the marble floor until every inch of my sister's silver-and-black SwiftChair was framed proudly between the Stars and Stripes and the Seal of Virginia.

When the studio strobes flashed against the mahogany walls and Katie smiled straight into the lens with her right hand resting on her joystick controller, my throat tightened with a pride so fierce I could barely swallow.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 12:00 PM — Swearing In on the Constitution of the United States of America

At two minutes before twelve o'clock noon—after riding the subterranean United States Capitol Subway together beneath Constitution Avenue—Dad and I took our places at the front brass railing of the Senate Family Gallery directly above the floor of the United States Senate Chamber.

Looking down from the gallery bay where my wheelchair brakes were locked beside Dad's polished dress shoes, I could see the entire semicircle of one hundred mahogany desks arranged across the blue carpet below us. On the far aisle of the Democratic side, the Sergeant at Arms carpenters had already modified Senator Katie Prairie's assigned mahogany desk—widening the aisle clearance and removing the fixed chair base so her compact SwiftChair rolled seamlessly beneath the desktop.

At precisely 12:00 PM, the heavy ivory gavel came down on the marble rostrum, calling the One Hundred Twentieth Congress of the United States to order.

As the Reading Clerk began calling the Newly Elected Senators forward to the well in alphabetical groups of four—*"Ms. Prairie of Virginia…"*—Dad reached over and gripped my shoulder with a steady, calloused hand.

In the span of three heartbeats, forty-one years of our lives flashed behind my eyes: two nine-year-old twins whispering our *Journey to the Sunlit Valley* cartoon password before unlocking the front door after school; two twelve-year-olds wearing matching maroon shirts on Twins' Day when a sixth-grade boy broke my sister's heart; two sixteen-year-olds learning in Dr. Chen's exam room that the borrowed time in our legs was almost gone; two seventeen-year-olds wedging a fifty-pound power wheelchair against the inside of a locked bedroom door on New Year's Eve while we ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box to stay safe from a house full of drunks; and two twenty-three-year-olds holding a camcorder on a CVTA Route 15 bus crossing the Elizabeth River as we exposed why working people couldn't even catch a bus home from a six o'clock City Council meeting.

Down on the blue carpet of the Senate Chamber, Katie didn't need stairs. She nudged her right thumb forward on her joystick, rolled her compact SwiftChair smoothly down the newly installed permanent ramp along the chamber aisle into the well of the Senate, and raised her right hand toward the rostrum.

Fifteen minutes later, as the applause from the galleries echoed through the Capitol corridors, the elevator doors brought Dad and me down to the historic Old Senate Chamber for the individual ceremonial swearing-in with the Vice President of the United States.

Every time Katie had ever taken an oath of office back home in Virginia—first on the Virginia Beach City Council, then in the Virginia House of Delegates, and then in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond—she had famously insisted on swearing her oath on a bound copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

To my sister's clear, literal, fiercely principled mind, if the oath required you to swear to support and defend the Constitution, then your left hand belonged on the exact document you were promising to defend.

Now, as Dad and I positioned ourselves right beside her in the center of the crimson-and-gold Old Senate Chamber while the Vice President stepped up with the oath card, I held out the thick, gold-stamped navy leather volume Dad had bought for her at the National Archives gift shop that morning: *The Constitution of the United States of America*.

Holding the leather-bound Constitution steady on my lap tray at exact wheelchair height between our two chairs, I looked into my twin sister's blue eyes as she placed her left palm squarely on the gold lettering of *We the People* and raised her right hand high.

"Do you solemnly swear that you will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that you will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; that you take this obligation freely, without any mental reservation or purpose of evasion; and that you will well and faithfully discharge the duties of the office on which you are about to enter: So help you God?" the Vice President asked.

Katie's voice rang out clear, steady, and unshakeable across the historic chamber:

"I do—so help me, God!"

As the shutters of the Senate photographers clicked in a rapid burst of white light and the Vice President shook her hand—"Congratulations, Senator Prairie"—Katie turned her head toward me first.

Right there on the floor of the Old Senate Chamber, with the Constitution of the United States resting between our two compact power wheelchairs and our father's hands resting proudly on both of our shoulders, United States Senator Katie Prairie slipped her left hand across our armrests and laced her fingers tightly through mine—proving to the entire country what the two of us had known since the day we were born: twin brothers and twin sisters never leave each other behind.

Part 3: The First Invite to Cocktails, A Known Side Effect of Death, & Home to Sunset Drive

Date: 2027-01-03 at 16:30 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 4:30 PM — The First Invite to Cocktails & "A Known Side Effect of Death"

"There she is—the newest Senator from the Commonwealth of Virginia!" Senator Arthur Harrington, the silver-haired senior chairman of the Appropriations Committee, boomed warmly across the gilded chandeliers and marble fireplace of the Mansfield Room just off the Senate floor. "Katie, bring your brother and your

father over here! Waiter—three flutes of the French champagne for Senator Prairie and her family, and then we're heading downstairs to my hideaway office for twenty-year single-malt scotch and celebratory cigars on the West Front terrace!"

A tuxedoed catering steward immediately stepped between our two compact SwiftChairs with a polished silver tray balanced on his palm, lowering three crystal flutes of bubbling gold champagne toward Katie, Dad, and me.

Across the crowded reception room, half a dozen senior Senators and committee chairs raised their wine glasses and crystal tumblers, waiting for the freshman Senator from Virginia to take a flute and join the oldest social ritual on Capitol Hill.

Sitting beside my sister in my powerchair, I didn't even have to glance at her to know what both of us were remembering beneath the polite clink of Capitol crystal: the sour stench of gin on our mother's breath on the boat deck of the *Sunward Tropics* in August 2001; the bass-heavy thump of our cousin Brittany's drunken New Year's Eve party rattling the walls of our brick ranch off Military Highway on December 31, 2002; and two seventeen-year-old twins wedging a fifty-pound wheelchair frame against the inside of a locked bedroom door while we ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box, clinked two cold cans of ginger ale together at midnight, and swore we would never touch a drop of alcohol for the rest of our lives.

In a room full of powerful Washington politicians, however, a personal promise made at age seventeen was the kind of thing back-slapping colleagues always tried to talk you into breaking *"just this once."*

Fortunately for the three of us, biology and pharmacology had given Katie, Dad, and me an answer that no Senator in the United States Capitol could ever argue with.

Katie raised her left hand—calm, poised, and completely unbothered—stopping the waiter's silver tray six inches above her armrest.

"Thank you so much, Arthur, and thank you, sir, but please keep the champagne on the tray," Katie said clearly enough for the entire circle of Senators to hear. "My twin brother Nate, my father David, and I can't touch a single drop of alcohol—or go anywhere near cigar smoke or tobacco—for medical reasons."

Senator Harrington's genial smile paused mid-toast as he lowered his crystal tumbler half an inch. "Oh—nothing serious, I hope?"

"All three of us take daily prescription medication where mixing it with alcohol or tobacco has a known side effect of death," Katie replied with matter-of-fact serenity, her blue eyes steady and bright beneath the crystal chandelier.

Across the circle of velvet ropes and gilded mirrors, the silence was instantaneous.

Two committee chairs instinctively took a half-step back with their wine glasses, and Senator Harrington's eyes widened before he immediately gestured for the waiter to pull the champagne tray away.

"Good Lord—say no more, Katie!" Senator Harrington said quickly, waving a second steward over from the refreshment bar across the room. "No alcohol and no cigars anywhere near you three—I'll make sure the whip's office and the cloakroom staff know that permanently! What can we get for you, Nate, and David right now?"

“Three glasses of ice-cold ginger ale would be wonderful, Arthur,” Dad said with a warm, easy smile, resting his hand on the back of Katie’s powerchair. “That’s been the Prairie family toast for twenty-four years.”

Thirty seconds later, when the steward returned with three tall highball glasses filled with crushed ice and golden ginger ale, Senator Harrington and the surrounding Senators raised their glasses right alongside ours.

As Katie, Dad, and I clinked our three glasses of ginger ale together in the center of the United States Capitol, Katie caught my eye across our armrests with the smallest, most triumphant glint of amusement. In a single sentence, my twin sister had just permanently exempted all three of us from every late-night Washington cocktail hour, wine-soaked donor reception, and smoke-filled backroom on Capitol Hill for the next six years.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 6:15 PM — Across the Potomac & Through the King Street Tunnel to Sunset Drive

At quarter past six that evening, while the winter sky over the National Mall deepened to indigo and the other newly sworn-in Senators climbed into waiting black town cars bound for Georgetown townhouses or Capitol Hill condominiums, Katie and I rolled out of the Capitol South elevator with Dad walking right beside us, our CapitalPass cards in hand.

Riding the Blue Line two stops to L’Enfant Plaza and transferring up to the southbound Yellow Line platform took less than ten minutes. As our silver Yellow Line train glided back out onto the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge high above the dark, glass-smooth waters of the Potomac River, the illuminated white dome of the Capitol receded behind us and the lights of Alexandria rose ahead on the Virginia shore.

“How does it feel, Senator?” I asked quietly over the hum of the traction motors as the train banked south past Reagan National Airport toward Old Town. “Leaving the District behind on your very first night?”

“Like I can finally breathe,” Katie said, leaning her head back against her wheelchair headrest and letting out a long, contented sigh as the Yellow Line glided onto the elevated platform at King Street–Old Town Station. “Washington is where I work, Nate. Virginia is who we are.”

Exiting the station street elevator into the crisp thirty-eight-degree night air, Katie and I rolled past the glowing destination signs of the King Street Station bus loop—where BOLT and Capital Transit buses were idling at the sawtooth curbs—and turned west along the wide, flat concrete sidewalk of King Street with Dad walking alongside us.

Immediately ahead of us stood the heavy dark-green steel girders and white-painted concrete retaining walls of the King Street railroad underpass, carrying the elevated tracks of both Alexandria Union Station and the King Street–Old Town Metro directly over the street.

As Katie and I guided our two SwiftChairs side by side along the sidewalk beneath the short railroad bridge with Dad walking at our side and emerged into the quiet residential glow on the west side of the tunnel, Dad's two-story Alexandria house rose right on the left where Sunset Drive met the hill.

It was a classic two-story red-brick Virginia house with black louvered shutters framing the multi-pane sash windows, two manicured round boxwood shrubs flanking a white columned front portico topped with a small white Chippendale railing, and a broad green lawn bordered by a shade tree just steps from the railroad overpass. Looking straight back over my shoulder from the front walkway, I could see the illuminated canopy of King Street–Old Town Metro Station and the upper-level rail embankment of Alexandria Union Station right across the bridge.

Back home in Hampton Roads, Katie and I owned our primary residence fifty-fifty in the Kempsville section of Virginia Beach—the house where we claimed legal residency, where we were registered to vote, and where we paid our property taxes to the City of Virginia Beach. Dad, however, had owned this house on Sunset Drive long before Katie ever ran for the Virginia Beach City Council in 2010. The house was one hundred percent paid off and titled one hundred percent in Dad's name, giving Katie and me a permanent family roof in Northern Virginia whenever the Senate was in session so she could take the train into Washington for day trips and truthfully say she slept in the Commonwealth of Virginia every single night. Even better, we never had to publish a street number for reporters or curiosity-seekers—to everyone who knew us, it was simply Dad's house on Sunset Drive, tucked right on the other side of the tunnel with buses and trains at our doorstep.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 7:30 PM — The Vertical Platform Lift & Coding in Bedroom 4

"Home sweet Virginia," Dad said as he unlocked the white front door beneath the columned portico and held it open for Katie and me to roll inside over the flush threshold ramp.

When the three of us had worked with our Alexandria contractor that autumn to adapt the two-story Sunset Drive house for two full-time powerchair users, we had designed every square foot around both our accessibility needs and our privacy.

Here at the front of the first floor, directly behind the shuttered windows facing the sidewalk and the street, sat a traditional Colonial living room and dining room with a central hallway leading back to an accessible kitchen with roll-under countertops and a curbless roll-in bathroom. Anyone walking past the house on the street at night saw only warm table lamps, bookshelves, and a dining room table through the front windows.

Right alongside the central staircase in the hallway stood the engineering centerpiece that made a two-story historic brick house work for Katie and me: a quiet, enclosed through-floor residential vertical platform wheelchair lift linking the first floor directly to the second-floor landing.

After the three of us heated up bowls of chicken noodle soup and toasted sourdough bread in the kitchen for supper—and took our evening prescription tablets with three tall glasses of cold water—Katie rolled her SwiftChair to the hall lift gate and pressed the illuminated call button.

“Come on, Nate,” Katie said, grinning over her shoulder even after sixteen hours awake since our 4:00 AM alarm in Virginia Beach. “Before we turn in, we still have to push the January 3rd schema update to our shared site network—and I want to test the new build in Quantum Studio 2026 while the night ARTS train rolls past the window.”

While Dad walked up the central carpeted staircase to meet us on the upper landing, Katie and I rode the vertical platform lift one at a time up through the ceiling opening to the second-floor hallway and rolled past the three upstairs doors that completed our four-bedroom layout.

The first door on the left was Bedroom 2: officially designated as my bedroom whenever congressional staffers, plumbers, or visitors ever saw the upstairs floor plan, completely furnished with a neatly made full-sized bed, a cherrywood dresser, and a nightstand lamp—even though that bed went completely untouched every single night.

Across the hall was Bedroom 3, Dad’s upstairs bedroom with his full-sized bed and reading chair.

And at the east end of the upstairs hallway, with two wide sash windows looking directly out over the shade tree and the steel railroad bridge toward the glowing platforms of King Street–Old Town and Alexandria Union Station, was Bedroom 4: our three-desk family office.

Having already changed out of her royal-blue Senate blazer into her favorite soft navy fleece pullover, the newly sworn-in United States Senator from Virginia rolled her powerchair right up to her dual-monitor workstation beside mine, while Dad settled into his ergonomic chair at the third desk in the corner to check his Monday morning remote-work queue.

For the next two hours, the only sounds in that warm upstairs room were the familiar, rhythmic click of three mechanical keyboards, the soft hum of our desktop towers, and the occasional distant rumble of a Capital Transit Yellow Line train or an ARTS locomotive gliding across the King Street bridge outside our window.

Side by side at our desks—just as we had coded together since learning HTML in seventh grade at Morrison Middle School in 1997, studying Dad’s *Quantum Basic 6.0* textbooks with him in 2001, and mastering PHP in the Web Applications Developer course at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center from March 2007 to March 2008—Katie and I had Quantum Studio 2026, Quantum Code, and our PHP backend templates open across our monitors, maintaining and deploying updates to the network of websites and desktop applications that the two of us shared.

“Look at line two hundred fourteen in the router controller, Nate,” Katie said happily, pointing at her screen as a northbound ARTS train whistled softly across the elevated embankment beyond the glass. “Five hours ago I was holding my hand on the Constitution of the United States in the Old Senate Chamber, and right now I’m fixing a trailing array comma in PHP with my twin brother. Tell me any other Senator on Capitol Hill is having a better Sunday night than this.”

“Not a single one of them, Katie,” I laughed, compiling the build in Quantum Studio 2026 and watching the green deployment checkmarks light up across our shared server dashboard.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 10:30 PM — The Private Ground-Floor Back Bedroom Sanctuary

At ten-thirty, Dad shut down his remote-work laptop at the third desk, stood up with a gentle stretch, and kissed the top of Katie's head before resting a warm hand on my shoulder.

"Goodnight, Senator. Goodnight, Nate," Dad said softly from the doorway of Bedroom 3 across the upstairs hall. "Sleep well, you two."

"Goodnight, Dad—love you," Katie and I said together.

One after the other, my sister and I took the interior vertical platform lift back down to the quiet first floor and rolled past the darkened front living room toward the rear of the house.

Tucked into the private back corner of the ground floor—looking out only onto our high-fenced backyard garden and tall evergreens behind drawn blackout curtains—was the Master Bedroom.

Officially, on paper, this ground-floor suite was Katie's bedroom, while Bedroom 2 upstairs was mine. We had deliberately chosen this room at the very back of the ground floor so that no passerby, reporter, or neighbor walking along the front sidewalk could ever peer through a street-facing window to see two forty-one-year-old opposite-gender twins sharing a bed.

Inside our quiet back-room sanctuary, however, there were no cameras, no Senate galleries, and no outsiders who needed an explanation for why the two halves of the same soul slept safest under the same quilt.

Rolling our two compact SwiftChairs to our respective sides of the shared queen-sized bed—right beneath the framed watercolor print of two blue butterflies we had carried with us from our bedroom off Military Highway—Katie and I plugged our magnetic charger leads into our joystick ports until both battery indicators glowed steady amber in the dim light.

Moving with the practiced upper-body coordination of twenty-five years in wheelchairs, I transferred onto the right side of the queen mattress and helped steady the quilt while Katie transferred smoothly onto the left.

When she clicked off the brass bedside lamp and we pulled the warm comforter up to our chins in the dark, a late-night southbound train glided quietly over the King Street bridge just beyond the trees outside—heading south through Virginia toward Richmond and Norfolk along the exact steel rails that tied our whole life together.

Underneath the covers, United States Senator Katie Prairie reached across the center of the mattress, found my hand in the dark, and laced her fingers through mine.

"Goodnight, Nate," she whispered against the pillow.

"Goodnight, Katie," I whispered back, holding my twin sister's hand as we drifted off to sleep in our house on Sunset Drive.